

Telugu, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Telugu one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Telugu letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read నమస్కారం *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Telugu simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Telugu — famous as “the Italian of the East” for its open, vowel-final music — is one of the four literary **Dravidian** languages, a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit. Like its sister Kannada, and unlike Tamil, it borrowed *heavily* from Sanskrit; so “hello” is the Sanskrit నమస్కారం (*namaskāram*), yet “yes” and “okay” are the native అవును (*avunu*) and సరే (*sarē*). Telugu also shows the family is no monolith: where its sisters say “no” with a word from the root *il-*, Telugu goes its own way with లేదు (*lēdu*). Each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Telugu out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

Modes: 👁 eyes (6) ⇌ **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 6 lessons.

The Telugu greetings and the words that oil a first conversation — and, taught through them, how to read the Telugu script and how Telugu sits inside the Dravidian family. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once.

1.1 నమస్కారం (*namaskāram*) — “greetings”

The letters in this word

Telugu reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a” (many under a little check-mark hat, the *talakattu*). న na, మ ma, ర ra. A **vowel sign** changes it: క ka + long-ā → కా kā. A vowel-less consonant **stacks below** the next as a conjunct: స tucks under ka → స్క “ska.” And the **anusvāra** ం adds a final nasal “-m.” Read న·మ·స్·కా·ర·ం → *namaskāram*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నమస్కారం (*namaskāram*) is **Sanskrit:** *namas* (“a bow, homage”) + *kāra* (“a making,” root *kr*, “to do”), with a Telugu ending = “the making of a bow.” The same word as Hindi *namaskār* and Kannada *namaskāra*. Telugu borrowed *heavily* from Sanskrit — often called the most Sanskritised Dravidian tongue — where its sister Tamil kept the home-grown *vaṇakkam*.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Hello”	Source
Telugu	నమస్కారం <i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Kannada	<i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Malayalam	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
Tamil	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Tamil alone kept its own word.

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. Both **hello** and **goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone.

1.2 ధన్యవాదములు — “thank you”

The letters in this word

New: ధ *dha* (aspirated *d*), the conjunct న్న (*na* stacked with *ya*), then వా·ద·ము·లు. Read ధ·న్య·వా·ద·ము·లు → *dhanyavādamulu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The core is **Sanskrit**: *dhanya* (“worthy,” from *dhana*, “wealth”) + *vāda* (“a saying,” root *vad*). Telugu adds its own **plural ending -mulu**, so *dhanyavāda-mulu* = “worthy-sayings,” thanks in the plural of courtesy (also the shorter *dhanyavādālu*). Same Sanskrit stem as Hindi *dhanyavād*.

Grammar Lens

Telugu builds words by gluing endings on. *-mulu* is your first taste of Dravidian *agglutination*: meaning is stacked by suffixes on a stem, not by separate little words. Later endings mark case (“to,” “from,” “with”) the same way. In Telugu, grammar is mostly **suffixes**.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Telugu	ధన్యవాదములు <i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit stem + Telugu plural
Kannada	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit — same stem
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād</i>	Sanskrit — same stem
Tamil	<i>nanṛi</i>	native (“goodness”)
Malayalam	<i>nandi</i>	native

1.3 అవును (*avunu*) — “yes”

The letters in this word

అ is the **independent vowel** “a” (word-initial). వు is *vu*, ను is *nu* (each a consonant with the “u” sign). Read అ·వు·ను → *avunu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

అవును (*avunu*) is the everyday native “yes / it is so” — close at root to the verb of being, which is why its “no” partner *kādu* (“is not”) is its exact mirror.

Grammar Lens

Telugu’s yes/no are little **statements of being**: *avunu* (“it is [so]”) vs. *kādu* (“it is not”). A Dravidian instinct — answer by asserting or denying existence, not with a bare particle. You’ll also hear a “yes” echoed as the question’s own verb.

1.4 లేదు (*lēdu*) — “no,” where Telugu parts ways with its sisters

The letters in this word

లే is *lē* (ల *la* with the long-“ē” sign); దు is *du*. Read లే·దు → *lēdu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

లేదు (*lēdu*) means “there is not, it is absent” — native Dravidian, but on a **different root** (*lē-*) from the *il-* of Tamil and Kannada. Telugu also has కాదు (*kādu*), “it is not [that],” so it splits “no” in two: *lēdu* denies **existence** (*pustakam lēdu*, “there is no book”); *kādu* denies **identity** (*idi pustakam kādu*, “this is not a book”).

Grammar Lens

Two “no”s, existence vs. identity. English leans on one flat “no”; Telugu keeps *lēdu* (“there isn’t”) and *kādu* (“isn’t that”). Choosing between them is choosing *what* you deny — a Dravidian trait Telugu draws most sharply, and with a different root-word from its sisters.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“No / isn’t”	Note
Telugu	లేదు / కాదు <i>lēdu</i> / <i>kādu</i>	native, different root
Tamil	<i>illai</i>	native, root <i>il-</i>
Kannada	<i>illa</i>	native, root <i>il-</i>
Malayalam	<i>illa</i>	native, root <i>il-</i>
Hindi	<i>nahīm</i>	Indo-European (unrelated)

Three sisters share *il-*; Telugu alone picked *lē-* / *kā-* — the family is real, but not uniform.

1.5 సరి (*sarē*) — “okay,” the family word in Telugu dress

The letters in this word

స is *sa*; రి is *rē* (ర *ra* with the long-“ē” sign you just met on *lē*). Read స·రి → *sarē*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

సరే (*sarē*) is native Dravidian “correct, right” → “okay, agreed” — the verbal nod of Telugu. It is the same family word as Tamil and Kannada *sari*, worn to *sarē*; doubled, *sarē sarē* = “alright, alright.”

Grammar Lens

One Dravidian word, three scripts. *sari* / *sarē* is essentially one word and meaning dressed in Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu letters. Spotting a shared word change its shape but not its sense is the fastest way to feel the family — and the whole point of learning these four side by side.

1.6 Recap, and how Telugu says goodbye

Read		Meaning	Origin
నమస్కారం	<i>namaskāram</i>	hello	Sanskrit
ధన్యవాదములు	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	thank you	Sanskrit + Telugu plural
అవును	<i>avunu</i>	yes	native
లేదు	<i>lēdu</i>	no / isn’t	native (root <i>lē-</i> , not <i>il-</i>)
సరే	<i>sarē</i>	okay	native (= <i>sari</i>)

The familiar pattern — Sanskrit for the greetings, native for the everyday grammar — with Telugu’s own twist: its “no” takes a different native root from its sisters.

Why it’s said this way

The same “go and come back.” Telugu, too, avoids a bare “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is వెళ్ళి వస్తాను (*velli vastānu*), “having gone, I [will] come [back],” with the reply వెళ్ళి రండి (*velli raṇḍi*), “go, and come back” — the worldview inside Tamil’s *pōy varugirēn* and Kannada’s *hōgi baruttēne*.

Next chapter: introducing yourself — *nā pēru...* (“my name...”) — and Telugu’s *nuvvu* / *mīru* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) 👁 eyes (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 8 lessons.

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

నా పేరు అరుణ్. (*nā pēru Arun* — “My name is Arun.”)
మీ పేరు ఏమిటి? (*mī pēru ēmiṭi* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled.

2.1 పేరు (*pēru*) — “name,” the native Dravidian word

The letters in this word

ప (*pa*) + ే (the *ē*-sign) → పే (*pē*); రు (*ru*). Read పే·రు → *pēru*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పేరు (*pēru*, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian **pēr* — the *same* word as Tamil *peyar* and Malayalam *pēr*, and a cousin of Kannada *hesaru* (which softened the old *p* to *h*). It is *not* the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*). Even in Telugu — the most Sanskritised of the Dravidian tongues — the everyday word for “name” stayed home-grown.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Name”	Source
Telugu	పేరు <i>pēru</i>	native Dravidian (*pēr)
Tamil	<i>peyar</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Malayalam	<i>pēr</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Kannada	<i>hesaru</i>	Dravidian (*pesar, p→h)
Hindi	<i>nām</i>	Sanskrit (Indo-European)
English	<i>name</i>	Indo-European

2.2 నా (*nā*) — “my”

The letters in this word

న (*na*) + ా (long ā) → నా (*nā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నా (*nā*, “my”) is the possessive of నేను (*nēnu*, “I”) — native Dravidian, on the pronoun stem *nān/*yān behind Tamil *nān* and Kannada *nānu*. No Indo-European cousin: the Dravidian “I/my” is a wholly different word from the European *I/my*.

2.3 నా పేరు ... (*nā pēru ...*) — “my name is...”

నా (my) + పేరు (name) + name = **nā pēru ...** *Nā pēru Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

No word for “is.” As in Tamil and Kannada, there is *no* verb: Telugu sets “my name” beside “Arun” and lets the “is” be understood — the **zero copula** of the Dravidian family. *Nā pēru Arun* = literally “my name Arun.”

2.4 నువ్వు / మీరు (*nuvvu* / *mīru*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The letters in this word

నువ్వు (*nuvvu*); మీరు (*mīru*, మీ *mī* + రు *ru*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నువ్వు (*nuvvu*, familiar “you”) traces to Proto-Dravidian **nīn* — the same native root as Tamil *nī* and Kannada *nīnu*. మీరు (*mīru*) is the respectful/plural “you.”

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural, again. *nuvvu* (familiar) vs. *mīru* (respectful, and literally plural) — the same politeness-by-plural as Tamil *nīṅgal*, Kannada *nīvu*, and French *vous*. For a first meeting, *mīru*.

2.5 ఏమిటి (*ēmiṭi*) — “what”

The letters in this word

ఏ (independent long *ē*) + మి (*mi*) + టి (*ṭi*, retroflex) → *ēmiṭi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఏమిటి (*ēmiṭi*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem **yā-/e-* — the same Dravidian question-root as Tamil *eṇṇa* and Kannada *ēnu*, heading Telugu’s question family: *ēmiṭi* (what), *evaru* (who), *ekkaḍa* (where), *enduku* (why).

2.6 మీ పేరు ఏమిటి? (*mī pēru ēmiṭi*) — “what’s your name?”

మీ (*mī*, “your”) is the possessive of *mīru* (“you,” respectful). So మీ పేరు ఏమిటి? is literally “**your name what?**” — and again *no* “*is.*” Three words, no verb.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *Nā pēru Arun.* The familiar “your” is *nī* (from *nuvvu*): *nī pēru ēmiṭi?*

2.7 సంతోషం (*santōṣam*) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is మిమ్మల్ని కలిసినందుకు సంతోషం (*mimmalni kalisinanduku santōṣam*) — “joy at having met you.” The key word సంతోషం (*santōṣam*, “joy, gladness”) is **Sanskrit** (*sam-* + *toṣa*, “full satisfaction”), the *same* loan Kannada uses — both reach for Sanskrit where Tamil keeps its native *maḡilcci*. Telugu, the most Sanskritised of the four, does so most readily of all.

2.8 The whole exchange

Telugu		English
నా పేరు మీరా.	<i>nā pēru Mira</i>	My name is Mira.
మీ పేరు ఏమిటి?	<i>mī pēru ēmiṭi</i>	What’s your name?
నా పేరు అరుణ్.	<i>nā pēru Arun</i>	My name is Arun.
సంతోషం.	<i>santōṣam</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *pēru* (Dravidian *pēr, *not name*), *nā* (from *nēnu*, “I”), *ēmiṭi* (Dravidian question-stem) — and *santōṣam*, a Sanskrit loan for “pleased.” The Telugu habit: the **zero copula** (no “is”). Next chapter: *elā unnāru?* (“how are you?”) and answering with *bāgunnānu* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) 👁 eyes (5) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and, for the first time, a Telugu verb “to be”:

మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? (*mīru elā unnāru* — “How are you?”)
నేను బాగున్నాను, ధన్యవాదములు. (*nēnu bāgunnānu, dhanyavādamulu* —
“I’m well, thank you.”)

3.1 ఎలా (*elā*) — “how,” another of the e-questions

The letters in this word

ఎ (independent short *e*) + లా (*lā*) → ఎలా (*elā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఎలా (*elā*, “how”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative base ఎ- (*e-*) from *ēmiṭi*. Telugu gathers nearly all its questions under this **e-**: *ēmiṭi* (what), *elā* (how), *evaru* (who), *ekkaḍa* (where), *eppuḍu* (when). It is the same Dravidian question-root heading Tamil’s *eppaṭi* and Kannada’s *ēnu* — a family older than the Sanskrit words Telugu otherwise borrows so freely.

3.2 మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? — “how are you?”

The new word is ఉన్నారు (*unnāru*, “you are”): from the verb ఉండు (*uṇḍu*, “to be, exist, stay”) + the respectful-you ending *-āru*. So మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? is “you how are?”, the verb last, as in every Telugu sentence.

Grammar Lens

The verb carries “you.” The ending *-āru* already means “you (respectful),” so *māru* can be dropped: *elā unnāru?* is a whole “how are you?” To a friend: నువ్వు ఎలా ఉన్నావు? (*nuvvu elā unnāvu?* — *-āvu* for the familiar “you”). Match the “you” to the verb-ending.

3.3 నేను (*nēnu*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

The letters in this word

నే (*nē*) + ను (*nu*) → నేను (*nēnu*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నేను (*nēnu*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian **yān* / **nēn* — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *maiṃ*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the నా (*nā*, “my”) you met in Chapter 2. For all the Sanskrit Telugu borrows elsewhere, its basic pronouns stayed Dravidian to the core.

3.4 బాగా (*bāgā*) — “well,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

బా (*bā*) + గా (*gā*) → బాగా (*bāgā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

బాగా (*bāgā*, “well, nicely, very”), from బాగు (*bāgu*, “goodness”), is the everyday “well/good/very.” To answer “how are you,” fuse it with the *uṇḍu* verb: నేను బాగున్నాను (*nēnu bāgunnānu*, “I am well” — *bāgā* + *unnānu* run together).

3.5 పరవాలేదు (*paravalēdu*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పరవాలేదు literally “**there is no harm**” — *paravā* (“harm”) + లేదు (*lēdu*, “is-not”), the Chapter-1 negative. It serves as “it’s okay / no worries / you’re welcome.” The atom లేదు (*lēdu*) is where Telugu goes its own way: Tamil, Kannada, and Malayalam all say *illa(i)* for “is-not,” but **Telugu alone** uses *lēdu* — so Tamil’s “no problem” is *paravāyillai*, Telugu’s is *paravalēdu*, the same idea on each language’s own “not.”

Grammar Lens

లేదు (*lēdu*) negates existence: *ḍabbu lēdu* (“there’s no money”). It is the negative twin of ఉంది (*undi*, “there is”) and of the *uṇḍu* verb behind “how are you.” Hold *undi* / *lēdu* together — “there is” and “there is not.”

3.6 The whole exchange

Telugu	English
మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు?	How are you?
నేను బాగున్నాను, ధన్యవాదములు.	I’m well, thank you.
పరవాలేదు.	No problem / you’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *elā* (the native *e*- questions), *nēnu* (Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*), *bāgā* (“well”), and the *undi* / *lēdu* pair — “there is” and “there is not,” Telugu’s own “not” where its sisters use *illa*. Next chapter: the farewells — and Telugu, like all its family, never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) ◉ eyes (4) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

Telugu, like every Dravidian language, does not say a plain “goodbye.” It promises to return:

వెళ్ళి వస్తాను. (*velli vastānu* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

4.1 వెళ్ళు (*vellu*) — “go,” and వచ్చు (come)

The letters in this word

వె (*ve*) + ళ్ళు (*llu*, doubled retroflex శ *!*) → వెళ్ళు. Its partner వచ్చు (*vaccu*, “come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

వెళ్ళు (*vellu*, “to go”) and వచ్చు (*vaccu*, “to come”) are native Dravidian verbs. As commands they are whole words: *vellu!* (“go!”), *rā!* (“come!”). You need both, because Telugu’s goodbye is “I go, and I come back.”

4.2 వెళ్ళి వస్తాను (*velli vastānu*) — “I’ll go and come back”

వెళ్ళి (*velli*, “having gone”) + వస్తాను (*vastānu*, “I come”) — literally “**having gone, I come [back]**,” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Telugu speaker never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving.” The warm reply is వెళ్ళి రండి (*velli randi*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Telugu	<i>veḷḷi vastānu</i>
Tamil	<i>pōy varugirēṇ</i>
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varām</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)

The whole south, and beyond, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

4.3 రేపు కలుద్దాం (*rēpu kaluddām*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

రే (*rē*) + పు (*pu*) → రేపు. కలుద్దాం (*kaluddām*) = *kalu* (“meet”) + *-ddām* (“let’s”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

రేపు (*rēpu*, “tomorrow”) is native; కలు (*kalu*, “to meet, join”) gives *kaluddām* (“let’s meet”) — “tomorrow, let’s meet.” The -దాం (*-ddām*) ending is Telugu’s “let’s ...”: *veḷḷiddām* (“let’s go”), *tindām* (“let’s eat”).

4.4 మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం (*maḷḷī kaluddām*) — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం = మళ్ళీ (*maḷḷī*, “again”) + *kaluddām* (“let’s meet”). Both are native Dravidian: *maḷḷī* (from *maral*, “to return”) and *kalu* (“meet”). Where Tamil’s “we’ll meet again” reaches for the Sanskrit loan *sandi* to say “meet,” Telugu keeps the native *kalu* — the same

phrase, from different stock.

4.5 The farewells

Telugu	English
వెళ్ళి వస్తాను.	I'll go and come back. (goodbye)
వెళ్ళి రండి.	Go and come back. (the reply)
రేపు కలుద్దాం.	See you tomorrow.
మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం.	We'll meet again.

Roots banked: *vellu/vaccu* (go/come), *rēpu* (“tomorrow”), *kalu* (“meet,” native — where Tamil borrowed *sandi*), and *mallī* (“again”). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *nēnu telugu māṭlāḍatānu* — and Telugu’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) ⇐ eyes (4) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and Telugu’s sentences begin to move:

నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను. (*nēnu telugu māṭlāḍatānu* — “I speak Telugu.”)

5.1 మాట్లాడు (*māṭlāḍu*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

మా (*mā*) + ట్లా (*ṭlā*) + డు (*ḍu*) → మాట్లాడు.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

మాట్లాడు (*māṭlāḍu*, “to speak”) is native Dravidian, built on మాట (*māṭa*, “word, speech”). To say “I speak,” Telugu stacks two endings on the stem — tense then person:

māṭlāḍ- + *-t-* (present) + *-ānu* (“I”) → మాట్లాడతాను (*māṭlāḍatānu*), “I speak.”

The *-ānu* ending is “I,” so *nēnu* is rarely needed: *māṭlāḍtāḍu* (he), *māṭlāḍtundi* (she/it), *māṭlāḍtāru* (they / you-respectful).

Grammar Lens

Stem + tense + person. Every Telugu verb is built this way. And, like Tamil, Telugu marks **no gender in the first person**: *māṭḷāḍatānu* is the same for a man or a woman — unlike Hindi’s *boltā/boltī*.

5.2 నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను — “I speak Telugu”

నేను (I) + తెలుగు (*telugu*, the object) + మాట్లాడతాను (speak) — “I Telugu speak,” verb last. The name తెలుగు (*telugu*) is native, of debated origin; its vowel-rich sound and habit of ending most words in a vowel earned it the old nickname “**the Italian of the East**.” It is the tongue of the *Kāvya* poets and of some eighty million speakers today.

Grammar Lens

No gender on “I speak.” *Māṭḷāḍatānu* is the same whether a man or a woman says it — Telugu, like Tamil, marks no gender in the first or second person (only the third: *-āḍu* he, *-undi* she/it).

5.3 ఉండు (*uṇḍu*) — “to be, to stay, to live”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఉండు (*uṇḍu*, “to be, exist, stay, live”) is native Dravidian and does enormous work: it is the verb behind Chapter 3’s *unnāru* (“you are”) and *bāgunnānu* (“I’m well”), and it also means “to reside”: నేను హైదరాబాద్‌లో ఉంటాను (*nēnu Hyderābādlo uṇṭānu*, “I live in Hyderabad”). One verb covers “be,” “stay,” and “live.”

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. హైదరాబాద్‌లో (*Hyderābādlo*) = *Hyderabad* + -లో (*-lō*, “in”), glued to the *end* of the noun. Telugu uses **postpositions** (case-suffixes) where English uses prepositions: “Hyderabad-in I stay,” the verb last.

5.4 పని చేయు (*pani cēyu*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

చేయు (*cēyu*, “to do, make”) is a core native verb, and Telugu — like Hindi with *karnā* and Tamil with *sey* — builds compounds by putting a noun in front of it: పని చేయు (*pani cēyu*, “work-do” = “to work”), *vaṇṭa cēyu* (“to cook”), *sahāyaṃ cēyu* (“to help,” with a **Sanskrit** noun on the **native** *cēyu* — the two vocabularies in one verb). So “I work” is నేను పని చేస్తాను (*nēnu pani cēstānu*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + చేయు = a new verb — the exact twin of Hindi’s “noun + *karnā*” and Tamil’s “noun + *sey*.” Three languages, two of them from unrelated families, all landed on the same trick.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Telugu	English
నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను.	I speak Telugu.
నేను హైదరాబాద్‌లో ఉంటాను.	I live in Hyderabad.
నేను పని చేస్తాను.	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, the verb always last — and no gender in the first person. Roots banked: *māṭṭlāḍu* (speak ← *māṭa* “word”), *uṇḍu* (be/stay/live, with *-lō* “in” on the noun’s end), and *cēyu* (do → *pani cēyu* “to work,” the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*). From here, Telugu’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Case Endings and Dative Subjects

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (1) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I know Telugu the way Telugu itself says it — “to me Telugu comes,” with no subject and the dative -ku.

Say నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు *against నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను*, then line up the four Dravidian datives -ku · -ukku · -ge · -ikku.

6.1 -కు (-ku) — “to, for”

Your first **case ending**. English puts “to” in **front** as its own word. Telugu sticks it on the **back** — and that difference is the biggest structural fact about the language.

You’ll want to know: Adding it on

word	+ -ku	meaning
పేరు <i>pēru</i> — name	పేరుకు <i>pēruku</i>	to/for the name
పని <i>pani</i> — work	పనికి <i>paniki</i>	for work

Notice the suffix appears as -కు *-ku* or -కి *-ki* depending on the vowel before it. Same suffix, adjusted to fit — the seam still shows.

And with “I”, which changes its body first:

నేను *nēnu* (“I”) → నాకు *nāku* (“to me”)

Nēnu becomes *nā-* before the ending. Nouns don't do this; they just take the suffix.

Grammar Lens: Why this matters

	Telugu -ku	a Latin ending like -īs
pins down the case?	yes — dative, always	no — <i>-īs</i> is dative or ablative
carries number?	no — a separate suffix does	yes — plural, baked in
carries declension class?	no	yes — 1st/2nd only
can you see the seam?	yes: <i>pēru + ku</i>	no — one fused lump

Telugu **stacks**: each suffix means one thing and sits in a fixed order, so you can point at every piece of a long word. Latin **fuses** — *-īs* is case *and* plural *and* declension, indivisible, and it doesn't even settle *which* case. Telugu's *-ku* is never ambiguous.

That's what “**agglutinative**” means, and it's why Telugu words grow long without growing hard: they are **built**, not memorised.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*pēru ... pēruku*”
- “*nēnu ... nāku*” — “I” ... “to me”
- “*paniki*” — “for work,” from Ch. 5's పని
- the principle — “one suffix, one meaning, visible seam”

Before you move on

What does **-కు** mean? (“**To**” or “**for**.”) Where does it go? (**On the end** of the noun.) What is “to me”? (నాకు *nāku* — *nēnu* shrinks to *nā-* first.) Why does it sometimes appear as **-కి**? (It **adjusts to the preceding vowel** — same suffix.) How does that differ from Latin? (Latin **fuses** case+number+declension into one ending — and *-īs* doesn't even fix *which* case; Telugu's carries **one** meaning,

unambiguously, with the **seam visible**.) Next: the sentence where Telugu leaves out the subject entirely.

6.2 నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు — “I know Telugu”

Chapter 5 taught you how to say “I speak Telugu.” Now say “I **know** Telugu.” Telugu won’t let you use *nēnu* — and the verb it uses instead will surprise you.

You’ll want to know: The sentence

నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు. *nāku telugu vaccu*. literally: “**to-me** Telugu comes.”

piece

నాకు <i>nāku</i>	“to me” — the dative from the last lesson
తెలుగు <i>telugu</i>	Telugu (Ch. 5)
వచ్చు <i>vaccu</i>	“ comes ” — the very verb you learned in Ch. 4

Two things at once. **You are not the subject** — *nēnu* is gone, moved into the dative, and what’s left unmarked is *telugu*. And the verb is literally “**to come**”: a language you know is a thing that **comes to you**.

Grammar Lens: Why: things that happen *to* you

Telugu sorts experiences from actions. Speaking is something you **do**, so Ch. 5 used *nēnu*. But knowing, liking, wanting, being hungry — these **arrive** at you. Telugu marks that by putting the person in the **dative**.

English frames it as	Telugu frames it as
I know Telugu	Telugu comes to me
I like it	it is pleasing to me
I am cold	cold is to me

English keeps one fossil of exactly this: “**methinks**” — *me* is a dative, “it seems **to me**.” Telugu made it the rule.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

language	“I know [the language]”	the dative
Telugu	<i>nāku telugu vaccu</i>	-ku
Tamil	<i>enakku tamīl teriyum</i>	-ukku
Kannada	<i>nanage kannada gottu</i>	-ge
Malayalam	<i>enikku malayālam ariyām</i>	-ikku

One construction across four languages, with four suffixes that are visibly the **same suffix** — *-ku* / *-ukku* / *-ge* / *-ikku*. The Dravidian family showing its bones, just as *blanc/bianco/branco* did for Romance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*nāku telugu vaccu*”
- the contrast — “*nēnu telugu māṭlādatānu*” (I speak) ... “*nāku telugu vaccu*” (comes to me)
- the literal — “to-me Telugu comes”
- the four cousins — “*-ku · -ukku · -ge · -ikku*”

Before you move on

What does నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు literally say? (“**To-me** Telugu **comes**.”) Which verb is doing the work, and where did you meet it? (వచ్చు “to come” — Chapter 4.) What has English got that Telugu hasn’t? (A nominative “**I**” — *nēnu* is replaced by the dative *nāku*.) Why the dative? (Knowing **happens to** you.) Which English word keeps the same idea? (**Methinks**.)

6.3 త — one character, met inside words you already say

Rounded, curvy letters, most crowned with a small tick or check-mark headstroke; no continuous top line.

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: త

త — *ta*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *t*, it is **ta**.

You already say these, and every one of them has త somewhere inside it:

- సంతోషం — joy / pleased to meet you
- వెళ్ళి వస్తాను *velli vastānu* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను — I speak Telugu
- నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు *nāku telugu vaccu* — ‘I know Telugu’

Writing: త — copy what you see

Put your pen on త and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find త in the ones that have it

సంతోషం · వెళ్ళి వస్తాను · నమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* త three times, saying *ta* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find త once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — త? What sound does it carry? (*ta.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

6.4 న — one character, met inside words you already say

Rounded, curvy letters, most crowned with a small tick or check-mark headstroke; no continuous top line.

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: న

న — *na.*

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *n*, it is **na**.

You already say these, and every one of them has న somewhere inside it:

- నమస్కారం *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- ధన్యవాదములు *dhanyavādamulu* — thank you (dhanyavādamulu — “utterances of ‘worthy’”)
- అవును *avunu* — yes (avunu)
- నువ్వు / మీరు *nuvvu / mīru* — you (familiar / respectful)

Writing: న — copy what you see

Put your pen on న and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find న in the ones that have it

నమస్కారం · ధన్యవాదములు · లేదు

- *Trace it:* న three times, saying *na* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find న once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — న? What sound does it carry? (*na*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 7

Numbers One to Ten

Modes: 👁 eyes (2) ✍ pen (2) 🖐 Hands-free start: none of the 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to ten in Telugu, including the numbers that wander furthest from their Dravidian cousins.

Count ఒకటి through పది, say the two Telugu builds fresh — enimidi and tommidi — and hear seven's three fates in ēlu, ēḷu and ēḍu.

7.1 ఒకటి, రెండు, మూడు, నాలుగు, ఐదు — one to five

Four of these five are old Dravidian friends. The very first one is Telugu going its own way.

You'll want to know: The five

	numeral	word	said
1	౧	ఒకటి	<i>okaṭi</i>
2	౨	రెండు	<i>reṇḍu</i>
3	౩	మూడు	<i>mūḍu</i>
4	౪	నాలుగు	<i>nālugu</i>
5	౫	ఐదు	<i>aidu</i>

The symbols ౧ ౨ ౩ ౪ ౫ are Telugu's own digits.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

One is where Telugu leaves the family. Its cousins agree — Tamil *onru*, Kannada *ondu*, Malayalam *onnu*, all from an old *on-* — but Telugu says **okaṭi**, a different formation altogether. It’s the number to memorise fresh rather than reason across from Tamil.

From two onward, the family closes ranks again:

	Tamil	Telugu
2	<i>iraṇṭu</i>	reṇḍu
3	<i>mūnru</i>	mūḍu
4	<i>nānku</i>	nālugu
5	<i>aintu</i>	aidu

Reṇḍu has simply dropped the opening vowel of *iraṇṭu*; *mūḍu* is *mūnru* with its cluster smoothed to a single **ḍ**. Same numbers, a Telugu polish.

Script you’ll notice: A Telugu shape to notice

Nearly every Telugu word here ends in **-u** (*reṇḍu*, *mūḍu*, *nālugu*) — the language’s strong preference for open, vowel-final syllables. Even where Tamil ends hard, Telugu tends to round the word off with a vowel.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “okaṭi, reṇḍu, mūḍu, nālugu, aidu”
- the maverick — “okaṭi”, NOT the *onru*/ondu/onnu of its cousins
- the family — “iraṇṭu → reṇḍu”, the opening vowel dropped

Before you move on

Count to five in Telugu. (*Okaṭi*, *reṇḍu*, *mūḍu*, *nālugu*, *aidu*.) Which number does Telugu form unlike the rest of the family, and what do the others say? (**One** — Telugu *okaṭi* vs *onru* / *ondu* / *onnu*.) How does *reṇḍu* relate to Tamil *iraṇṭu*? (The opening vowel was dropped.) What vowel do most Telugu words here end in? (**-u**.) Next: six to ten.

7.2 ఆరు, ఏడు, ఎనిమిది, తొమ్మిది, పది — six to ten

The top of the count is where Telugu is least like its cousins — two of these you simply learn on their own.

You'll want to know: The five

	numeral	word	said
6	ఁ	ఆరు	<i>āru</i>
7	౭	ఏడు	<i>ēḍu</i>
8	౮	ఎనిమిది	<i>enimidi</i>
9	౯	తొమ్మిది	<i>tommidi</i>
10	౧౦	పది	<i>padi</i>

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Six is an easy cousin (Tamil *āru* → Telugu *āru*). **Seven** is more interesting: Tamil *ēlu* carries the rare **l** (the *zh* of *Tamil*); Kannada hardened it to **ḷ** (*ēḷu*); **Telugu went further still** and turned it into a plain **ḍ** — *ēḍu*. One inherited sound, three fates across the three scripts.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here Telugu strays furthest from its cousins —

	Tamil	Malayalam	Telugu
8	<i>eṭṭu</i>	<i>eṭṭu</i>	enimidi
9	<i>onpatu</i>	<i>onpatu</i>	tommidi

You can't reach *enimidi* and *tommidi* from Tamil by regular sound-change the way you can *reṇḍu* from *iraṇṭu*: *tommidi* is a different word entirely, and *enimidi* — though it shares the ancient *eṇ*-root behind *eṭṭu* — has drifted too far to derive. So unlike 2–7, learn these two **fresh**.

Ten comes partly back into the fold — Telugu *padi* is a worn-down relative of the *pat*- in Tamil *pattu* (and the *-patu* hiding inside *tommidi* and Tamil *onpatu*, “one-to-ten”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āru, ēḍu, enimidi, tommidi, padi”
- seven’s three fates — “Tamil ēlu, Kannada eḷu, Telugu ēḍu”
- the two you learn fresh — “enimidi, tommidi”

Before you move on

Count six to ten in Telugu. (*Āru, ēḍu, enimidi, tommidi, padi.*) What became of Tamil’s **l** (in *ēlu*) by the time it reached Telugu *ēḍu*? (It hardened all the way to **ḍ**.) Which two numbers can’t you derive from Tamil by regular correspondence? (**Eight and nine** — learn *enimidi, tommidi* fresh.) How does *padi* relate to Tamil *pattu*? (A worn-down relative of the same *pat*- “ten”.)

7.3 ు — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ు — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ు

ు — *u*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *u*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ు somewhere inside it:

- ధన్యవాదములు *dhanyavādamulu* — thank you (dhanyavādamulu — “utterances of ‘worthy’”)
- అవును *avunu* — yes (avunu)
- లేదు *lēdu* — no / there isn’t (lēdu)
- పేరు *pēru* — name

Writing: య — copy what you see

Put your pen on య and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find య in the ones that have it

ధన్యవాదములు · అవును · నమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* య three times, saying *u* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find య once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — య? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *u* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

7.4 య — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: న — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: య

య — *ya*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *y*, it is **ya**.

You already say these, and every one of them has య somewhere inside it:

- ధన్యవాదములు *dhanyavādamulu* — thank you (dhanyavādamulu — “utterances of ‘worthy’”)
- పని చేయు *pani cēyu* — to work (lit. “work-do”)

Writing: య — copy what you see

Put your pen on య and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find య in the ones that have it

ధన్యవాదములు · నమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* య three times, saying *ya* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find య once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — య? What sound does it carry? (*ya*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 8

Please

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ✍ pen (2) 🖱 Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say please in Telugu, and use the polite -aṇḍi verb ending speakers actually reach for.

Build దయచేసి out of daya (“compassion”) + cēsi (“having done”), then make the everyday polite request instead: కూర్చోండి, “please sit.”

8.1 దయచేసి (dayacēsi) — please (having done compassion)

Telugu’s “please” carries a whole small sentence inside it: “having **done** (me) a compassion.”

You’ll want to know: The word

దయచేసి = **please**, literally “**having done kindness / compassion.**” Two pieces:

- దయ (*daya*) = **compassion, kindness, grace** — from Sanskrit **daya**.
- చేసి (*cēsi*) = “**having done,**” from the verb చేయు (*cēyu*) “to do.”

So *dayacēsi* is *having done (a) kindness* — you ask by crediting the listener with the grace you hope they’ll show.

It is the twin of **Tamil** *tayavu seytu* (“do the kindness”) — both use a “do” verb — and cousins with **Kannada** *dayaviṭṭu* (“having placed compassion”). Further off, **Arabic** *min faḍlik* (“from your grace”) and **Hindi** *kṛpayā* (from *kṛpā*, “compassion”) ask in the very same spirit.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

daya + a light verb, four ways:

- Telugu దయచేసి *dayacēsi* — compassion + **having done**
- Tamil தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu* — kindness + **do**
- Kannada ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು *dayaviṭṭu* — compassion + **having placed**
- Malayalam ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — compassion + **as / having become**

Why it’s said this way

Honestly: the standalone word is somewhat **formal / emphatic**. Day-to-day, Telugu politeness rides on the **respectful command** ending -ండ్డి (-*aṇḍi*): కూర్చోండ్డి (*kūrcōṇḍi*) “please sit,” చెప్పండ్డి (*ceppaṇḍi*) “please tell me.” That -*aṇḍi* is already “please.” Put దయచేసి in front to warm it further.

Script you’ll notice: Sound & structure point

The middle syllable చే is *ca* wearing the **long-ē** sign -ే (the counterpart of the short-e sign -ె), giving *cē*; then సి is *sa* + the *i* sign (-ి). Telugu marks a vowel’s length and quality by the little sign riding on the consonant — the consonant stays put, the vowel-sign changes the tune.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “daya” — compassion — then “cēsi,” having done
- the whole word — “dayacēsi” = please
- the everyday way — the verb ending: “kūrcōṇḍi” = please sit

Before you move on

What is the Telugu word for please? (దయచేసి *dayacēsi*.) What do its pieces mean? (“**Compassion**” *daya* + “**having done**” *cēsi*.) Which cousins ask the same way? (**Tamil, Kannada, Malayalam** with *daya* — plus **Arabic** *faḍl*, **Hindi** *kṛpā*.) What carries “please” in ordinary speech? (**The respectful verb ending** -ఁడి *-aṇḍi*.)

8.2 క — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ఁ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: క

క — *ka*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *k*, it is **ka**.

You already say these, and every one of them has క somewhere inside it:

- నమస్కారం *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (*namaskāram* — “a making of a bow”)
- రేపు కలుద్దాం *rēpu kaluddām* — see you tomorrow
- మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం *maḷḷī kaluddām* — we’ll meet again
- నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు *nāku telugu vaccu* — ‘I know Telugu’

Writing: క — copy what you see

Put your pen on క and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find క in the ones that have it

నమస్కారం · రేపు కలుద్దాం · ధన్యవాదములు

- *Trace it:* క three times, saying *ka* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find క once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — క? What sound does it carry? (*ka.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

8.3 స — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: య — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: స

స — *sa.*

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *s*, it is **sa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has స somewhere inside it:

- నమస్కారం *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- సరే *sarē* — okay / alright (sarē)
- వెళ్లి వస్తాను *velli vastānu* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- దయచేసి *dayacēsi* — please (dayacēsi)

Writing: స — copy what you see

Put your pen on స and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find స in the ones that have it

సమస్కారం · సరే · ధన్యవాదములు

- *Trace it:* స three times, saying *sa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find స once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — స? What sound does it carry? (*sa*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 9

Sorry

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (2) 🖐️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise in Telugu and ask someone to forgive me, using the same respectful ending.

Say క్షమించండి, unpack it as kṣamiṅcu plus the respectful -aṇḍi already met in kūrcoṇḍi, and trace it to Sanskrit kṣamā.

9.1 క్షమించండి — sorry

You already know దయచేసి and its respectful -ండి ending (*kūrcoṇḍi*, “please sit”). Telugu’s “sorry” hands you that very ending again, riding a brand-new verb.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- క్షమా (*kṣamā*) = “**forgiveness, patience**” — the Sanskrit noun, borrowed whole.
- -ఇంచు (*-iṅcu*) = a **verb-making suffix**: *kṣamā* + *-iṅcu* → క్షమించు (*kṣamiṅcu*), “**to forgive**.” (The same pattern gives ప్రారంభించు *prārambhīṅcu*, “to begin,” from Sanskrit *prārambha*.)
- -ండి (*-aṇḍi*) = the **respectful imperative** ending — exactly the one you already met on *kūrcoṇḍi* “please sit” and *ceppaṇḍi* “please tell me.”

So క్షమించండి is “**please forgive**” — the same polite mold you already know, filled with a new verb.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- Telugu క్షమించండి *kṣamiṇcaṇḍi* — Sanskrit *kṣamā* + **-iṇcu** (verb) + **-aṇḍi** (imperative)
- Kannada ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ *kṣamisi* — Sanskrit *kṣamā* + **-isu** (verb) + **-i** (imperative)
- Malayalam ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkanaṁ* — Sanskrit *kṣama* + **-ikkuka** (verb) + **-aṇaṁ** (necessitative)
- Tamil மன்னிக்கவும் *mannikkavum* — its **own** native root *manni*, not Sanskrit at all

Why it's said this way

క్షమించండి is a real, everyday “sorry / please forgive me” — not stiffly formal — though in quick, casual exchanges Telugu speakers just as often reach for the borrowed English “**sorry.**”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kṣamā*” — the Sanskrit noun, forgiveness
- the verb — “*kṣamiṇcu*,” to forgive — then “*kṣamiṇcaṇḍi*,” please forgive
- the ending you already know — “*-aṇḍi*,” same as *kūrcōṇḍi*

Before you move on

What is క్షమించండి built from? (**Sanskrit** *kṣamā* + the verb-making suffix **-iṇcu** + the respectful ending **-aṇḍi**, which you already met on *kūrcōṇḍi*.) Which cousins also verb-ify *kṣamā*, and which doesn't? (**Kannada and Malayalam** do too; **Tamil** uses its own root *manni*.) What's the casual alternative? (**Borrowed English** “**sorry.**”)

9.2 ூ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: క — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ூ

ఁ — *a nasal, ridden on the syllable before it.*

It is a **nasal**, written as a mark rather than as a letter. It rides on the syllable before it and turns the end of it nasal.

You already say these, and every one of them has ఁ somewhere inside it:

- నమస్కారం *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- రేపు కలుద్దాం *rēpu kaluddām* — see you tomorrow
- మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం *maḷḷi kaluddām* — we'll meet again
- ఉండు *undu* — to be, to stay, to live

Writing: ఁ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ఁ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ఁ in the ones that have it

నమస్కారం · రేపు కలుద్దాం · ధన్యవాదములు

- *Trace it:* ె౦ three times, humming the nasal at the end of the syllable as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ె౦ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ె౦? What does it add to the syllable before it? (**A nasal.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

9.3 చ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: స — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: చ

చ — *ca*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *c*, it is **ca**.

You already say these, and every one of them has చ somewhere inside it:

- పని చేయు *pani cēyu* — to work (lit. “work-do”)
- నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు *nāku telugu vaccu* — ‘I know Telugu’
- దయచేసి *dayacēsi* — please (dayacēsi)
- క్షమించండి — please forgive / sorry

Writing: చ — copy what you see

Put your pen on చ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find చ in the ones that have it

సమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* చ three times, saying *ca* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find చ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — చ? What sound does it carry? (*ca.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name any day of the week in Telugu, including the Sunday that is counted rather than named for a planet.

Run Somavāram through Śanivāram, then name Sunday ఆదివారం, “the first day” — positional like Arabic’s numbered days, not planetary.

10.1 సోమవారం to ఆదివారం — Telugu’s week, with a twist on Sunday

Like Kannada, Telugu’s week runs on Sanskrit deity-names — but its Sunday breaks the “planet” pattern entirely, in a way even Kannada’s doesn’t.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Telugu	deity/planet	day
సోమవారం (<i>Somavāram</i>)	Moon (Soma)	Monday
మంగళవారం (<i>Maṅgaḷavāram</i>)	Mars (Maṅgala)	Tuesday
బుధవారం (<i>Budhavāram</i>)	Mercury (Budha)	Wednesday
గురువారం (<i>Guruvāram</i>)	Jupiter (Guru/ Bṛhaspati)	Thursday
శుక్రవారం (<i>Śukravāram</i>)	Venus (Śukra)	Friday
శనివారం (<i>Śanivāram</i>)	Saturn (Śani)	Saturday
ఆదివారం (<i>Ādivāram</i>)	— not a planet at all	Sunday

Why it's said this way

Five days match the familiar planet-deity pattern — but ఆదివారం (*Ādivāram*) doesn't name the Sun at all. ఆది (*ādi*) is Sanskrit for “**the beginning, the first**.” So Telugu's Sunday literally means “**the first day**” — a **positional** name, like Arabic's numbered weekdays, sitting right next to six planet-names that don't work that way. Even within one single week, a language can mix completely different naming strategies.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Somavāram, Maṅgaḷavāram, Budhavāram, Guruvāram, Śukravāram, Śanivāram” — Monday through Saturday
- the odd one — “Ādivāram” — not a planet, “the first day”
- the parallel — like Arabic's numbered days, one Telugu day is positional too

Before you move on

What does ఆదివారం literally mean, and is it a planet-name? (“**The first day**” — ādi “beginning” — **not** a planet-name, unlike the other six.) What ending do the other six Telugu weekdays share? (-వారం -vāram, Sanskrit “day,” each paired with a planet-deity.)

10.2 ి — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ం — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ి

ి — *no sound of its own — it takes one away.*

It is a **vowel-killer**. Every consonant in this script arrives with an *a* already inside it — that is what an abugida is. This mark takes the *a* back, leaving the bare consonant. It is how the script writes two consonants in a row.

You already say these, and every one of them has ి somewhere inside it:

- నమస్కారం *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- ధన్యవాదములు *dhanyavādamulu* — thank you (dhanyavādamulu — “utterances of ‘worthy’”)
- నువ్వు / మీరు *nuvvu / mīru* — you (familiar / respectful)
- వెళ్ళు *vellu* — to go (and వచ్చు, to come)

Writing: ి — copy what you see

Put your pen on ి and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character** or **which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real

variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ీ in the ones that have it

నమస్కారం · ధన్యవాదములు · అవును

- *Trace it:* ీ three times, and each time say what it does: **it kills the built-in a**
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ీ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ీ? What does it do to the consonant it sits on? (**Takes away the built-in a.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

10.3 ప — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: చ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ప

ప — *pa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *p*, it is **pa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ప somewhere inside it:

- పేరు *pēru* — name
- పరవాలేదు *paravālēdu* — it's okay / no problem / you're welcome

- రేపు కలుద్దాం *rēpu kaluddām* — see you tomorrow
- పని చేయు *pani cēyu* — to work (lit. “work-do”)

Writing: ప — copy what you see

Put your pen on ప and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ప in the ones that have it
పేరు · పరవాలేదు · నమస్కారం
- *Trace it:* ప three times, saying *pa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ప once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ప? What sound does it carry? (*pa.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 11

Four Core Colours

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name four basic colours in Telugu — black, white, red, and blue.

Say నలుపు, తెలుపు, ఎరుపు — Telugu’s own three — then నీలం, blue, which Telugu borrowed rather than inherited.

11.1 నలుపు, తెలుపు, ఎరుపు, నీలం — the pattern completes itself

By now the shape should feel familiar: native colors for black, white, and red — and one shared Sanskrit word for blue. Telugu confirms it a fourth time.

You’ll want to know: Three native colors

- నలుపు (*nalupu*) = “**black**” — native Dravidian.
- తెలుపు (*telupu*) = “**white**” — native Dravidian.
- ఎరుపు (*erupu*) = “**red**” — native Dravidian.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నీలం (*nīlam*) = “**blue**” — the identical Sanskrit नील (*nīla*) loan that also sits in Tamil (*nīlam*), Malayalam (*nīla*), Kannada (*nīli*), and Hindi (*nīlā*). Four Dravidian languages plus Hindi, all independently

keeping their own native black/white/red, and all reaching for the **exact same** borrowed word the moment it comes to blue.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nalupu, telupu, erupu” — black, white, red
- “nīlam” — blue, the word the four Dravidian languages and Hindi all share
- the whole pattern, one more time — native, native, native, **borrowed**

Before you move on

What’s the pattern across Tamil, Malayalam, Kannada, and Telugu’s basic colors? (**Black, white, and red are native Dravidian words in every one of them; blue is a shared Sanskrit loan (nīla) in every one of them.**)

11.2 ఓ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ఌ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ఓ

ఓ — *ra*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *r*, it is **ra**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ఓ somewhere inside it:

- నమస్కారం *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- సరే *sarē* — okay / alright (sarē)

- పేరు *pēru* — name
- నువ్వు / మీరు *nuvvu / mīru* — you (familiar / respectful)

Writing: ర — copy what you see

Put your pen on ర and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ర in the ones that have it

నమస్కారం · సరే · ధన్యవాదములు

- *Trace it:* ర three times, saying *ra* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ర once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ర? What sound does it carry? (*ra.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

11.3 ల — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ప — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ల

ల — *la*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *l*, it is **la**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ల somewhere inside it:

- ధన్యవాదములు *dhanyavādamulu* — thank you (dhanyavādamulu — “utterances of ‘worthy’”)
- లేదు *lēdu* — no / there isn’t (lēdu)
- పరవాలేదు *paravālēdu* — it’s okay / no problem / you’re welcome
- రేపు కలుద్దాం *rēpu kaluddām* — see you tomorrow

Writing: ల — copy what you see

Put your pen on ల and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ల in the ones that have it

ధన్యవాదములు · లేదు · నమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* ల three times, saying *la* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ల once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ల? What sound does it carry? (*la*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 12

Family

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my parents and my brothers and sisters in Telugu, choosing the right word for older or younger.

Name నాన్న and అమ్మ, then the four age-graded siblings అన్న · తమ్ముడు · అక్క · చెల్లి, with చెల్లి being Telugu’s own.

12.1 నాన్న, అమ్మ, and four sibling words — Telugu’s own twist

Telugu also sorts siblings by relative age. Its words for “father” and “younger sister,” though, go their own way.

You’ll want to know: Parents — one matches, one is Telugu’s own

- నాన్న (*nānna*) = “**father**” — **Telugu’s own word**, unlike Tamil/Kannada’s *appā/appa*.
- అమ్మ (*amma*) = “**mother**” — matches Tamil/Kannada’s *ammā/amma* closely.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Telugu	meaning	compare Tamil/ Kannada
అన్న (anna)	older brother	<i>aṇṇan/aṇṇa</i> — near match
తమ్ముడు (tammudu)	younger brother	<i>tambi/tamma</i> — near match
అక్క (akka)	older sister	<i>akkā/akka</i> — near match
చెల్లి (celli)	younger sister	<i>tangai/tangi</i> — Telugu's own word here

So the *system* — four words, split by relative age rather than just gender — is shared across Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu. But the exact words aren't identical everywhere: Telugu keeps its own నాన్న for father and చెల్లి for “younger sister,” even while three of the six words line up closely with its cousins.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nānna, amma” — father, mother
- “anna, tammudu” — older/younger brother
- “akka, celli” — older/younger sister — celli is Telugu's own

Before you move on

Which two Telugu family words are its own, rather than matching Tamil/Kannada? (నాన్న *nānna*, “father,” and చెల్లి *celli*, “younger sister.”) Does Telugu still split siblings by age the same way? (**Yes** — the four-way age-before-gender system is shared across the whole Dravidian family, even where the exact words differ.)

12.2 ூ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ூ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ூ

ூ — $\bar{a}$.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with $\bar{a}$. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ூ somewhere inside it:

- నమస్కారం *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- ధన్యవాదములు *dhanyavādamulu* — thank you (dhanyavādamulu — “utterances of ‘worthy’”)
- బాగా *bāgā* — well, fine — and the reply ”నేను బాగున్నాను
- పరవాలేదు *paravāḷedu* — it’s okay / no problem / you’re welcome

Writing: ூ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ூ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ூ in the ones that have it

నమస్కారం · ధన్యవాదములు · అవును

- *Trace it:* ా three times, saying *ā* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ా once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ా? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *ā* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

12.3 ె — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ె — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ె

ౌ — *e*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *e*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ె somewhere inside it:

- వెళ్ళు *vellu* — to go (and వచ్చు, to come)
- వెళ్లి వస్తాను *vellī vastānu* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు *nāku telugu vaccu* — ‘I know Telugu’
- ఒకటి రెండు మూడు నాలుగు ఐదు *okaṭi reṇḍu mūḍu nālugu aidu* — one to five

Writing: ெ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ெ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ெ in the ones that have it

వెళ్ళు · నమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* ெ three times, saying *e* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ெ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ெ? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *e* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 13

Head and Hand

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the head and the hand in Telugu.

Say తల, plainly matching its cousins, and చెయ్యి — the same Dravidian root as kai, reshaped by sound change past easy recognition.

13.1 తల, చెయ్యి — head and hand

Head matches its cousins plainly. Hand looks, at first glance, like Telugu went its own way — but look closer, and it’s the same word after all, just heavily reshaped.

You’ll want to know: The words

- తల (*tala*) = “**head**” — native Dravidian, matching Tamil *talai*, Malayalam *thala*, and Kannada *tale* closely and plainly.
- చెయ్యి (*ceyyi*) = “**hand**” — also native Dravidian, and **the very same root** as Tamil/Malayalam/Kannada’s *kai*: Proto-Dravidian *kay-*. Telugu’s own regular sound change turned that ancient **k-** into **c-**, and reshaped the rest of the word alongside it — so *ceyyi* only *looks* unrelated to *kai*. It’s a cognate in disguise, not a different word.

So all four Dravidian languages actually **agree** on both “head” and “hand” at the root level — Telugu’s hand-word has simply drifted further in sound than its cousins have, thanks to a sound change that reshaped many Telugu words the same way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tala” — head, matching its cousins plainly
- “ceyyi” — hand, the SAME root as kai, reshaped by sound change
- the lesson — looks different, is actually the same word

Before you move on

Does Telugu’s word for “head” match its cousins? (**Yes** — *tala*, like Tamil/Malayalam/Kannada.) Is its word for “hand,” *ceyyi*, truly a different word from *kai*? (**No** — it’s the **same Proto-Dravidian root** *kay-*, reshaped by Telugu’s own regular *k*→*c* sound change — a cognate in disguise, not an unrelated word.)

13.2 ీ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ీ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ీ

ీ — *i*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *i*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ీ somewhere inside it:

- ఏమిటి *ēmiṭi* — what
- వెళ్లి వస్తాను *veḷḷi vastānu* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- పని చేయు *pani cēyu* — to work (lit. “work-do”)
- ఒకటి రెండు మూడు నాలుగు ఐదు *okaṭi reṇḍu mūḍu nālugu aidu* — one to five

Writing: ీ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ీ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ీ in the ones that have it
ఏమిటి · వెళ్ళి వస్తాను · నమస్కారం
- *Trace it:* ీ three times, saying *i* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ీ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ీ? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *i* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

13.3 డ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ె — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: డ

డ — *da*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *d*, it is **da**.

You already say these, and every one of them has డ somewhere inside it:

- ధన్యవాదములు *dhanyavādamulu* — thank you (dhanyavādamulu — “utterances of ‘worthy’”)
- లేదు *lēdu* — no / there isn’t (lēdu)
- పరవాలేదు *paravālēdu* — it’s okay / no problem / you’re welcome
- రేపు కలుద్దాం *rēpu kaluddām* — see you tomorrow

Writing: డ — copy what you see

Put your pen on డ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find డ in the ones that have it

ధన్యవాదములు · లేదు · నమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* డ three times, saying *da* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find డ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — డ? What sound does it carry? (*da.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 14

Seasons

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) ✍ pen (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the four seasons in Telugu, including the rains that anchor the year.

Say వేసవి (*cousin of Kannada's bēṣige*), వానాకాలం and శీతాకాలం from native roots, then the doubly-Sanskrit వసంత ఋతువు.

14.1 వసంత ఋతువు, వేసవి, వానాకాలం, శీతాకాలం — the pattern completes itself

Telugu closes out the Dravidian season words the same way Kannada did: native words for summer/rain/cold, and a spring-word borrowed twice over from Sanskrit.

You'll want to know: The words

Telugu	meaning	source
వసంత ఋతువు (<i>vasanta ṛtuvu</i>)	“spring”	both <i>vasanta</i> and ఋతువు <i>ṛtuvu</i> (“season”) are Sanskrit, like Kannada’s pair
వేసవి (<i>vēsavi</i>)	“summer”	native Dravidian — cousin of Kannada’s <i>bēsige</i>
వానాకాలం (<i>vānākālam</i>)	“rainy season”	వాన <i>vāna</i> (“rain,” native) + <i>kālam</i> (“time,” itself Sanskrit-derived but long assimilated)
శీతాకాలం (<i>śītākālam</i>)	“winter/cold season”	<i>śīta</i> (“cold”) leans Sanskrit-flavored here, unlike Tamil/ Kannada’s fully native cold-words

Why it’s said this way

Telugu’s *vēsavi* and Kannada’s *bēsige* are close enough in shape to be genuine cousins — the same native Dravidian summer-word wearing two languages’ sound changes. And once again, it’s వానాకాలం (*vānākālam*, the rains) that actually organizes Andhra/Telangana’s agricultural year, not a clean four-way Western split — the same honest point its neighbours make.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vēsavi” — summer, cousin of Kannada’s *bēsige*
- “vānākālam” — the rains, the real central season
- “śītākālam” — the cold season
- the double Sanskrit loan — “vasanta ṛtuvu,” like Kannada

Before you move on

What's the relationship between Telugu's *vēsavi* and Kannada's *bēsige*? (**Cousins** — the same native Dravidian summer-word.) Which Dravidian languages borrow BOTH halves of their spring-word from Sanskrit (the season-name AND the word for “season” itself)? (**Kannada and Telugu** — *vasanta ṛtu(vu)* — unlike Tamil/Malayalam's single *vasantham* loan plus the long-assimilated *kaalam*.)

14.2 వ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ధ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: వ

వ — *va*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *v*, it is **va**.

You already say these, and every one of them has వ somewhere inside it:

- ధన్యవాదములు *dhanyavādamulu* — thank you (dhanyavādamulu — “utterances of ‘worthy’”)
- అవును *avunu* — yes (avunu)
- నువ్వు / మీరు *nuvvu / mīru* — you (familiar / respectful)
- పరవాలేదు *paravālēdu* — it's okay / no problem / you're welcome

Writing: వ — copy what you see

Put your pen on వ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find వ in the ones that have it

ధన్యవాదములు · అవును · నమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* వ three times, saying *va* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find వ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — వ? What sound does it carry? (*va*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 15

Water and Rice

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for water in Telugu and tell raw rice apart from cooked rice.

Say నీళ్లు — matching Tamil and Kannada — then separate బియ్యం, Telugu’s own word for raw rice, from అన్నం, the cooked rice on the plate.

15.1 నీళ్లు, బియ్యం, అన్నం — water and rice

Water closes out 3-against-1 against Malayalam. Rice, though, turns out to have its own twist here.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

నీళ్లు (*nīḷḷu*) = “**water**” — matching Tamil’s *nīr* and Kannada’s *nīru*. Malayalam’s *vellam* is the odd one out among all four Dravidian languages for water, not Telugu.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- బియ్యం (*biyyam*) = “**rice**” (raw grain) — **Telugu’s own word**, unlike the shared *ari/arisi/akki* found in Malayalam, Tamil, and Kannada.
- అన్నం (*annam*) = “**cooked rice**” (the meal) — matching Kannada’s *anna* closely, both likely Sanskrit-influenced.

So the pattern flips between water and rice: for **water**, Telugu joins the majority (Tamil/Kannada) against Malayalam; for **raw rice**, Telugu is itself the odd one out against the other three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nīḷḷu” — water, matching Tamil/Kannada
- “biyyam” — raw rice, Telugu’s own word
- “annam” — cooked rice, matching Kannada’s anna

Before you move on

Which language is the odd one out for water, and which for raw rice? (**Malayalam** is the odd one out for water (*vellam*); **Telugu** is the odd one out for raw rice (*biyyam*, unlike the shared *ari/arisi/akki* elsewhere).)

15.2 గ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: వ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: గ

గ — *ga*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *g*, it is **ga**.

You already say these, and every one of them has గ somewhere inside it:

- బాగా *bāgā* — well, fine — and the reply ”నేను బాగున్నాను
- నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను — I speak Telugu
- నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు *nāku telugu vaccu* — ‘I know Telugu’

- ఒకటి రెండు మూడు నాలుగు ఐదు *okaṭi reṇḍu mūḍu nālugu aidu* — one to five

Writing: గ — copy what you see

Put your pen on గ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find గ in the ones that have it
- బాగా · నమస్కారం
- *Trace it:* గ three times, saying *ga* as you finish each one
 - *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find గ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — గ? What sound does it carry? (*ga*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 16

The Traditional Months

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the twelve traditional Telugu months and say when Ugadi, the new year, falls.

Recite Caitrami through Phālgunāmi, place Ugadi at Chaitra Śuddha Pādyaṃi, and note the family split: Telugu and Kannada share Hindi's calendar, Tamil and Malayalam do not.

16.1 చైత్రం to ఫాల్గుణం — completing the split

The pattern across all four Dravidian languages is now complete: Telugu, like Kannada, shares its calendar with Hindi rather than building its own.

You'll want to know: The twelve months

The year runs in three four-month groups:

- చైత్రం, వైశాఖం, జ్యేష్ఠం, ఆషాఢం — *Caitrami, Vaiśākhami, Jyēṣṭhami, Āṣāḍhami*.
- శ్రావణం, భాద్రపదం, ఆశ్వయుజం, కార్తీకం — *Śrāvaṇami, Bhādrapadamī, Āśvayujami, Kārtikamī*.
- మార్గశిరం, పుష్యం, మాఘం, ఫాల్గుణం — *Mārgaśīrami, Puṣyamī, Māghamī, Phālgunāmi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

This closes out a genuine, clean split across the four Dravidian languages: **Tamil** and **Malayalam** each built their **own** solar calendar (nakshatra-named and zodiac-named, respectively) — while **Kannada** and **Telugu** instead share the **same pan-Indian Sanskritic lunisolar calendar** as Hindi’s Vikram Samvat. Telugu’s New Year, **Ugadi**, falls on the very same day as Kannada’s — *Chaitra Śuddha Pādyami*, the first day of Chaitra’s bright fortnight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “Caitraṁ, Vaiśākhaṁ, Jyēṣṭhaṁ, Āṣāḍhaṁ, Śrāvaṇaṁ, Bhādrapadaṁ, Āśvayujaṁ, Kārtikaṁ, Mārgaśiraṁ, Pūṣyaṁ, Māghaṁ, Phālgunaṁ”
- “Ugadi — Chaitra Śuddha Pādyami”
- the whole family split — Tamil/Malayalam their own; Kannada/Telugu shared with Hindi

Before you move on

How does the four-language Dravidian calendar picture split? (**Tamil and Malayalam** each have their **own** solar calendar; **Kannada and Telugu** share the **same pan-Indian lunisolar calendar** as Hindi.) What is Telugu’s New Year, and when does it fall? (**Ugadi**, on *Chaitra Śuddha Pādyami* — the same day as Kannada’s Ugadi.)

16.2 ँ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ँ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ీ

ీ — ī.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with ī. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ీ somewhere inside it:

- నువ్వు / మీరు *nuvvu* / *mīru* — you (familiar / respectful)
- మీ పేరు ఏమిటి? — what's your name?
- మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? — how are you? (respectful)
- మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం *maḷḷī kaluddām* — we'll meet again

Writing: ీ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ీ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ీ in the ones that have it

నమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* ీ three times, saying ī as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ీ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ీ? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts ī on;**

takes the built-in *a* off.) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say noon and midnight in Telugu and explain why one is “middle” and the other “half.”

Say మధ్యాహ్నం and అర్ధరాత్రి, then separate madhya (“middle”) from ardha (“half”) — two different Sanskrit roots where Kannada uses one.

17.1 మధ్యాహ్నం, అర్ధరాత్రి — the same noon word, a different midnight word

Telugu and Kannada share the exact same Sanskrit word for noon — but then quietly part ways on midnight.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

మధ్యాహ్నం (*madhyāhnam*) = “**noon, midday**” — the same Sanskrit *tatsama* compound as Kannada’s *madhyāhna*: మధ్య (*madhya*, “middle”) + అహ్న (*ahna*, “day”), plus Telugu’s own -ం (*anusvāra*) ending. Same root, same meaning, same everyday register in both languages.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

అర్ధరాత్రి (*ardharātri*) = “**midnight**” — but here Telugu reaches for a **different** Sanskrit root: అర్ధ (*ardha*, “half”), not *madhya* (“middle”). Paired with రాత్రి (*rātri*, “night”), it literally means “**half-night**” —

structurally the same shape as Hindi’s colloquial *ādhī rāt* (“half night”) and Latin’s transparent *media nox* pattern, but built from Sanskrit’s own dedicated “half” word rather than “middle.”

Grammar Lens: Be honest: two different “middle-ish” ideas, side by side

Don’t assume *madhya* and *ardha* are the same word wearing different clothes — they’re genuinely **separate Sanskrit roots** (“middle” vs. “half”) that happen to land on the same meaning here, the way English “midday” and “half the day gone” would both point at noon without sharing a root. Telugu’s noon word keeps Kannada’s “middle” logic; its midnight word switches to “half” logic instead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “madhyāhnam” — noon, same root as Kannada
- “ardharātri” — midnight, literally “half-night”
- the contrast — “madhya” (middle) for noon, “ardha” (half) for midnight — two different Sanskrit roots

Before you move on

Does Telugu’s noon word match Kannada’s? (**Yes** — both *madhyāhna(m)*, from *madhya*, “middle.”) Does Telugu’s midnight word use the same root? (**No** — *ardharātri* uses **ardha**, “half,” a different Sanskrit root.) What does *ardharātri* literally mean? (“**Half-night**” — the same shape as Hindi’s *ādhī rāt*.)

17.2 ण — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ण — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ే

ే — ē.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with ē. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ే somewhere inside it:

- లేదు *lēdu* — no / there isn't (lēdu)
- సరే *sarē* — okay / alright (sarē)
- పేరు *pēru* — name
- నేను *nēnu* — I

Writing: ే — copy what you see

Put your pen on ే and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ే in the ones that have it
లేదు · సరే · నమస్కారం
- *Trace it:* ే three times, saying ē as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ే once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ే? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts ē on; takes the built-in a off.**) Name one word you already say that

contains it.

Chapter 18

Telling Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell someone the time on the hour in Telugu, in the singular and the plural.

Say గంట — *hour*, and also “bell” — then ఒక గంట for one o’clock and రెండు గంటలు for two, taking the plural -lu.

18.1 గంట — matching Kannada and Hindi’s “bell” word exactly

Telugu completes a clean three-way match: Hindi, Kannada, and now Telugu all use the same Sanskrit “bell” word for “hour.”

You’ll want to know: గంట — bell AND hour, a third time

గంట (*ganṭa*) = “hour” — and, exactly like Hindi’s *ghaṇṭā* and Kannada’s *gaṇṭe*, it means “bell, clapper” just as commonly, from the same Sanskrit घण्टा (*ghaṇṭā*). Same word, same bell-strikes-the-hour logic, three languages in a row.

Why it’s said this way

So on this concept, the split isn’t “Hindi vs. all four Dravidian languages” — **Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu** all share the Sanskrit *ghaṇṭā* (“bell”) root. **Tamil** most likely goes its own way with a native Dravidian word instead (though even specialists don’t call this fully settled). **Malayalam** is the genuinely surprising one: its cognate word,

mani, is ALSO Sanskrit-derived per its own dictionaries — just from a **different** Sanskrit word, *maṇi* (“gem”), not *ghaṇṭā*. So three of these four languages likely trace their hour-word to Sanskrit, just not all to the *same* Sanskrit word — worth remembering that a Sanskrit/native split isn’t fixed per language, and isn’t always a clean binary either.

Grammar Lens: telling the time

ఒక గంట. — “One o’clock.” (*oka gaṇṭa*, “one hour/bell”)
 రెండు గంటలు. — “Two o’clock.” (*reṇḍu gaṇṭalu* — *gaṇṭa* takes its plural form, *gaṇṭalu*, once the count passes one)

Notice Telugu’s *gaṇṭa* pluralizes to *gaṇṭalu* for “two o’clock” onward — a small grammatical wrinkle Kannada’s *gaṇṭe* didn’t show you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gaṇṭa” — hour, also “bell”
- “oka gaṇṭa” — one o’clock
- “reṇḍu gaṇṭalu” — two o’clock, plural *gaṇṭalu*

Before you move on

What Sanskrit word do గంట, Kannada’s *gaṇṭe*, and Hindi’s *ghaṇṭā* all share? (घण्टा, *ghaṇṭā*, “bell.”) Which Dravidian language most likely does NOT use this Sanskrit word for “hour”? (**Tamil** — most likely a native Dravidian word instead.) Does Malayalam’s cognate word skip Sanskrit entirely too? (**No** — it’s Sanskrit-derived too, per its own dictionaries, just from a *different* Sanskrit word, *maṇi*, “gem.”) What happens to *gaṇṭa* for “two o’clock”? (It **pluralizes** to *gaṇṭalu*.)

18.2 ళ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ఴ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: శ

శ — *la*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *l*, it is **la**.

You already say these, and every one of them has శ somewhere inside it:

- వెళ్ళు *vellu* — to go (and వచ్చు, to come)
- వెళ్ళి వస్తాను *velli vastānu* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం *malli kaluddām* — we’ll meet again
- సోమవారం మంగళవారం బుధవారం గురువారం శుక్రవారం శనివారం ఆదివారం
— the seven weekdays

Writing: శ — copy what you see

Put your pen on శ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find శ in the ones that have it

వెళ్ళు · నమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* శ three times, saying *la* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find శ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — *ǵ*? What sound does it carry? (*!a.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone how old they are in Telugu and give my own age in return.

Ask నీ వయసెంత? and answer నా వయసు ఇరవై — a complete verbless exchange about age.

19.1 నీ వయసెంత? — matching Kannada's simple possessive exactly

Telugu matches Kannada closely here — same Sanskrit word, same verbless grammar, just fused together by ordinary Telugu vowel sandhi.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

వయస్సు (*vayasu*) = “age” — the exact same Sanskrit वयस् (*vayas*, “age, vigor, strength,” PIE cousin of Latin *vīs*) that Kannada also carries.

Grammar Lens: fused by sandhi, still verbless

నీ వయసెంత? — “How old are you?” — literally “**your age how-much?**” (*nī vayas-enta?* — from *nī vayasu* + *enta*, “how much,” fused by regular vowel sandhi into *vayasenta*.)
నా వయస్సు ఇరవై. — “I am twenty years old.” — literally “**my age [is] twenty.**” (*nā vayasu iravai.*)

Same shape as Kannada: a plain possessive (“your/my age”) sitting next to the number, **no verb at all**. The only wrinkle is surface-level: everyday spoken Telugu often **fuses** *vayasu* + *enta* into one word, *vayasenta*, the same kind of vowel sandhi you’d see fusing any two Telugu words in fast speech — the underlying grammar is identical to Kannada’s, just written closer together.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vayasu” — age
- “nī vayasenta?” — how old are you?
- “nā vayasu iravai” — I am twenty, “my age [is] twenty”

Before you move on

Is Telugu’s వయస్సు the same Sanskrit word as Kannada’s *vayassu*? (**Yes** — both from *vayas*, PIE cousin of Latin *vīs*.) What happens to *vayasu* + *enta* in “nī vayasenta?”? (They **fuse** by ordinary vowel sandhi.) Does Telugu use a verb to state age, like Kannada? (**No** — same verbless possessive shape.)

19.2 ఉ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ళ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ఉ

ఉ — *u*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape the vowel *u* takes when a word begins with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

You already say these, and every one of them has ఉ somewhere inside it:

- మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? — how are you? (respectful)
- ఉండు *undu* — to be, to stay, to live

Writing: ఉ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ఉ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ఉ in the ones that have it

ఉండు · నమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* ఉ three times, saying *u* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ఉ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ఉ? What sound does it carry? (*u*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 20

Numbers 11–20 and Weather

Modes: ☞ voice (2) ✍ pen (1) ☞ Hands-free start: first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what the weather is doing in Telugu and count past ten up to twenty.

Say వాతావరణం — a pure Sanskrit *vāta + āvaraṇa*, “the covering of air” — and report the weather with వర్షం పడుతోంది, “rain is falling.”

20.1 పదకొండు, ఇరవై — the same pattern, worn down one step further

You just watched Kannada’s twenty split cleanly into “two” + “ten.” Telugu most likely comes from the exact same pattern — but centuries of extra erosion have worn it past the point of being visible today.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Telugu’s teens echo పది (*padi*, “ten”) plus each digit — పదకొండు (*padakonḍu*, 11), పన్నెండు (*pannenḍu*, 12), and onward through పందొమ్మిది (*paṇḍommidi*, 19) — the same “digit + ten-echo” compounding Kannada builds.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఇరవై (*iravai*, “twenty”) most likely continues the **same** pan-Dravidian pattern as Kannada’s *ippattu* — an old ***iru-/*renḍu** (“two”) root fused with an old “ten” root — but here’s the honest difference:

centuries of sound change have worn *iravai* down far enough that it no longer visibly splits into “two” and “ten” on the surface, the way Kannada’s *ippattu* still does today. Telugu’s own word for “two,” రెండు (*renḍu*), doesn’t obviously show up inside *iravai* anymore — treat this as the most likely comparative-Dravidian account rather than a transparent, easily re-derivable compound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “padakoṇḍu, pannoṇḍu” — 11, 12
- “padi” — ten
- “iravai” — twenty, most likely the same “two-tens” idea as Kannada, just worn down further

Before you move on

How are Telugu’s teens built? (పది (ten) + a digit, compounded.) Does ఇరవై visibly split into “two” + “ten” today, the way Kannada’s *ippattu* does? (No — it most likely continues the same pan-Dravidian pattern, but erosion has worn away the visible split.) What’s Telugu’s word for “two”? (రెండు, *renḍu*.)

20.2 వాతావరణం — “the covering of air,” pure Sanskrit this time

Kannada’s weather word mixed a Persian loan with a Sanskrit one. Telugu’s is different again — a single, unmixed Sanskrit compound.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

వాతావరణం (*vātāvaraṇam*) = “weather, atmosphere” — built entirely from Sanskrit:

- వాత (*vāta*, “wind, air”) — the same Sanskrit root behind వాయువు (*vāyuvu*, “wind,” and the wind-god Vāyu).

- ఆవరణ (*āvaraṇa*, “covering, layer, enclosure”).

So *vātāvaraṇam* literally means “**the covering of air**” — the layer of air surrounding everything, i.e., the atmosphere/weather. Unlike Kannada’s *havāmāna* (Persian *hava* + Sanskrit *māna*), **both** pieces here are Sanskrit — no Perso-Arabic loan involved at all.

Grammar Lens: వర్షం పడుతోంది — “rain is falling”

వర్షం పడుతోంది. — “It’s raining.” — literally “**rain is falling**.” (*varṣaṇi paḍutōndi*.) — వర్షం (*varṣaṇi*, “rain”) is the same Sanskrit root, *varṣā*, you’ll see again in the Dravidian arc.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*vātāvaraṇam*” — weather, “the covering of air”
- “*vāta*” — wind/air, “*āvaraṇa*” — covering
- “*varṣaṇi paḍutōndi*” — it’s raining, “rain is falling”

Before you move on

What are the two Sanskrit pieces of వాతావరణం, and what does the whole word literally mean? (వాత, “air,” + ఆవరణ, “covering” — “**the covering of air**.”) Is either piece a Persian/Arabic loan, like part of Kannada’s word? (**No** — both pieces are Sanskrit.) What word does Telugu use for “rain”? (వర్షం, *varṣaṇi*.)

20.3 డ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: డ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: డ

డ — *ḍa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ḍ*, it is **ḍa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has డ somewhere inside it:

- మాట్లాడు *māṭlāḍu* — to speak
- ఉండు *uṇḍu* — to be, to stay, to live
- ఒకటి రెండు మూడు నాలుగు ఐదు *okaṭi reṇḍu mūḍu nālugu aidu* — one to five
- పదకొండు — ఇరవై *padakoṇḍu — iravai* — 11-20 — additive “ten-echo” compounds for the teens; ఇరవై

Writing: డ — copy what you see

Put your pen on డ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find డ in the ones that have it

మాట్లాడు · ఉండు · నమస్కారం

- *Trace it:* డ three times, saying *ḍa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find డ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — *ǣ*? What sound does it carry? (*ǣa*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a dog and a cat in Telugu.

Say కుక్క, which genuinely breaks from the family’s shared naayi root, and పిల్లి, most likely the Dravidian source behind Hindi’s billī.

21.1 కుక్క, పిల్లి — the odd one out, and the word that most likely closes the loop

Kannada just gave you a rock-solid native dog-word. Telugu breaks from that pattern — but its cat-word may be the single most important word in this whole arc.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

కుక్క (*kukka*, “dog”) does **not** clearly continue the same నాయి-family root shared by Kannada, Malayalam, and Tamil. Its origin is honestly debated: some linguists propose it’s **onomatopoeic**, imitating the sound of a bark; others propose a borrowing from **Sanskrit** कुक्कुर (*kukkura*, itself a similarly-shaped word for dog). Neither is settled — but either way, Telugu’s everyday dog-word genuinely doesn’t match its closest cousins.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పిల్లి (*pilli*, “cat”) is a real, documented **Proto-Dravidian** root, ***pillV** — with cognates surviving as **rarer**, **alternate** words for cat

in both Tamil and Kannada. Here’s why this word matters for the **whole** arc: Sanskrit’s word for cat, बिडाल (*biḍāla*) — the word behind Hindi’s बिल्ली (*billī*), which you met as “most likely” borrowed from Dravidian, without a confirmed specific source — most likely traces back to **this exact root**. So Telugu’s everyday word for “cat” is most likely the closest living relative of the very word Sanskrit borrowed, tying together Latin’s *cattus*/Arabic’s *qitt* story on one side and Hindi’s *billī* story on the other, all in one word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kukka” — dog, genuinely different from its Dravidian cousins
- “pilli” — cat, most likely the source behind Hindi’s *billī*

Before you move on

Does కుక్క continue the same root as Kannada’s *nāyī*? (**No** — genuinely different, debated between onomatopoeia and a Sanskrit loan.) What is పిల్లి most likely the source of? (**Sanskrit’s** बिडाल, *biḍāla* — and so Hindi’s बिल्ली, *billī*.)

21.2 ఎ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: డ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ఎ

ఎ — *e*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape the vowel *e* takes when a word begins with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

You already say these, and every one of them has ఎ somewhere inside it:

- ఎలా — how
- మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు? — how are you? (respectful)
- ఆరు ఏడు ఎనిమిది తొమ్మిది పది — six to ten
- నలుపు తెలుపు ఎరుపు నీలం — black, white, red, blue

Writing: ఎ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ఎ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ఎ in the ones that have it
- ఎలా · నమస్కారం
- *Trace it:* ఎ three times, saying *e* as you finish each one
 - *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ఎ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ఎ? What sound does it carry? (*e*.) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name green and yellow in Telugu, on top of the four colours I already had.

*Say పచ్చ and పసుపు and show they are doublets of one Proto-Dravidian *pac- root — where Kannada’s yellow broke away as a Sanskrit loan.*

22.1 పచ్చ, పసుపు — two colors, one Dravidian root

In Kannada, green stayed native but yellow got borrowed from Sanskrit. Telugu tells a tighter story: its green word and its yellow word turn out to be **doublets of the same root**, wearing two different faces.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పచ్చ (pacca, “green”) comes from **Proto-Dravidian *pac-** — the same root already behind Tamil’s பச்சை (paccai) and Kannada’s ಹಸಿರು (hasiru, via Old Kannada pasir). No surprise here; this is the same pan-Dravidian green family from the last lesson.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

పసుపు (pasupu, “yellow, turmeric”) is, remarkably, **also** a direct descendant of that **same** Proto-Dravidian ***pac-** root — a true **doublet** of pacca itself, not a separate borrowing the way Kannada’s

haladi was. Tamil even keeps a matching cognate, பசுப்பு (*pacuppu*), sitting alongside its own *paccai*. So where Kannada split green and yellow into two unrelated families (native Dravidian vs. a Sanskrit turmeric-loan), Telugu kept **both** colors inside the same native word-family — *pacca* and *pasupu* are, at root, doublets of the same word, one settling on “green” and the other on “yellow, turmeric-colored.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “పచ్చ” — green, from Proto-Dravidian *pac-*
- “పసుపు” — yellow/turmeric, a true doublet of *pacca*, same root
- the contrast with Kannada — Telugu kept both colors in one native family; Kannada’s yellow broke away as a Sanskrit loan

Before you move on

Are పచ్చ and పసుపు two unrelated words, or doublets of the same root? (**Doublets** — both from Proto-Dravidian **pac-*.) Does Telugu’s yellow word follow the same pattern as Kannada’s *haladi* (a Sanskrit loan)? (**No** — Telugu kept its yellow word native, unlike Kannada.) What Tamil word is *pasupu*’s direct cognate? (பசுப்பு, *pacuppu*.)

Chapter 23

Day

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say “day” in Telugu and choose between the everyday Persian loan and its formal Sanskrit alternate.

Say రోజు, a genuine Persian loan from *rōz*, and set it against the formal దినము — the mirror image of Kannada’s plain *dina*.

23.1 రోజు (rōju) — “day,” a genuine Persian surprise

You might expect Telugu’s word for “day” to be Sanskrit, like Kannada’s *dina*, or native Dravidian. It’s neither — it’s Persian.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

రోజు (rōju) — “day” — is Telugu’s everyday, ordinary word for “a day.” Here’s the real surprise: it’s **borrowed from Classical Persian** روز (rōz) — the same root, ultimately, as the Persian day names hiding in words like “Nowruz” (“new day”). Persian *rōz* itself traces to a Proto-Indo-European root, **lew-* (“bright”) — a **completely different** PIE root from the **dyew-* family behind Latin’s *diēs*, Hindi’s *din*, and Kannada’s *dina*. Both roots independently mean something like “shining, bright” — but they are **not** cousins; this is convergent meaning, not shared ancestry.

Why it's said this way

Telugu also has దినము (**dinamu**) — the same Sanskrit **tatsama** word as Kannada's *dina*. But here's the honest twist: unlike Kannada, where *dina* is the plain, everyday word, Telugu's దినము is the more **formal, literary** alternate — *rōju* does the everyday work instead. Telugu's formal/everyday split runs the **opposite direction** from Kannada's.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rōju” — “day,” a genuine Persian loanword
- the honest surprise — from Persian *rōz*, PIE *lew-*, *NOT the same root as diēs/din/dina*
- the reversed pattern — *dinamu* is Telugu's FORMAL word, unlike Kannada's plain *dina*

Before you move on

What language does Telugu's everyday రోజు (*rōju*) come from? (**Persian** — *rōz*.) Is Persian *rōz*'s PIE root the same as Latin *diēs*/Hindi *din*/Kannada *dina*'s root? (**No** — a completely different PIE root, **lew-*, “bright,” vs. **dyew-* — related in meaning, not in ancestry.) Is Telugu's Sanskrit word, దినము (*dinamu*), the everyday word or the formal one? (**The formal one** — the opposite of Kannada, where *dina* is plain and everyday.)

Chapter 24

Night

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say “night” in Telugu and recognise it inside the midnight word I already knew.

Say రాత్రి, find it again inside అర్ధరాత్రి, and note the three native words — rēyi, māpu, irulu — it pushed aside.

24.1 రాత్రి (rātri) — “night,” this time matching the expected pattern

Last lesson’s *rōju* broke every expectation. This one is more straightforward — but still worth checking honestly, not assuming.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

రాత్రి (rātri) — “night” — is a Sanskrit **tatsama** word, already hiding inside అర్ధరాత్రి (*ardharātri*, “midnight,” Chapter 17). Unlike *rōju*’s Persian surprise, *rātri* really **is** Telugu’s ordinary, everyday word for “night” — matching Kannada’s own pattern this time, not breaking it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Telugu **does** have native words here — but be honest: it’s a **messier** picture than Kannada’s clean two-word story, not a tidy mirror of it.

- రేయి (rēyi) — attested in older Telugu literature; most sources treat it as inherited Dravidian, though some grammars instead

link it to *rātri* itself, so its native status is less than fully settled.

- మాపు (*māpu*) — its **primary** sense is actually “**evening, dusk**” (as in రేపుమాపు, “morning and evening”), with “night” only a secondary, extended sense — not a clean synonym for *rātri*.
- ఇరులు (*irulu*) — a genuine cognate of Kannada’s ಇರುಳು (*irulu*), but its primary modern sense is “**darkness**,” archaic even in that use.

All three have been effectively pushed aside by the Sanskrit loan — but unlike Kannada’s single native competitor, Telugu’s “native” side is split across three words in three different, overlapping senses.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*rātri*” — “night,” already met inside *ardharātri*
- *rēyi*, *māpu*, *irulu* — three native words, three overlapping senses, all pushed aside
- the contrast with last lesson — day broke the pattern, night matches it

Before you move on

Where have you already met రాత్రి before this lesson? (అర్ధరాత్రి, *ardharātri*, “midnight.”) Does *rātri* follow the same “Sanskrit-as-everyday” pattern as Kannada’s *rātri*, or does it break the pattern the way *rōju* did for “day”? (**It matches** — *rātri* really is Telugu’s everyday word.) Does Telugu’s native-word story cleanly mirror Kannada’s single-word *irulu*? (**No** — it’s messier: three words, రేయి/మాపు/ఇరులు, in three overlapping senses, not one clean replacement.)

Chapter 25

Good Night

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good night in Telugu.

Say శుభ రాత్రి — “auspicious night” — pairing the రాత్రి already learned with śubha, while knowing many speakers code-switch to English here.

25.1 శుభ రాత్రి (śubha rātri) — the standard translation, honestly checked against real speech

You have both pieces already: *rātri* from last lesson, and one more Sanskrit word. But this lesson’s honest twist is about who actually says the result out loud.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

శుభ రాత్రి (śubha rātri) — “good night” — literally “auspicious night.” Both pieces are Sanskrit **tatsama**: రాత్రి (*rātri*, “night,” already met) plus శుభ (*śubha*, “auspicious,” from root śubh, “to be beautiful,” ultimately PIE **kewb^h-*).

Why it’s said this way

Here’s a genuinely interesting wrinkle, hedged appropriately: some sources describe modern Telugu speakers, especially casually, often **code-switching to English “good night”** rather than saying శుభ

రాత్రి aloud — treating it more as the standard written/dictionary translation than an everyday spoken phrase. Be careful with this claim, though: the evidence for it comes mainly from informal language-learning blogs and forum posts, not rigorous sociolinguistic sources, and the same “code-switch to English for casual farewells” pattern plausibly shows up across other South Asian languages too — it isn’t clearly something unique to Telugu, just something the available sources happened to mention for Telugu specifically. Either way, *śubha rātri* itself is perfectly correct and understood Telugu, whatever its actual spoken frequency turns out to be.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha rātri” — “good night,” literally “auspicious night”
- śubha’s own root — śubh, “to be beautiful” → “auspicious”
- the honest twist — the standard translation, but many speakers code-switch to English instead

Before you move on

What does శుభ రాత్రి literally mean? (“**Auspicious night.**”) Is *śubha rātri* actually the phrase most Telugu speakers say aloud for “good night”? (**Often not** — many code-switch to English “good night” in casual speech; *śubha rātri* is the standard written/ formal translation.) Does this mean *śubha rātri* is wrong or ungrammatical? (**No** — perfectly correct, just less commonly spoken than expected.)

Chapter 26

Morning

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say “morning” in Telugu with the same word that sits inside the morning greeting.

Say ఉదయం, Telugu’s broadest morning word, note the real native competitors poddu and vēkuva, and see that Kannada splits this job across two unrelated words.

26.1 ఉదయం (udayam) — the same Sanskrit root, a different job than in Kannada

Last lesson’s రోజు was a genuine Persian surprise. This lesson’s word for “morning” goes the other way — straight Sanskrit, doing double duty in a way its Kannada cousin doesn’t.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఉదయం (udayam) — “**morning**” — is a Sanskrit **tatsama**: from ఉదయ (udaya, “**rise, appearance**”) plus Telugu’s own -ము (-mu) nominal suffix. This is Telugu’s most common, general everyday word for “morning” — but be honest: it doesn’t have the field entirely to itself. పొద్దు/పొద్దున (poddu/podduna) is genuine **Proto-Dravidian** vocabulary — cognate with Tamil **pozhudu** and Kannada **hottu** — and does real everyday work too (“పొద్దున్నే లేచాను,” “I woke up in the morning”). వేకువ (vēkuva, “dawn, early morning”) is labeled **colloquial**, not archaic or purely poetic. ఉదయం is the broadest, most

general word — but not an uncontested one.

Why it's said this way

Here's the honest cross-language twist. Kannada also has this **exact** Sanskrit root, ఉదయ (udaya) — but only inside its **greeting**, ಶುಭೋದಯ (śubhōdaya, “good morning”). Kannada's actual everyday **noun** for “morning” is a completely unrelated **native** word, ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ (beḷagge, “the shining”). Telugu doesn't split the job that way: ఉదయం covers both the everyday noun AND, in శుభోదయం, the greeting root — one word, doing what Kannada spreads across two unrelated ones. And unlike రోజు (last lesson's genuine Persian surprise for “day”), Telugu's morning word holds no such twist — straightforwardly Sanskrit, start to finish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “udayam” — “morning,” Sanskrit tatsama, the broadest word, though poddu/podduna and vēkuva are real native alternatives too
- the cross-language twist — Kannada's ఉదయ root only shows up in ITS greeting; Telugu uses ఉదయం for both the noun and the greeting
- the contrast with రోజు — no Persian surprise here, just straightforward Sanskrit

Before you move on

Is ఉదయం the ONLY word Telugu speakers use for “morning”? (**No** — it's the broadest, most common one, but పొద్దు/పొద్దున and వేకువ, both genuinely native, do real everyday work too.) Does Kannada's everyday morning-noun share ఉదయం's root? (**No** — Kannada's బెళగ్ಗೆ is native; the shared root, udaya, shows up only inside Kannada's GREETING, శుభೋదయ.) Does ఉదయం hold a surprise the way రోజు did? (**No** — straightforwardly Sanskrit throughout.)

Chapter 27

Evening

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say “evening” in Telugu.

Say సాయంత్రం, from sāyam plus a time-suffix, and follow its PIE

**seh₁- root across to Latin sērus, French soir and Italian sera.*

27.1 సాయంత్రం (sāyantram) — a distant cousin of French “soir”

This lesson’s word for “evening” reaches back to a PIE root that also surfaces — in a completely different language, on a completely different continent’s language family.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

సాయంత్రం (sāyantram) — “evening” — is a Sanskrit **tatsama**: from సాయం (sāyam, “in the evening”) plus a Sanskrit **-tana** suffix that turns time-adverbs into adjectives — the same suffix pattern behind Sanskrit **divātana** (“of the day”) and **sanātana** (“eternal, lasting”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here’s the striking part, checked directly against primary sources rather than assumed: సాయం itself traces to **Proto-Indo-European *seh₁-** (“long, lasting”) — and this is **explicitly** documented as “distantly related to **Latin sērus**” (“late”), itself confirmed independently to trace to the very same **seh₁-* root (via Proto-Italic

sēros*). *sērus* is worth a closer look: it's the Latin root well attested as the source of **French soir and **Italian sera** — French and Italian's own everyday “evening” words. That makes సాయంత్రం and **soir/sera** genuine distant cognates — one route through Sanskrit tatsama borrowing into Telugu, one route through centuries of Vulgar Latin erosion into French and Italian, both ultimately the same Proto-Indo-European idea of something “long, lasting” stretching into “late in the day.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sāyantram” — “evening,” sāyam + the -tana time-suffix
- the deep root — PIE *seh₁-*, “long, lasting”
- the cross-family cognate — the same root behind French **soir** and Italian **sera**, via Latin *sērus*

Before you move on

What is సాయంత్రం built from? (సాయం, “in the evening,” + a Sanskrit “-tana” time-adjective suffix.) What PIE root does సాయం trace to? (**seh₁-*, “long, lasting.”) What two Romance words are genuine distant cognates of సాయంత్రం, and through which Latin word? (**French soir** and **Italian sera** — both through Latin *sērus*, “late,” which traces to the same **seh₁-* root.)

Chapter 28

Afternoon

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use Telugu’s noon word to talk about the afternoon, and reach for the classical term when I need to be precise.

Reuse మధ్యాహ్నం for the stretch between noon and evening, then contrast it with ఆపరాహ్నం, the more formal, more precise later-afternoon word.

28.1 మధ్యాహ్నం — the same “noon” word, now also “afternoon”

You already know మధ్యాహ్నం means “noon” — precisely, “middle of the day.” This lesson’s honest twist: the word doesn’t stay that precise in modern use.

Why it’s said this way

మధ్యాహ్నం (**madhyāhnam**) is the exact word from Chapter 17, still literally “middle” + “day” — but a source fetched directly (not just a search summary) confirms it now covers “**the time between noon and evening**” in modern usage — a genuine widened sense, not just the precise midday instant its etymology points to. This mirrors Hindi’s दोपहर (clearly, well- confirmed widened from “noon” to “afternoon”) and, more thinly Kannada’s own ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ (a hedged, single-source impression of the same kind of stretch).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Telugu also has అపరాహ్నం (*aparāhnam*), from the same classical **five-part Sanskrit day division** already found behind Kannada’s అపరాహ్న — *prāta/udaya* (sunrise), *saṅgava*, *madhyāhna* (noon), *aparāhna* (“later afternoon” specifically), *sāyāhna* (evening). Be honest about the sourcing here, echoing the same hedge already applied to Kannada’s *aparāhna*: thin, informal evidence — a native-speaker forum discussion, general dictionary usage notes — points toward మధ్యాహ్నం **winning colloquially**, with అపరాహ్నం staying the more **formally precise** term. Real, but not corpus-linguistics-grade sourcing — treat it the same cautious way Kannada’s own equivalent finding was treated, not as fully settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “madhyāhnam” — the same word from Chapter 17, “middle of the day”
- the confirmed widening — now also covers “the time between noon and evening”
- “aparāhnam” — the more precise classical word for later afternoon, staying the more formal term per thin but real evidence

Before you move on

Is మధ్యాహ్నం a new word, or the same one from Chapter 17? (**The same word** — “middle” + “day.”) Does modern usage confirm మధ్యాహ్నం covers only the exact instant of noon? (**No** — a directly-fetched source confirms it now covers “the time between noon and evening” too.) Is it confirmed whether అపరాహ్నం or widened మధ్యాహ్నం is more common today? (**Thin but real evidence** points to మధ్యాహ్నం winning colloquially, అపరాహ్నం staying formally precise — not fully settled, but not silent either.)

Chapter 29

Good Morning

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good morning in Telugu.

Say శుభోదయం — śubha + ఉదయం — and weigh the single low-authority claim that it is out of trend against నమస్కారం, the safer everyday bet.

29.1 శుభోదయం (śubhodayam) — a claim worth real skepticism, not a settled fact

You already have ఉదయం. This lesson’s honest twist is about a dramatic-sounding claim — and about being skeptical of it, even though it came from a source fetched directly.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

శుభోదయం (śubhodayam) — “good morning” — is built from శుభ (“good”) plus ఉదయం (already met, Chapter 26). Grammatically and etymologically, this is the straightforward, traditional Telugu “good morning.”

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the twist, and the honesty this time cuts against the source itself: one directly-fetched page describes శుభోదయం as **out of trend**, displaced by **English** “good morning,” with children taught the

English phrase from **preschool**. That’s a vivid, quotable claim — but “fetched directly” doesn’t make a source authoritative. This is the **same genre** of Telugu/Kannada/Hindi-learning content blog already found **overstated** for Hindi’s सुप्रभात and Kannada’s own ಶುಭೋದಯ (a single uncredentialed listicle, no sociolinguistic methodology, no citations) — treat this claim the same skeptical way, not as settled. Genuinely worth separating from that dramatic claim: సుప్రభాతం (*suprabhātam*) also exists — built on ప్రభాత (*prabhāta*), a **completely different** Sanskrit root from ఉదయ (*udaya*). This is **not** the same root behind Kannada’s ಶುಭೋದయ, which itself uses *udaya* — don’t conflate the two Sanskrit “morning” roots. A third option, ప్రొద్దుటి వందనాలు (“morning greetings,” built on పొద్దు, Chapter 26’s genuine native competitor to ఉదయం), also exists but isn’t confirmed common either. నమస్కారం is the safer bet for everyday use — matching the same నమస్కార/नमस्ते pattern already found doing the real everyday work for both Kannada and Hindi.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubhōdayam” — “good morning,” śubha + udayam
- the honest twist — one low-authority source claims it’s out of trend, displaced by English; treat with real skepticism
- నమస్కారం — the safer everyday-greeting bet

Before you move on

What is శుభోదయం built from? (శుభ + ఉదయం.) Is the claim that శుభోదయం has been displaced by English a confirmed, well-sourced fact? (**No** — it comes from one low-authority content-blog source, the same genre already found overstated for Hindi/Kannada; treat it skeptically, not as settled.) Does సుప్రభాతం share ఉదయం’s root, or Kannada’s ಶುಭೋದయ’s root? (**Neither** — its own root, ప్రభాత/*prabhāta*, is a genuinely different Sanskrit word.)

Chapter 30

Good Evening

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good evening in Telugu.

Say శుభ సాయంత్రం, backed by two independent sources as genuinely common in both formal and casual speech, with నమస్కారం as an alternative rather than a replacement.

30.1 శుభ సాయంత్రం (śubha sāyantram) — a claim that actually holds up on checking

Last lesson’s morning greeting rested on one dramatic, shaky source. This one is different — and the difference itself is worth noticing.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

శుభ సాయంత్రం (śubha sāyantram) — “good evening” — pairs శుభ (“good”) with సాయంత్రం (already met, Chapter 27 — the word whose PIE root, *seh*₁-, turned out to be a genuine distant cognate of Latin’s *sērus*, and so of French *soir* and Italian *sera*).

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest contrast worth drawing explicitly: last lesson’s శుభోదయం rested on **one** dramatic, low-authority source claiming it had been displaced by English entirely. This time, **two** independently

fetches sources — not just search-engine summaries — **agree**: శుభ సాయంత్రం is genuinely, commonly used, in **both** formal and informal contexts, appropriate for greeting people after work or arriving at an evening gathering. Neither source flags it as archaic or displaced. This doesn't mean these sources are beyond question — they're still the same general genre of language-learning content that has needed hedging before — but **being independently cross-corroborated** is a real, meaningful difference in evidence quality from a single dramatic claim, and it's worth being just as honest about a claim holding up as about one that doesn't. నమస్కారం, as before, remains a genuine time-independent alternative — but nothing here suggests it has **displaced** this greeting the way English reportedly displaced శుభోదయం.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha sāyantram” — “good evening,” śubha + sāyantram
- the honest contrast — this claim is cross-corroborated by two sources, unlike last lesson's single dramatic one
- నమస్కారం — a time-independent alternative, not a replacement here

Before you move on

What word does శుభ సాయంత్రం pair with, and what's that word's own striking cross-language story? (సాయంత్రం — a genuine distant PIE cognate of Latin sērus/French soir/Italian sera.) Is the “genuinely commonly used” claim for శుభ సాయంత్రం as thinly sourced as శుభోదయం's “displaced by English” claim was? (**No** — two independent sources agree here, versus one dramatic claim last lesson — a real difference in evidence quality.)

Chapter 31

Good Afternoon

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good afternoon in Telugu and judge whether it fits the setting I am in.

Say శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం where the setting is formal or workplace-timed, and fall back on నమస్కారం, the time-independent everyday greeting.

31.1 శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం (śubha madhyāhnam) — good afternoon

You already know శుభ from the morning and evening greetings and మధ్యాహ్నం from the parts-of-day lessons. Put them together.

You'll want to know: శుభ + మధ్యాహ్నం

శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం (śubha madhyāhnam) means “good afternoon.” The second word originally centres on “midday” or “noon,” but you learned in Chapter 28 that modern use widens it into the stretch between noon and evening.

Telugu could instead have built the phrase on అపరాహ్నం (*aparāhnam*), the more classically precise word for later afternoon. It did not. Kannada made the same choice in ಶುభ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ (śubha madhyāhna): both languages chose the everyday “noon, widened” word from two available classical terms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha madhyāhnam” — “good afternoon,” śubha + madhyāhnam
- the word choice — built on మధ్యాహ్నం, not అపరాహ్నం, matching Kannada’s exact same choice
- Kannada ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ్ನ — the same word-building choice

Before you move on

Is శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం built on మధ్యాహ్నం or అపరాహ్నం? (మధ్యాహ్నం — the “noon, widened” word.) Which sister language made the same choice? (Kannada, in ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ.)

31.2 శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం — register and evidence

You can now build శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం. The next question is when it sounds natural—and how strongly the available evidence answers that question.

Why it’s said this way

Two independently fetched language-learning sources confirm that శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం is a real, correctly formed greeting for **formal or workplace** use around noon and early afternoon.

Keep the claims separate, though. Talkpal explicitly ranks the greeting as **less common** in everyday conversation than morning or evening greetings. Preply independently supports its timing and formal register, but does not make that frequency comparison. So there are two sources for “real and formal,” but only one for “less common.” A second source must not be counted as evidence for a claim it never made.

Why it’s said this way

- శుభోదయం — the morning lesson found one low-authority claim of displacement by English; treat that dramatic claim skeptically.
- శుభ సాయంత్రం — two sources supported common formal and

informal use.

- శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం — real and workplace-timed, with narrower support for its lower everyday frequency.

The three phrases do not need one uniform usage story. For a time-independent everyday greeting, నమస్కారం remains the safer choice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two-source claim — real, formal, and workplace-timed
- the one-source claim — less common than morning or evening
- నమస్కారం — the time-independent everyday alternative

Before you move on

Do both sources rank శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం as less common? (No. Both support its formal use; only Talkpal makes the frequency comparison.) What is the safer all-day greeting? (నమస్కారం.)

Chapter 32

The Core Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (6) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can build a Telugu verb as stem plus tense plus person, say why one form covers both “I go” and “I will go”, give a polite command with -aṇḍi, and explain why ఉండు has to borrow its negative and తెలుసు has no person at all.

Say నాకు తెలుసు, name the three slots that built uṇṭānu, veḷṭānu and cūṣṭānu, separate it from Chapter 6’s నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు — fact against skill — and recall that ఉండు switches to lē- to be negated.

32.1 ఉండు (uṇḍu) — “to be,” and the negative that is a different verb

Thirty-one chapters of words. Now the engine room. Telugu glues a verb together one piece at a time, seams showing, and this first verb carries the machine.

You’ll want to know: ఉండు

ఉండు — uṇḍu — to be, to exist, to stay

Chapter 5 met it as “to live somewhere.” Here it is the verb-machine itself: ఉండ్- (the stem) + -త- (tense) + -ను (“I”) → ఉంటాను (uṇṭānu), “I stay, I will be.”

One form is already in your mouth: ఉన్నాను (unnānu), “I am — right now,” the shape hiding inside bāgunnānu and mīru elā unnāru?

Telugu is alone in this word. Tamil says இரு (*iru*), Kannada ಇರು (*iru*), Malayalam ഇരിക്കുക (*irikkuka*) — one verb, three sisters. Telugu went its own way, as it did with *lēdu*.

The letters in this word

ఉ is the standing vowel *u*. ండు is the retroflex cluster *ṇḍ* with the *u* sign — tongue tip curled back, then released. Both shapes are familiar from Chapter 5.

Grammar Lens: Telugu’s “be” cannot be made negative

There is no negative of *uṇḍu*. To say something is **not** there, Telugu drops the verb and picks up a second one, లే- (*lē-*) — the root behind Chapter 1’s *lēdu*. It takes the very same person-endings:

who	is	is not
I	<i>unnānu</i>	<i>lēnu</i>
he	<i>unnāḍu</i>	<i>lēḍu</i>
it	<i>undi</i>	<i>lēdu</i>

So *lēdu* was never a bare word for “no.” It is the **it**-form of a full verb, and you can now run it through its persons.

This is where Telugu parted from its sisters. Tamil negates *iru* with இல்லை (*illai*), Kannada with ಇಲ್ಲ (*illa*), Malayalam with ഇല്ല (*illa*) — one shared root, *il-*. Telugu dropped it and grew *lē-* instead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “uṇḍu” — be, exist, stay
- the three pieces in order — “uṇḍ ... ta ... ānu” → “uṇṭānu”
- the pair you must switch verbs for — “unnānu ... lēnu”
- the three sisters’ one verb — “iru ... iru ... irikkuka”

Before you move on

What are the three pieces of *uṇṭānu*? (**Stem, tense, person** — *uṇḍ-*, *-ta-*, *-ānu*.) How do you say “I am not there”? (లేను, *lēnu* — a different verb entirely.) So what kind of word is *lēdu*? (**The it-form**

of the negative verb *lē-*.) Which root do the other three sisters use, and does Telugu? (*il-*; Telugu does **not**.) Next: the same machine, tense piece swapped.

32.2 వెళ్ళు (*veḷḷu*) — “to go,” and a tense Telugu refuses to split

You have the three pieces — stem, tense, person. Change only the middle one. That is the whole of Telugu tense, and it has one setting fewer than you would expect.

You’ll want to know: వెళ్ళు

వెళ్ళు — *veḷḷu* — to go

Chapter 4 gave it to you as a bare command, *veḷḷu!*, “go!” Threaded up it is వెళ్తాను (*veḷtānu*), and its past is వెళ్ళాను (*veḷḷānu*), “I went.”

Telugu keeps a second go-verb beside it. The family’s inherited word for going is *pō-*, and Telugu has it as పోవు (*pōvu*), పోతాను (*pōtānu*) — the same verb as Tamil போ (pō), Malayalam പോകുക (*pōkuka*) and Kannada ಹೋಗು (*hōgu*). So Telugu did not lose the family’s word; it gave the everyday job to *veḷḷu*, a verb of its own whose deeper history is best left open.

The letters in this word

వె is *va* with the short-*e* sign. ళ్ళు is the retroflex శ (*ḷ*) doubled and held — *veḷ-ḷu*, a real catch in the middle. The same doubling is in *nḷḷu*, Chapter 15’s water.

Grammar Lens: one piece for “I go” and “I will go”

when	Telugu	the middle piece
now, or later	<i>veḷtānu</i>	<i>-ta-</i>
already	<i>veḷḷānu</i>	<i>-ā-</i>
this minute	<i>veḷtunnānu</i>	<i>-tunnā-</i>

Be honest about the first row: వెళ్తాను means “I go” **and** “I will go.” Telugu does not separate habit from future — one piece does both, and context decides. Tamil keeps them apart (*pōgīrēn* against *pōvēn*); Telugu merged them.

Having merged them, Telugu needed a way to say “right this minute,” and built one out of last lesson’s verb. వెళ్తున్నాను (*veḷtunnānu*) is *veḷ-* plus ఉన్నా-, the very *unnānu* that means “I am,” welded on: literally “going-am-I.” The be-verb did not stay a word. It became a piece of every other verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “veḷḷu” — go — then “veḷtānu”
- the two meanings of one form — “I go” and “I will go”
- the three times — “veḷtānu ... veḷḷānu ... veḷtunnānu”
- the be-verb hiding in the third — “unnānu ... veḷtunnānu”

Before you move on

How many things does *veḷtānu* mean? (**Two** — “I go” and “I will go”; Telugu merges habit and future.) What is glued inside *veḷtunnānu*? (ఉన్నా-, the be-verb — “going-am-I.”) Does Telugu have the family’s old go-root at all? (**Yes** — *pōvu*, cousin of *pō*, *pōkuka*, *hōgu*; *veḷḷu* just took the everyday work.) Next: a verb you call by one shape and build on another.

32.3 రా (rā) — “come!”, and the stem it is not built on

Veḷḷu threads its pieces on without a fuss: the word you call it by is the word you build on. Its partner refuses — and the goodbye you learned in Chapter 4 has been hiding the reason.

You’ll want to know: రా

రా — *rā* — **come!**

One syllable: ఱ (ra) with the long-ā sign. It is a whole command on its own, the plainest thing one Telugu speaker can say to another.

Every sister has this verb, and every sister’s command-shape drifted somewhere different: Tamil **வர** (*vā*), Kannada **ಬಾ** (*bā*), Malayalam **വരുക** (*varuka*), Telugu **రా** (*rā*). A *v*, a *b*, an *r* — one old Dravidian come-word, worn three ways, not three separate verbs.

Grammar Lens: the word you call it by is not the word you build on

Try to thread endings onto *rā*- and you get nothing anyone says. They attach to **వచ్చు** (*vaccu*) instead, which appears as *vast*- once the tense piece arrives:

- **వస్తాను** (*vastānu*) — “I come, I will come”
- **వచ్చాను** (*vaccānu*) — “I came”
- **వస్తున్నాను** (*vastunnānu*) — “I am coming right now”

The third one is last lesson’s trick again: the be-verb *unnā*- welded onto the stem. Learn this verb as a pair, then — **రా**, and **వచ్చు**. Telugu is not odd here; Tamil pairs *vā* with *varu*- and Kannada pairs *bā* with *baru*-, and the building-stems stayed far closer to each other than the commands did.

You have said *vastānu* already. Chapter 4’s farewell **వెళ్లి వస్తాను** (*velli vastānu*) — “I’ll go and come back” — is *velli* and *vaccu* standing side by side, and that second word is exactly the form above. Chapter 6 used the bare stem too, in *nāku telugu vaccu*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the command — “*rā!*”
- the pair to learn together — “*rā ... vaccu-*”
- “*vastānu ... vaccānu ... vastunnānu*”
- the farewell you now understand — “*velli vastānu*”

Before you move on

Which shape do the endings attach to for “come”? (వచ్చు, *vaccu*-, never *rā*-.) Say “I will come.” (*Vastānu*.) Which two verbs are standing in *velli vastānu*? (వెళ్ళు and వచ్చు — go, and come back.) Are Tamil *vā*, Kannada *bā* and Telugu *rā* three different verbs? (No — one old come-word, reshaped three ways.) Next: a verb Telugu kept where Tamil replaced it.

32.4 తిను (tinu) — “to eat,” the root Telugu kept

Three verbs in, and every one has been Telugu’s own choice. This one is the opposite: the oldest eat-word the family has, still doing plain everyday work.

You’ll want to know: తిను

తిను — *tinu* — to eat

తి is the dental *ta* with the *i* sign; ను is *nu*, the same shape that ends *nēnu*. Threaded up: తింటాను (*tiṇṭānu*), “I eat, I will eat,” and తిన్నాను (*tinṇānu*), “I ate.”

The inherited Dravidian root is **tin-**, and the family kept it: Kannada ತಿನ್ನು (*tinnu*), Malayalam തിന്നുക (*tinnuka*), Tamil தின் (*tin*). But Tamil narrowed its own to chewing and snacking and put an assembled compound, சாப்பிடு (*sāppiḍu*), in the everyday slot. Telugu did no such thing. *Tinu* is still simply the word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Build a noun straight off the root and you get తిండి (*tiṇḍi*) — “food, grub.” Native, transparent, and blunt: it is what you feed people, not what you invite them to.

For the invitation Telugu reaches across to Sanskrit: భోజనం (*bhōjanam*, “a meal”) and ఆహారం (*āhāram*, “food”). Both are **tatsama** loans, taken in whole, and both outrank *tiṇḍi* in politeness without displacing it.

That is Telugu’s Sanskrit habit in miniature, and it is worth naming plainly. The verbs at the centre of living — be, go, come, eat — stayed Dravidian. The formal and ceremonial vocabulary layered on top came

from Sanskrit. You met the same split in Chapter 1, where the greeting *namaskāram* is Sanskrit while *avunu* and *sarē* are native. Telugu borrowed far more of that top layer than Tamil ever did; it did not borrow the floor.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tinu” — eat — then “tiṇṭānu ... tinnānu”
- the root the whole family kept — “tinu ... tinnu ... tinnuka”
- the native noun and the borrowed one — “tiṇḍi ... bhōjanam”
- the four verbs so far — “uṇṭānu ... veḷṭānu ... vastānu ... tiṇṭānu”

Before you move on

Did Telugu keep the inherited eat-root? (Yes — *tinu*, plain and everyday, where Tamil demoted *tin* and built *sāppiḍu*.) Which word for food is native, and which is borrowed? (తిండి *tiṇḍi* is native and blunt; భోజనం *bhōjanam* is Sanskrit and polite.) What is the pattern? (Native verbs at the core, Sanskrit vocabulary layered on top — as with *avunu* against *namaskāram*.) Next: a verb, and the polite ending that fits every verb in this chapter.

32.5 చూడు (cūḍu) — “to see,” and the polite ending that fits every verb

Four bare commands so far — *uṇḍu*, *vellu*, *rā*, *tinu* — and every one is blunt. This verb brings the ending that makes them polite.

You’ll want to know: చూడు

చూడు — *cūḍu* — to see, to look

Threaded up: చూస్తాను (*cūstānu*), “I see, I will see,” and చూశాను (*cūśānu*), “I saw.”

Here the sisters scatter completely. Tamil says **பார்** (*pār*), Kannada **ನೋಡು** (*nōḍu*), Malayalam **കാണുക** (*kāṇuka*), Telugu **చూడు** (*cūḍu*). Four languages, four unrelated everyday verbs.

And yet the family’s oldest seeing-root is right there in all four, sitting in a noun you can point at: **కన్ను** (*kannu*, “eye”) — Tamil **கண்** (*kaṇ*), Kannada **ಕಣ್ಣು** (*kaṇṇu*), Malayalam **കണ്ണ്** (*kaṇṇ*). Telugu still builds on it: **కనిపించు** (*kanipiṅcu*), “to appear, to be visible.” Four everyday verbs, one shared eye.

The letters in this word

చూ is **చ** (*ca*) with the **long-ū** sign — the drawn-out partner of the short *u* ending every verb in this chapter. Hold it: *cū*, not *cu*. **డు** is retroflex *ḍa* with that short *u*.

Grammar Lens: -అండి, the respectful command, on any stem

Chapter 8 gave you **కూర్చండి** (*kūrcōṇḍi*), “please sit.” Chapter 9 gave you **క్షమించండి** (*kṣamiṅcaṇḍi*), “forgive me.” That shared **-అండి** (*-aṇḍi*) is not baked into those two words. It is a slot, and every verb in this chapter can fill it:

- **చూడండి** (*cūḍaṇḍi*) — please look
- **రండి** (*raṇḍi*) — please come
- **తినండి** (*tiṇaṇḍi*) — please eat
- **వెళ్ళండి** (*vellaṇḍi*) — please go

Bare stem for a child or a close friend; stem plus *-aṇḍi* for everyone else. The respect is built the way Chapter 2 built it: *mīru* is a plural standing in for one person, and *-aṇḍi* is that plural now sitting on the verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cūḍu” — see, look — then “cūstānu”
- the four sisters’ four verbs — “cūḍu ... pār ... nōḍu ... kāṇuka”
- the eye they all share — “kannu ... kaṇ ... kaṇṇu ... kaṇṇ”

- all four polite commands — “cūḍaṇḍi ... raṇḍi ... tinaṇḍi ... vellāṇḍi”

Before you move on

Do the four sisters share an everyday verb for seeing? (**No** — *cūḍu*, *pār*, *nōḍu*, *kāṇuka*, all different.) What do they share instead? (**The eye** — *kannu*, *kaṇ*, *kaṇṇu*, *kaṇṇ*.) Make “please eat” and “please come.” (*Tinaṇḍi*; *raṇḍi*.) Where have you met that politeness before? (**In మీరు** — a plural used for one person, now on the verb.) Next: a verb with no room for a person at all.

32.6 తెలుసు (telusu) — “to know,” the verb with no room for a person

Five verbs, and every one ended on *-ānu*, the piece that means “I.” The last verb of the chapter has no such piece — and Chapter 6 already handed you the sentence it makes.

You’ll want to know: తెలుసు

తెలుసు — *telusu* — it is known

Not “to know” in the English sense. It comes from తెలియు (*teliyu*), “to become clear, to be apparent” — a thing *telusu*-es to you the way a shape resolves out of fog. Its negative is తెలియదు (*teliyadu*), “it is not known.”

Tamil has the exact cousin, தெரி (*teri*). The other two sisters picked different words — Kannada ಗೊತ್ತು, *gottu*, Malayalam അറിയാം, *ariyām* — but all four build the sentence the same way, which is the point of this lesson.

Grammar Lens: no person on the verb, so the person moves

నాకు తెలుసు. — *nāku telusu* — “I know.”

తెలుసు never changes shape. Only the little dative word in front of it moves:

the knower	the sentence
I	<i>nāku telusu</i>
you	<i>nīku telusu</i>
he	<i>ataniki telusu</i>

Five verbs put the person in the last piece, which is why *nēnu* could be

dropped. Here there is no such piece, so the dative word is the one thing you **cannot** drop. Telugu treats knowing as something that **happens to** you, not something you do — and Tamil builds it identically, *enakkut teriyum*.

Now the distinction Chapter 6 could not yet draw. నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు uses *vaccu*, “comes” — Telugu **comes to** you, and that is a **skill**, a language you can actually use. నాకు తెలుసు is a **fact** you hold. Two dative sentences, two verbs, two kinds of knowing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “telusu” — it is known — from “teliyu”, to become clear
- “nāku telusu” — I know
- three knowers, one verb — “nāku ... nīku ... ataniki telusu”
- the five that carried the person — “uṇṭānu, veḷṭānu, vastānu, tiṇṭānu, cūstānu”

Before you move on

What does *telusu* mean underneath “know”? (**It is clear, it is apparent** — from *teliyu*.) Which piece is missing from it? (**The person** — so the knower sits in the dative instead.) Say “I know.” (*Nāku telusu*.) What is the difference from *nāku telugu vaccu*? (***Vaccu* marks a skill, *telusu* marks a fact.**) Name the three slots one last time, with a verb in them. (Stem, tense, person — *veḷ* + *-ta-* + *-ānu*.) And what has no negative of its own? (ఉండు — Telugu switches to *lē-*.)

Chapter 33

Four Verbs of the Mind

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I think, I understand, I read and I write in Telugu with the same three slots, build the -కో ending that hands an action back to its doer, say “I understood” with no నేను in it, and tell this chapter’s native verbs from the Sanskrit words layered beside them.

Say నేను తెలుగు రాస్తాను, run the chapter’s four verbs in the present, count them up from ఆరు to పది, take వ్రాయు back to the Dravidian line-drawing root behind Tamil వ్రాయ and Kannada ಬರೆ, and name which of the four words came from Sanskrit.

33.1 అనుకో (anukō) — “to think,” which is saying it to yourself

Nāku telusu — “I know” — and that verb had no room for a person. This one takes the person back, and carries a second verb on its end.

You’ll want to know: అనుకో

అనుకో — *anukō* — to think; to suppose

Threaded up: అనుకుంటాను (*anukuntānu*), “I think,” and అనుకున్నాను (*anukunnānu*), “I thought.” That -ంటాను is the ending you already made in తింటాను (*tiṇṭānu*): stem, tense, then the -ānu that means “I.”

The letters in this word

అ is the standing vowel *a*, used when a word begins on that sound. ను is *na* with the *u* sign, the shape that ends *nēnu*. క్ is క (*ka*) with the long-*ō* sign: hold it, *kō*.

Grammar Lens: -క్, the ending that hands the verb back

కొను (*konu*) is a verb of its own — “to take, to get.” Bolted onto the back of another verb it stops being a word and becomes an ending, -కొను, worn down to -క్ in speech. What it adds is small and everywhere: *do the thing, and keep it*. So అను (“say”) plus -క్ is **say it, and keep it** — say it to nobody but yourself.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

అను (*anu*), “to say,” is Proto-Dravidian **aHn-*, and every sister kept it: Tamil என் (*en*), Kannada ಅನ್ನು (*annu*), Malayalam എన్నുക (*ennuka*).

Beside it Telugu keeps a borrowed thinker: ఆలోచించు (*ālōciṇcu*), “to consider” — ఆలోచిస్తాను (*ālōcistānu*). Its Sanskrit noun ఆలోచన (*ālōcana*) is glossed two ways at once: “reflecting” and “seeing.” Sanskrit made thinking a kind of looking, as English did in *reflect*. The split Chapter 32 named over *tiṇḍi* and *bhōjanam* holds: plain verb native, formal word Sanskrit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two pieces, then the word — “anu ... *kō* ... anukō”
- “anukunṭānu”, I think — then “anukunnānu”, I thought
- the ending you already had — “tiṇṭānu ... anukunṭānu”
- the family’s say-verb — “anu ... *en* ... annu ... ennuka”
- native and borrowed — “anukunṭānu ... *ālōcistānu*”

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *anukō*, and what does the second do? (అను “say” plus -కో, which hands the action back to the doer.) Say “I think,” and name the verb ending the same way. (*Anukunṭānu*; తిను.) Which sisters keep the say-verb, and what is *ālōcana* glossed as? (**All three**; “reflecting” and “seeing”.) Which think-word is borrowed? (అలోచించు — as *bhōjanam* was beside *tiṇḍi*.)

33.2 అర్థం చేసుకో (artham cēsukō) — “to understand,” making the meaning yours

Anukunṭānu — I think — and the -కో on its back meant *and keep it*. That ending now arrives on a verb you have owned since Chapter 5.

You’ll want to know: అర్థం చేసుకో

అర్థం చేసుకో — *artham cēsukō* — to understand

Three pieces, all already yours: అర్థం (*artham*, “meaning”), చేయు (*cēyu*, “to do”), and the -కో of the last lesson. Word for word it says **make the meaning your own**.

నేను అర్థం చేసుకుంటాను. — *nēnu artham cēsukunṭānu* — “I understand.”

The letters in this word

ర్థ is a **conjunct** — ర (*ra*) stacked above థ (*tha*), one block for two consonants with no vowel between. ం is the **anusvāra** that closes *namaskāram*, and చే opens *cēyu*.

Grammar Lens: the other way to say it, with no “I” in it

నాకు అర్థమైంది. — *nāku arthamaīndi* — “I understood.”
Literally: “to me it became meaning.”

Three dative sentences now, and one design:

the sentence	what it says
<i>nāku telugu vaccu</i>	Telugu comes to me
<i>nāku telusu</i>	it is clear to me
<i>nāku arthamaṇḍi</i>	it became meaning to me
No <i>nēnu</i> in any of them: the person sits in the dative because understanding, like knowing, arrives. Both shapes are good Telugu and do not feel alike — <i>nēnu artham cēsukuntānu</i> is work you did, <i>nāku arthamaṇḍi</i> is a thing that landed.	

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

అర్థం is Sanskrit अर्थ (*artha*), and Telugu took the whole of it: అర్థము means “**meaning**” and “**money, wealth**” in one entry — which is why Kauṭilya’s manual of statecraft is the *Arthaśāstra*. Its opposite: అపార్థం (*apārtham*), “a meaning taken wrong.”

Now the seam. Chapter 20’s వాతావరణం was Sanskrit throughout — *vāta* plus *āvaraṇa*. This is not that. Only the noun crossed over; the doing is Telugu’s own *cēyu* wearing Telugu’s own *-kō*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three pieces — “artham ... cēyu ... kō”
- “nēnu artham cēsukuntānu” — I understand
- the three dative sentences — “nāku telugu vaccu ... nāku telusu ... nāku arthamaṇḍi”
- the two verbs built with *-kō* — “anukuntānu ... artham cēsukuntānu”
- “artham ... apārtham”

Before you move on

Take *artham cēsukō* apart and give the literal sense. (**Meaning + do + for yourself.**) Say “I understood” without *nēnu*, then name the other two sentences built that way. (*Nāku arthamaṇḍi*; *nāku telugu vaccu*, *nāku telusu*.) Why is the person in the dative?

(Understanding arrives at you.) What two things does *artham* mean, and how is this compound unlike *vātāvaraṇam*? (Meaning and wealth; *vātāvaraṇam* is Sanskrit throughout, here only the noun is.)

33.3 చదువు (caduvu) — “to read,” which is also “an education”

Nāku arthamaindi — it became meaning to me. Say it once.
Now the verb for the work that gets you there.

You’ll want to know: చదువు

చదువు — *caduvu* — to read; to study

నేను తెలుగు చదువుతాను. — *nēnu telugu caduvutānu* — “I read Telugu.”

Telugu does not split reading from studying, and it builds no separate noun either: చదువు unchanged is “education, studies” — what a family means when it says a child’s *caduvu* is going well.

The sisters scatter here as completely as they did over seeing: Tamil படி (*paḍi*), Kannada ಓದು (*ōdu*), Malayalam വായിക്കുക (*vāyikkuka*), Telugu చదువు. Four unrelated everyday verbs for one act.

The letters in this word

చ is *ca*, the letter that opens *cūḍu*. దు is ద (*da*) with the *u* sign, and వు is వ (*va*) with the same sign. Three light syllables, each ending in that short *u*.

Grammar Lens: one stem, three middle vowels

when	Telugu
now, or later	<i>caduvutānu</i>
already	<i>cadivānu</i>
asked politely	<i>cadavaṇḍi</i>

cadu-, *cadī-*, *cada-*. The middle vowel moves, and nothing else does.
Chapter 32 gave you the harsh version of this with ు: there the word you call the verb by was not the word the endings attach to, and they

went to *vaccu-* instead. This is the mild version — one stem, three vowels, plainly the same word. Expect the wobble; do not expect a second verb.

The respectful -అండి arrives exactly as it did on *cūḍaṇḍi*: చదవండి (*cadavaṇḍi*), “please read.” The ending never changes; only the stem in front of it does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nēnu telugu caduvutānu” — I read Telugu
- the three middle vowels — “caduvutānu ... cadivānu ... cadavaṇḍi”
- the two polite commands — “cūḍaṇḍi ... cadavaṇḍi”
- the four sisters’ four verbs — “caduvu ... paḍi ... ṍdu ... vāyikkuka”
- the chapter so far — “anukunṭānu, artham cēsukunṭānu, caduvutānu”

Before you move on

What two English verbs does *caduvu* cover, and what is its noun? (**Read** and **study**; the **same word** — an education.) Say “I read Telugu,” then “please read.” (*Nēnu telugu caduvutānu*; *cadavaṇḍi*.) What moves between *caduvutānu*, *cadivānu* and *cadavaṇḍi*, and which verb warned you about a second stem? (**The middle vowel**; ా, whose endings went to *vaccu-*.) Do the four sisters share a read-verb? (**No** — *caduvu*, *paḍi*, *ṍdu*, *vāyikkuka*.)

33.4 రాయ (rāyu) — “to write,” which began as drawing a line

Caduvutānu, *cadivānu*, *cadavaṇḍi* — one stem, three middle vowels. The chapter’s last verb is the other half of that one.

You'll want to know: రాయు

రాయు — *rāyu* — to write

నేను తెలుగు రాస్తాను. — *nēnu telugu rāstānu* — “I write Telugu.”

The past is రాశాను (*rāśānu*). Dictionaries often print the headword as వ్రాయు (*vrāyu*): not a different verb, just the older spelling, with a *v* gone quiet in speech.

The letters in this word

రా is ర (*ra*) — Chapter 32's whole command *rā* — with the long-*ā* sign, and యు is య (*ya*) with the *u* sign. In వ్రాయు a వ is stacked in front.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

That silent *v* is the evidence. వ్రాయు goes back to a Dravidian **warV-*, “to draw a line,” and the sisters kept the *v* Telugu buried: Tamil வரை (*varai*), Malayalam വരയ്ക്കുക (*varaykkuka*), Kannada ಬರೆ (*bare*) with a *b*. Every one still means **draw** as readily as **write**. Telugu's noun keeps the shape: రాత (*rāta*), “handwriting” — and, in speech, what is written for you.

One honest note: Tamil's everyday write-verb is எழுது (*elutu*), not *varai*. The sisters share the root without agreeing which word does the daily work — the picture *caduvu* left you with.

Grammar Lens: ten verbs, and one machine

Chapter 32 handed you ఆరు (*āru*) verbs. Four more makes పది (*padi*), ten — and not one needed a new machine. Stem, tense, person: the three slots were already yours. That is what agglutination buys. What they added is a shape and a habit. The shape is -శ్, which hands the action back to its doer. The habit is Telugu's oldest: *caduvu*, *rāyu* and *anu* are native, while *ālōcana* and *arthamī*, laid on top, are Sanskrit — *tiṇḍi* beside *bhōjanamī*, one chapter on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nēnu telugu rāstānu” — then “rāśānu”

- the spellings and the sisters — “rāyu ... vrāyu ... varai ... bare”
- the chapter’s four — “anukunṭānu, artham cēsukunṭānu, caduvutānu, rāstānu”
- the count — “āru”, then “padi”
- two dative sentences — “nāku telusu ... nāku arthamaindi”

Before you move on

Say “I write Telugu,” name the older spelling, and say what the root meant first. (*Nēnu telugu rāstānu*; వ్రాయు; **to draw a line** — Tamil *varai*, Kannada *bare*.) Run this chapter’s four verbs, then count them with Chapter 32’s. (*Anukunṭānu, artham cēsukunṭānu, caduvutānu, rāstānu*; **padi** — *āru* plus four.) What does -**క** do, and which two carry it? (**Hands the action back to the doer**; *anukō, artham cēsukō*.) Which words here are Sanskrit? (అర్థం and *ālōcana*, with the plain verbs native — *tiṇḍi* against *bhōjanam*.)

Chapter 34

Four Verbs Between People

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I take, I ask and I help in Telugu, say నాకు తెలుగు ఇష్టం knowing there is no verb in it, place it beside the three other dative sentences I have built, and name the branch of Dravidian Telugu actually belongs to.

Say నాకు తెలుగు ఇష్టం and unpack it as “to me, Telugu, a liking” with no verb at all; line it up against నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు, నాకు తెలుసు and నాకు అర్థమైంది; choose between the native నచ్చు and ఇష్టపడు, whose పడు is the falling of వర్షం పడుతోంది; and trace ఇష్టం to the Indo-European root behind English ask.

34.1 తీసుకో (tīsukō) — “to take,” the third verb you do for yourself

The last four verbs happened inside your head; these four happen between you and somebody else. Say *caduvutānu* and *rāstānu*, and name what *vrāyu*’s root first meant.

You’ll want to know: తీసుకో

తీసుకో — *tīsukō* — to take

Underneath it is తీయు (*tīyu*), “to pull out,” and then the -కో you have met twice: pull it out, **and keep it**.

తీసుకుంటాను (*tīsukunṭānu*), “I take”; తీసుకున్నాను (*tīsukunnānu*), “I took” — *tiṇṭānu*’s ending on a different stem. Two whole sentences, from Chapter 15:

నేను నీళ్ళు తీసుకుంటాను. — *nēnu nīḷḷu tīsukunṭānu* — “I take water.”

>

నేను బియ్యం తీసుకుంటాను. — *nēnu biyyam tīsukunṭānu* — “I take rice.”

The letters in this word

తీ is the dental త (ta) with the long-ī sign — *tinu*’s letter, held longer. సు is స (sa) plus u; కో is *anukō*’s *kō*.

Grammar Lens: three verbs, one ending

the verb	what the -కో adds
<i>anukō</i>	say it — to yourself
<i>artham cēsukō</i>	make the meaning — yours
<i>tīsukō</i>	pull it out — for yourself

The respectful -అండి goes on this one too: తీసుకోండి (*tīsukōṇḍi*), “please take” — what a Telugu host says while pushing a dish towards you.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

కొను (*konu*) is still a verb on its own: “to take, to get, to buy.” Its cousins are exact — Tamil கொள் (*kol*) and Malayalam കൊള്ളുക (*kolḷuka*), both “to hold, to take.”

What those two did with it is the good part: they welded it onto the backs of other verbs as an ending, with the very meaning Telugu gives it. So the shape you learned two lessons ago is not a Telugu quirk. It is Dravidian machinery, and *tīsukō* is the verb it started from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tīyu ... *kō*” → “tīsukō”
- “nēnu nīḷḷu tīsukunṭānu” — then with “biyyam”, rice
- the three with the ending — “anukō ... artham cēsukō ... tīsukō”

- what a host says — “*t̥isukōṇḍi*”
- the cousins — “*konu ... kol ... kolḷuka*”

Before you move on

Take *t̥isukō* apart, say “I take water,” and name the other two verbs with that ending. (తీయు plus -కో; *nēnu n̄ḷḷu t̥isukunṭānu*; *anukō* and *artham cēsukō*.) Which verb did the ending come from, and which sisters have it? (కొను; Tamil *kol*, Malayalam *kolḷuka* — both use it as an ending too.) How do you offer someone food? (తీసుకోండి.)

34.2 అడుగు (*aḍugu*) — “to ask,” and the branch Telugu really sits on

T̥isukunṭānu — and its ending belonged to the whole family.
This next verb belongs to almost nobody.

You’ll want to know: అడుగు

అడుగు — *aḍugu* — to ask; to request

అడుగుతాను (*aḍugutānu*), “I ask”; అడిగాను (*aḍigānu*), “I asked”; అడగండి (*aḍagaṇḍi*), “please ask.” *aḍu-*, *aḍi-*, *aḍa-*: the middle vowel wanders as *caduvu*’s did, and the polite -అండి rides on unbothered.

One warning: Telugu has a **second** అడుగు, “a foot, a step” — same spelling, different root, nothing to do with asking.

The letters in this word

అ is the standing vowel *a*, as in *anukō*; డ is the retroflex డ (*ḍa*) plus *u*, the *ḍu* ending *cūḍu*; గు is గ (*ga*) plus *u*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The four literary sisters share no ask-verb: Tamil கேள் (*kēḷ*) and Kannada ಕೇಳು (*kēḷu*), which also mean “hear”; Malayalam ചോദിക്കുക (*cōdikkuka*); and Telugu అడుగు, which keeps hearing separate in విను (*vinu*). The Dravidian dictionary’s firmest match for *aḍugu* is in none of them: it is **Parji** *aḍ-*, a small language of central India.

That is the clue to something worth naming outright. **Telugu is not in the same branch as Tamil, Kannada and Malayalam.** Those three are **South Dravidian**; Telugu heads **South-Central Dravidian**, with Gondi, Konda, Kui, Kuvi, Pengo and Manda. So the pattern was no run of accidents: *lēdu* against the sisters' *il-*, *uṇḍu* against their *iru*, *enimidi* and *tommidi* where *eṭṭu* and *onpatu* will not reach.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

For the noun Telugu reaches for Sanskrit: ప్రశ్న (*praśna*), “a question,” from प्रच्छ (*prach*) — an Indo-European root, and the root of Latin *precārī*, which English took as **pray**. Native verb, borrowed noun: *tiṇḍi* and *bhōjanam*, a third time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three vowels — “aḍugutānu ... aḍigānu ... aḍagaṇḍi”
- the same wobble — “caduvutānu ... cadivānu ... cadavaṇḍi”
- four sisters, four verbs — “aḍugu ... kēḷ ... kēḷu ... cōdikkuka”
- Telugu’s own branch — “Gondi, Konda, Kui”
- what it explains — “lēdu ... uṇḍu ... enimidi, tommidi”
- the borrowed noun and its cousin — “praśna ... pray”

Before you move on

Say “I ask,” “I asked,” “please ask,” and name the other verb that wanders its middle vowel. (*Aḍugutānu*, *aḍigānu*, *aḍagaṇḍi*; చదువు.) Do the four literary sisters share an ask-verb? (**No** — *aḍugu*, *kēḷ*, *kēḷu*, *cōdikkuka*.) Which branch is Telugu on, who is on it, and name two things that explains. (**South-Central Dravidian**, with Gondi, Konda and Kui; *lēdu* against *il-*, *uṇḍu* against *iru*, *enimidi* and *tommidi*.) Where is *praśna* from? (**Sanskrit**, from the root behind English **pray**.)

34.3 సహాయం చేయు (sahāyaṁ cēyu) — “to help,” which is a going-together

Aḍagaṇḍi — please ask. Say it, and name where *prāsna* came from. The verb that answers is one Chapter 5 walked past.

You’ll want to know: సహాయం చేయు

సహాయం చేయు — *sahāyaṁ cēyu* — **to help**

Chapter 5 listed it once, as an example of what *cēyu* does with a noun in front. Take it properly now.

నేను మీకు సహాయం చేస్తాను. — *nēnu mīku sahāyaṁ cēstānu* — “I help you.”

The person helped goes in the **dative**: *mīku*, “to you,” Chapter 6’s -కు at ordinary work. Politely: సహాయం చేయండి (*sahāyaṁ cēyaṇḍi*). Speech shortens the noun to సాయం (*sāyaṁ*).

The letters in this word

స is *sa*; హ is హ (*ha*) with the long-ā sign; యం is య (*ya*) closed by the anusvāra.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

సహాయం is Sanskrit सहाय (*sahāya*), and it comes apart cleanly: सह (*saha*), “with,” plus आय (*āya*), “a going.” A helper is **one who goes with you**. Both halves are Indo-European — *saha* is the “one, together” root behind **same** and **similar**, and *āya* is the go-root Latin carries as *ire*, which English took whole in **exit** and **transit**.

The build is Chapter 8’s: a borrowed noun in front of the native చేయు, as దయచేసి was made from *daya*. Kannada and Malayalam borrowed *sahāya* too; **Tamil did not**, keeping its own உதவி (*udavi*) — yet for *please* all four reached for *daya*. Borrowing happens **word by word**.

Why it’s said this way

Dictionaries record సహాయం and సాయం side by side, *sāyaṁ* the shorter and more casual. What no source consulted here states is that *sāyaṁ* is a worn-down *sahāyaṁ*. It seems obvious. Obvious is not a citation.

Chapter 31 drew the same line over a greeting: two sources for “real and formal,” one for “less common,” kept apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nēnu mīku sahāyaṁ cēstānu” — I help you
- shorter, then polite — “sāyaṁ cēstānu ... sahāyaṁ cēyaṇḍi”
- the halves — “saha ... āya” — then “exit ... transit”
- two nouns, one verb — “daya cēsi ... sahāyaṁ cēyu”
- the sister that kept its own — “udavi”
- the chapter — “tīsukunṭānu, aḍugutānu, sahāyaṁ cēstānu”

Before you move on

Say “I help you,” name the case the helped person takes, and take *sahāya* apart. (*Nēnu mīku sahāyaṁ cēstānu*; the **dative** -కు; सह “with” plus आय “a going” — **exit** and **transit** carry the go-half.) Which other word is built on *cēyu* that way, and which sister kept its own? (దయచేసి; **Tamil**, with *udavi*.) What may you *not* say about *sāyaṁ*? (**That it comes from *sahāyaṁ*** — that derivation is not sourced here.)

34.4 నాకు తెలుగు ఇష్టం — “I like Telugu,” with no verb in it

Sahāyaṁ cēstānu — a going with somebody. Say it, then *tī-sukunṭānu*. This last sentence has no verb.

You’ll want to know: The sentence

నాకు తెలుగు ఇష్టం. *nāku telugu iṣṭaṁ*. — “to me — Telugu — a liking.”

ఇష్టం is a **noun**: “a liking, a wish,” and Telugu supplies no *is*, having never needed one. Only the front piece moves — *nāku, nīku, ataniki*. తెలుసు behaved so too: there the verb had no room for a person; here there is no verb.

The letters in this word

ఇ is the standing vowel *i*; ష్ట is the conjunct ష (*ṣa*) over ట (*ṭa*).

Grammar Lens: the fourth dative sentence, and two ways round it

Four sentences, one idea: *nāku telugu vaccu*, a **skill**; *nāku telusu*, a **fact**; *nāku arthamaṇḍi*, a meaning that **landed**; *nāku telugu iṣṭam*, a **taste**. Chapter 6’s dative subject was no curiosity: it is how Telugu files what happens **to** you.

A native verb does it too — నచ్చు (*naccu*), “to be pleasing”: నాకు ఇది నచ్చింది (*nāku idi naccindi*). Tamil நச்ச and Kannada ನಚ್ಚు are the same verb: *iṣṭam* displaced nothing.

One shape takes an ordinary subject: ఇష్టపడు (*iṣṭapaḍu*), నేను ఇష్టపడతాను — *iṣṭam* plus పడు (*paḍu*), “to fall,” Chapter 20’s verb in వర్షం పడుతోంది. Liking is something you **fall into**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ఇష్టం is Sanskrit इष्ट (*iṣṭa*), “desired,” from इष् (*iṣ*) — an Indo-European root whose English descendant is **ask**. So this chapter carried two asking-roots, not one: *prach* behind *pray*, *iṣ* behind *ask*. Telugu’s అడుగు is cousin to neither: its relatives are Gondi and Kui.

Spanish *me gusta*, Italian *mi piace*, Hindi *muḥe pasand hai*, Bengali *āmār bhālo lāge*, Tamil *enakkut tamil piḍikkum* — and now *nāku telugu iṣṭam*. **Six languages, three unrelated families, one design**, with Chapter 6’s Dravidian seam showing: **-ku, -ukku, -ge, -ikku**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*nāku telugu iṣṭam*” — “to me, Telugu, a liking”
- three likers — “*nāku ... nīku ... ataniki telugu iṣṭam*”

- the four datives — “vaccu ... telusu ... arthamaindi ... iṣṭam̐”
- native, then falling — “naccindi ... iṣṭapaḍatānu”
- the chapter — “tīsukunṭānu, aḍugutānu, cēstānu, iṣṭam̐”
- the endings — “-ku · -ukku · -ge · -ikku”

Before you move on

Say “I like Telugu,” say how many verbs it holds, and name the four datives. (*Nāku telugu iṣṭam̐*; **none**; *vaccu* a **skill**, *telusu* a **fact**, *arthamaindi* a **landing**, *iṣṭam̐* a **taste**.) Which native verb does the same job, and what hides inside *iṣṭapaḍu*? (నచ్చు; పడు, the falling of *varṣam̐ paḍutōndi*.) Which English word is *iṣṭam̐*’s cousin, and is it *praśna*’s? (**Ask**; **no**, that is **pray** — and **six** languages in **three** families build liking so.)

Chapter 35

Family and Friends

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my family as a group in Telugu and name a friend, and say which of the two words is a Sanskrit loan and which is Telugu’s own native word.

Say ఇది నా కుటుంబం and ఇతను నా స్నేహితుడు, trace కుటుంబం and స్నేహితుడు back to Sanskrit, and set స్నేహితుడు beside the native, DEDR-attested నేస్తం.

35.1 కుటుంబం (kuṭumbam) — “family,” the word the household words never needed

Nāku telugu iṣṭam closed the last chapter on a sentence built from nothing but nouns. This chapter opens on the plainest nouns of all: the words for the people you would actually say that sentence to.

You’ll want to know: కుటుంబం

కుటుంబం — *kuṭumbam* — family

ఇది నా కుటుంబం. — *idi nā kuṭumbam*. — “This is my family.”

నా, “my,” has been yours since one of the very first words you learned.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

కుటుంబం is Sanskrit कुटुम्ब (kuṭumba), “family, household,” carried into Telugu whole — the same kind of tatsama loan as నమస్కారం and సంతోషం.

Your earlier family-words lesson gave you six words: నాన్న, అమ్మ, and the four age-graded siblings అన్న/తమ్ముడు, అక్క/చెల్లి. Every one is native Dravidian, and not one of them means “family” — each names a single specific person. Telugu never inherited a plain word for the group itself, so when it needed one, it reached for Sanskrit. The people came first, and stayed native; the collective came later, and came borrowed — the same split you already met between *tinu* and *bhōjanam*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “idi nā kuṭumbam” — this is my family
- the six named people, then the borrowed group word — “nānna, amma, anna, tammudu, akka, celli ... kuṭumbam”
- “nāku telugu iṣṭam” — once more, no verb in it

Before you move on

Say “this is my family.” (*Idi nā kuṭumbam*.) Is *kuṭumbam* native Dravidian or a loan? (**A Sanskrit loan**, like *namaskāram* and *santōṣam*.) Name the six family words from that earlier lesson. (*Nānna, amma, anna, tammudu, akka, celli*.) Which of those six means “family” as a group? (**None of them** — that’s exactly the gap *kuṭumbam* fills.)

35.2 స్నేహితుడు (snēhituḍu) — “friend,” and the native word beside it

Kuṭumbam named the people you’re related to. This word names the people you choose.

You'll want to know: స్నేహితుడు

స్నేహితుడు — *snēhituḍu* — **friend** (male; స్నేహితురాలు, *snēhiturālu*, for a female friend)

ఇతను నా స్నేహితుడు. — *itanu nā snēhituḍu*. — “This is my friend.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

స్నేహితుడు is built on Sanskrit स्नेह (*sneha*), “affection, love” — the same kind of tatsama loan as *kuṭumbam* itself, plus a Telugu agentive ending. Telugu also has a **native** word for friendship: నేస్తం (*nēstam*), catalogued in the Dravidian Etymological Dictionary alongside the related forms *neyyamu*, *neyyami*, and *neyyari* — all clustered around friendship, love, and tenderness. *Nēstam* is real and still heard, but the everyday choice for “friend” is the borrowed one, *snēhituḍu* — the same pattern already found with *sahāyami cēyu*, where the everyday verb is built on a Sanskrit noun too.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “itanu nā snēhituḍu” — this is my friend
- the borrowed word and the native one — “snēhituḍu ... nēstam”
- family, then friend — “kuṭumbam ... snēhituḍu”

Before you move on

Say “this is my friend.” (*Itanu nā snēhituḍu*.) Is *snēhituḍu* native or borrowed? (**A Sanskrit loan**, from *sneha*, “affection.”) What is Telugu’s own native word for friendship, and is it the everyday choice? (నేస్తం, *nēstam* — real, but **not** the everyday choice; that’s the borrowed word.)

Chapter 36

Son and Daughter, Two Different Roots

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say son and daughter in Telugu, and show that they trace to two different Proto-Dravidian roots rather than one shared root.

Line up కొడుకు and కూతురు against their two separate Proto-Dravidian roots, trace కొడుకు's own root sideways to కోడలు (“daughter-in-law”), and trace కూతురు's root across the family to Kannada's word for infant.

36.1 కొడుకు (koḍuku) — “son,” and the unexpected word it shares a root with

Kuṭumbani, family; *snēhituḍu*, friend. Now the two words for your own children — and Telugu does not build them the tidy way you might expect.

You'll want to know: కొడుకు

కొడుకు — *koḍuku* — son

వాడి కొడుకు వయసెంత? — *vāḍi koḍuku vayasenta?* — “How old is his son?” — the verbless age question you already know, asked about someone else's child.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

కొడుకు is inherited from Proto-Dravidian ***kōz-**, “young, tender.” You might expect “daughter,” Telugu’s other child-word, to share that same root with a different ending — that is exactly the shape Kannada’s *magu/maga/ magalu* takes. Telugu does not do that. The very same ***kōz-** root instead gives Telugu కొడలు (*kōḍalu*), “daughter-in-law” — the woman a son marries, not the daughter a parent has. So *koḍuku* and *kōḍalu* are true cognates, one root apart; *koḍuku* and *kūturu* — son and daughter — are not related to each other at all. The next lesson takes up *kūturu*’s own, separate root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “koḍuku” — son
- “vāḍi koḍuku vayasenta?” — how old is his son?
- the unexpected cognate — “koḍuku ... kōḍalu” — son, daughter-in-law
- three words for people — “kuṭumbam ... snēhituḍu ... koḍuku”

Before you move on

Say “son.” (*Koḍuku.*) What Proto-Dravidian root does it come from, and what other Telugu word shares that exact root? (***kōz-**, “young, tender” — shared with కొడలు, “daughter-in-law,” not with “daughter” itself.) Ask “how old is his son?” (*Vāḍi koḍuku vayasenta?*)

36.2 కూతురు (*kūturu*) — “daughter,” on a root all its own

Koḍuku’s root turned up again inside a completely different Telugu word. This word’s root does something even less expected: it turns up inside a different **language**.

You'll want to know: కూతురు

కూతురు — *kūturu* — daughter

నా కూతురు. — *nā kūturu.* — “My daughter.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

కూతురు is inherited from Proto-Dravidian ***kūnttu** — a root with **no connection** to *koḍuku*'s ***kōḷ-**. Telugu's two child-words are not a matched pair; they are two separate inheritances that happen to sit side by side in the same sentence.

Kūturu's cousin is not in Telugu at all. Kannada ಕೂಸು (*kūsu*), “**infant, maiden**,” answers to the very same root. So the word a Telugu speaker uses for “my daughter” and the word a Kannada speaker uses for “the baby” are, underneath, one and the same — a reminder that a cognate does not have to keep the same *sense* as it crosses a language boundary, only the same root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*nā kūturu*” — my daughter
- son, then daughter — “*koḍuku ... kūturu*” — two unrelated roots
- the cross-language cousin — “*kūturu ... kūsu*” — daughter, infant
- friend, son, daughter — “*snēhituḍu ... koḍuku ... kūturu*”

Before you move on

Say “my daughter.” (*Nā kūturu.*) Does *kūturu* share a root with *koḍuku*? (**No** — two separate Proto-Dravidian roots.) What word in another Dravidian language answers to *kūturu*'s own root, and what does it mean there? (**Kannada ಕೂಸು *kūsu*, “infant, maiden.”**)

Chapter 37

Four Words on the Face

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my eye, ear, nose and mouth in Telugu, and say which three the family agrees on and which one Telugu's word does not obviously match.

Name కన్ను, చెవి, ముక్కు and నోరు; close the loop Chapter 32 left open on కన్ను; and say why నోరు, unlike the other three, shows no visible trace of the shared వాచ్య root Tamil, Malayalam and Kannada all carry.

37.1 కన్ను (kannu) — “eye,” a word you’ve already met once

Head and hand, taught earlier, gave you your first two body words. This chapter gives you four more — starting with one this book has secretly used before.

You’ll want to know: కన్ను

కన్ను — *kannu* — eye

నా కన్ను. — *nā kannu.* — “My eye.”

Three body words now, with two from that earlier lesson: *tala*, *ceyyi*, *kannu* — and *koḍuku*, “son,” still fresh, one lesson back.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

కన్ను already appeared earlier, inside the *cūḍu* lesson’s own etymology note for చూడు — as proof that Tamil *pār*, Kannada *nōḍu*, Malayalam *kāṇuka*, and Telugu *cūḍu*, four completely unrelated everyday see-verbs, all sit beside the very same ancient eye-word: Telugu *kannu*, Tamil *kaṇ*, Kannada *kaṇṇu*, Malayalam *kaṇṇ*. That chapter named the word without ever teaching it. This lesson closes the loop. Like *tala* (“head”) and *ceyyi* (“hand,” a cognate reshaped almost past recognition) before it, *kannu* is native Dravidian, and here the whole family agrees on it plainly — no reshaping required.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nā kannu” — my eye
- the four sisters’ shared eye — “kannu ... kaṇ ... kaṇṇu ... kaṇṇ”
- three body words — “tala ... ceyyi ... kannu”
- son, daughter, eye — “koḍuku ... kūturu ... kannu”

Before you move on

Say “my eye.” (*Nā kannu*.) Which earlier lesson already used this exact word, and what did it prove? (**The *cūḍu* lesson’s** etymology note — that all four Dravidian sisters share one eye-root behind four unrelated see-verbs.) Name the two body words from that earlier lesson. (తల, *tala*, and చెయ్యి, *ceyyi*.)

37.2 చెవి (cevi) — “ear,” matching Tamil almost letter for letter

Kannu matched its cousins closely but not exactly. This word matches even more closely.

You'll want to know: చెవి

చెవి — *cevi* — ear

నా చెవి. — *nā cevi.* — “My ear.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

చెవి is native Dravidian, and it answers Tamil செவி (*cevi*) almost syllable for syllable — a plainer, closer match than *kannu* found with Tamil *kaṇ* just one lesson ago. Two body words in a row, both native, both recognizably the same family — but “close cousin” is not “identical twin”: each word drifts by its own amount, and *cevi* simply happened to drift less.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nā cevi” — my ear
- the near-match — “cevi ... cevi”
- eye, then ear — “kannu ... cevi”
- daughter, then ear — “kūturu ... cevi”

Before you move on

Say “my ear.” (*Nā cevi.*) Which Dravidian cousin’s word for ear matches *cevi* most closely? (**Tamil** *cevi* — almost syllable for syllable.) Did *kannu* match its cousins that closely? (**Not quite** — one vowel apart from Tamil’s *kaṇ*.)

37.3 ముక్కు (mukku) — “nose,” an inherited word with a second word’s fingerprints on it

Eye and ear both descend cleanly from their Proto-Dravidian roots. This word descends too — but not quite cleanly.

You'll want to know: ముక్కు

ముక్కు — *mukku* — nose

నా ముక్కు. — *nā mukku.* — “My nose.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ముక్కు descends from Proto-Dravidian ***mūnk(k)u**, and it is a real cognate of Kannada *mūgu*, Malayalam *mūkkū*, and Tamil *mūkku*. But comparative Dravidian scholarship flags Telugu's own reflex as **irregular**: the consonant in the middle of the word is probably not a clean, regular descendant of **mūnk(k)u* alone. It looks contaminated by a separate Dravidian root, ***mok-**, “face” — as if two related words leaned on each other and left a mark. *Cevi* showed a word that drifted very little; *mukku* shows one that drifted in a specific, traceable way, nudged by its neighbour.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nā mukku” — my nose
- the cousins — “mukku ... mūgu ... mūkkū ... mūkku”
- three body words so far — “kannu ... cevi ... mukku”

Before you move on

Say “my nose.” (*Nā mukku.*) Is *mukku* a regular or an irregular reflex of its Proto-Dravidian root? (**Irregular** — likely contaminated by the separate root **mok-*, “face.”) Which two body words so far were plain, regular matches with their cousins? (కన్ను and చెవి.)

37.4 నోరు (nōru) — “mouth,” the word that breaks the chapter's pattern

Eye, ear, nose — three native words, three visible matches with the family, one plainer than the next. The fourth face word does not keep that streak going.

You'll want to know: నోరు

నోరు — *nōru* — **mouth**

నా నోరు. — *nā nōru.* — “My mouth.”

Four body words done: *kannu*, *cevi*, *mukku*, *nōru*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil and Malayalam both say **வாய்/vāyi** (*vāy*), “mouth,” and Kannada’s **ಬಾಯಿ** (*bāyi*) answers it through a regular sound law that turns a Tamil word-initial *v-* into Kannada *b-*. Three sisters, one shared root, one visible law.

నోరు does not obviously belong to that set. It shows no trace of *vāy*, and no source consulted here states what its own deeper Proto-Dravidian root actually is — so nothing is invented for it, the same discipline applied earlier to *vellu*’s own unresolved history. After three straight matches — *kannu* plain, *cevi* nearly exact, *mukku* traceably contaminated but still clearly related — *nōru* is the one face word where this book cannot show you the family resemblance, only note honestly that it is not there to show.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nā nōru” — my mouth
- the shared root Telugu sits outside of — “vāy ... bāyi ... nōru”
- all four face words — “kannu ... cevi ... mukku ... nōru”

Before you move on

Name all four face words. (కన్ను, చెవి, ముక్కు, నోరు.) Which three Dravidian sisters share one root and one sound law for “mouth,” and does Telugu’s word visibly belong with them? (**Tamil, Malayalam, and Kannada**, on *vāy*; **no** — *nōru* shows no trace of it, and its own root is not confirmed by any source consulted here.)

Chapter 38

The Heart, Two Ways

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my heart in Telugu two ways, the everyday native word and the literary Sanskrit loan, and trace the Sanskrit one to the same Proto-Indo-European root as the English word heart.

Say నా గుండె and నా హృదయం నీది, set the everyday native word beside the literary Sanskrit loan, and trace హృదయం to the same PIE root as English heart, Latin cor and Greek kardía.

38.1 గుండె (guṇḍe) — “heart,” the everyday native word

Four face words done, one of them an honest gap. This chapter gives you a fifth body word — and then, unusually, a second word for the very same thing.

You’ll want to know: గుండె

గుండె — *guṇḍe* — heart

నా గుండె. — *nā guṇḍe*. — “My heart.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

గుండె is inherited from Proto-Dravidian ***kuṇṭV**, and it is cognate with Kannada’s own native heart-word, గుಂಡిగి (*guṇḍige*) — plainly

the same root, wearing a different Telugu and Kannada shape. *Guṇḍe* is the plain, physical, everyday word: the organ beating in your chest. The next lesson gives Telugu's *other* word for heart — not a synonym so much as a different register entirely.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nā guṇḍe” — my heart
- the Kannada cognate — “guṇḍe ... guṇḍige”
- five body words — “kannu ... cevi ... mukku ... nōru ... guṇḍe”

Before you move on

Say “my heart.” (*Nā guṇḍe*.) Is *guṇḍe* native or borrowed? (**Native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian **kuṇṭV*.) Which language carries a matching native heart-word? (**Kannada**, *guṇḍige*.)

38.2 హృదయం (hṛdayam) — “heart,” and a genuine cousin of the English word

Guṇḍe is the heart beating in your chest. This word is the heart Telugu reaches for in a poem, a speech, or a love letter.

You’ll want to know: హృదయం

హృదయం — *hṛdayam* — **heart** (literary, emotional register)

నా హృదయం నీది. — *nā hṛdayam nīdi*. — “My heart is yours.”

The letters in this word

హృ is హ (*ha*) carrying the **vocalic-r vowel sign** ృ — the *dependent* form of the same vowel taught earlier as the *independent* letter ఋ, standing alone at the front of ఋతువు. Same vowel, two shapes: one when it opens a word, another when it rides on a consonant. దయం closes with the familiar అనుస్వారం.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

హృదయం is Sanskrit हृदय, built on हृद् (*hṛd*), “heart.” That Sanskrit root and the English word **heart** are not a coincidence of sound — both descend from the same reconstructed Proto-Indo-European root, ***kērd-**. Latin’s **cor** (genitive *cordis*, the source of English *cordial* and *courage*) and Greek’s **kardía** (behind *cardiac*) come from that exact same root. Four languages, one ancient word.

Telugu keeps *hṛdayam* beside native *gunḍe* the same way it keeps Sanskrit *bhōjanam* beside native *tinḍi*: the plain, physical word stays Dravidian; the word for ceremony, poetry, and feeling is layered on top from Sanskrit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nā hṛdayam nīdi” — my heart is yours
- the four cousins — “hṛd ... heart ... cor ... kardía”
- native, then literary — “gunḍe ... hṛdayam”
- all six body words now — “kannu ... cevi ... mukku ... nōru ... gunḍe ... hṛdayam”

Before you move on

Say “my heart is yours.” (*Nā hṛdayam nīdi.*) Is *hṛdayam* a real Indo-European cousin of English “heart,” or just a coincidence of sound? (**A real cousin** — both from PIE **kērd-*, alongside Latin *cor* and Greek *kardía*.) Which is the everyday, physical word for heart, and which is literary? (గుండె everyday; హృదయం literary.)

Chapter 39

Tea and Milk, Two Roads

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can politely ask for tea or milk in Telugu, and say which word travelled by sea and which one three Dravidian cousins share under one regular sound law.

Ask దయచేసి టీ and దయచేసి పాలు, follow టీ along its sea route through Hokkien and Malay against the overland chai route, then place పాలు beside Tamil and Malayalam’s matching pāl against Kannada’s own p-to-h shift.

39.1 దయచేసి టీ (dayacēsi ṭī) — “tea, please,” a word that sailed rather than walked

Two ways to say heart, done. దయచేసి — please, taught earlier — is about to earn its keep again, in front of the drink you’d politely ask for first.

You’ll want to know: టీ

టి — ṭī — tea

దయచేసి టీ. — dayacēsi ṭī. — “Tea, please.”

Day to day, Telugu politeness usually rides on the -అండి verb ending already named as the everyday carrier — but a bare request for a drink, with no verb at all, is exactly where దయచేసి itself does the work instead.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

తీ is a direct loan from English **tea**. English’s own word traces to **Hokkien** (Southern Min Chinese) **tê**, carried west by Dutch and English sea trade through **Malay** *teh* and into Europe — the **sea** route.

That is the opposite road from the word most of Telugu’s neighbours use. Hindi, Kannada, and Marathi all say some form of **chai**, which travelled **overland**: Mandarin **chá**, into Persian چای (*chāy*), and from Persian into North and South India alike. One drink, two Chinese dialects, two trade routes, two families of words — and Telugu’s coastal contact with English trade left it holding the sea-word, **తి**, where its landlocked neighbours picked up the land-word instead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dayacēsi **తి**” — tea, please
- the sea route — “tê ... teh ... tea ... **తి**”
- the land route it is not — “chá ... chāy ... **chai**”

Before you move on

Say “tea, please.” (*Dayacēsi **తి***.) Did **తి** travel by land or by sea, and through which languages? (**By sea** — Hokkien *tê*, Malay *teh*, English *tea*.) Which word, common in Hindi, Kannada, and Marathi, took the overland road instead, and through which languages? (**Chai** — Mandarin *chá*, Persian *chāy*.)

39.2 పాలు (pālu) — “milk,” where Kannada is the odd one out, not Telugu

తి showed Telugu going its own way against most of its neighbours. This word shows the opposite: Telugu sits with the majority, and one cousin stands alone.

You'll want to know: ಪಾಲು

ಪಾಲು — *pālu* — milk

ದಯವೇಸಿ ಪಾಲು. — *dayacēsi pālu.* — “Milk, please.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ಪಾಲು descends, unchanged, from Proto-Dravidian ***pāl** — matching Tamil பால் (*pāl*) and Malayalam പാൽ (*pāl*) exactly. Kannada alone says ಹಾಲು (*hālu*), because Kannada carries a **regular sound law** that turns a word-initial Dravidian *p*- into *h*-: the same law that turns Tamil பத்து (*pattu*, “ten”) into Kannada ಹತ್ತು (*hattu*). Telugu, Tamil, and Malayalam all keep the original *p*-; only Kannada shifted it. So the pattern this chapter has been building — Telugu sometimes matching its neighbours, sometimes standing apart — flips one more time: here it is **Kannada** standing apart, not Telugu.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dayacēsi pālu” — milk, please
- the three that match — “pālu ... pāl ... pāl”
- the one that shifted — “pālu ... hālu”
- tea, then milk — “ṭī ... pālu”

Before you move on

Say “milk, please.” (*Dayacēsi pālu.*) Which three Dravidian languages keep the original *p*- in “milk,” and which one shifts it to *h*-? (**Telugu, Tamil, and Malayalam** keep *p*-; **Kannada** alone shifts to *h*-, *hālu*.) Name one other word pair that shows the same Kannada sound law. (**Tamil pattu, Kannada hattu** — “ten.”)

Chapter 40

A Meal

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I am having a meal in Telugu, using the word an earlier chapter already used and never explained.

Say భోజనం చేద్దాం, explain భోజనం against everyday తిండి the way Chapter 32 first set them side by side, and apologise for a late meal with Chapter 9's క్షమించండి.

40.1 భోజనం (bhōjanam) — “a meal,” a word this book named before it ever taught it

Tea, then milk. This chapter’s last word is not a drink — it is the meal you would sit down to with both.

You’ll want to know: భోజనం

భోజనం — *bhōjanam* — a meal

భోజనం చేద్దాం. — *bhōjanam cēddām*. — “Let’s eat” (literally, “let’s do a meal”).

The *tinu* lesson already used this exact word, in passing, as the polite counterpart of native తిండి — without ever teaching it properly. This lesson finally does.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

భోజనం is Sanskrit भोजन, built on भुज् (*bhuj*), “to enjoy, to partake of, to eat.” It sits above native తిండి the same way దయచేసి sits above the everyday -అండి ending: a formal Sanskrit layer over a plain Dravidian floor. కన్ను, “eye,” was a word this book had already used once, unglossed, inside an etymology note — this lesson does the very same thing for భోజనం, which was named earlier without ever being taught. If a meal runs late, Telugu reaches for the apology word taught earlier: భోజనం ఆలస్యం అయింది, క్షమించండి — “the meal is late, sorry” — the same respectful -అండి ending that first met you on దయచేసి’s own everyday alternative.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhōjanam cēddām” — let’s eat
- native, then borrowed — “tiṇḍi ... bhōjanam”
- the apology — “bhōjanam ālasyam ayindi, kṣamiṇcaṇḍi”
- the chapter — “tī ... pālu ... bhōjanam”

Before you move on

Say “let’s eat.” (*Bhōjanam cēddām.*) Which earlier lesson already used *bhōjanam*, without teaching it as its own word? (**The *tīnu* lesson.**) Apologise for a late meal, using the word you learned earlier. (*Bhōjanam ālasyam ayindi, kṣamiṇcaṇḍi.*)

Chapter 41

Pointing, and Asking

Modes: 🗣️ voice (7) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can point at something in Telugu and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.*

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

41.1 ఇది (idi) — this one — the thing near me

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You’ll want to know: ఇది

ఇది — *idi* — this one — the thing near me.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is అది *adi*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **i-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ఇది” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *idi*? (this one — the thing near me.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**i-** — near.)

41.2 అది (adi) — that one — the thing over there

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: అది

అది — *adi* — that one — the thing over there.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is ఇది *idi*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **a-** for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “అది” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *adi*? (that one — the thing over there.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**a-** — far.)

41.3 ఇక్కడ (ikkaḍa) — here — where I am

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: ఇక్కడ

ఇక్కడ — *ikkada* — here — where I am.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is అక్కడ *akkaḍa*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **i-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ఇక్కడ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *ikkada*? (here — where I am.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**i-** — near.)

41.4 అక్కడ (akkaḍa) — there — where I am not

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: అక్కడ

అక్కడ — *akkaḍa* — there — where I am not.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is ఇక్కడ *ikkada*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **a-** for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “అక్కడ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *akkada*? (there — where I am not.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (a- — far.)

41.5 ఎవరు (evaru) — who? — asking about a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You’ll want to know: ఎవరు

ఎవరు — *evaru* — who? — asking about a person.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is ఎక్కడ *ekkada*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — e- for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ఎవరు” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *evaru*? (who? — asking about a person.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (e-

— ask.)

41.6 ఎక్కడ (ekkaḍa) — where? — asking about a place

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: ఎక్కడ

ఎక్కడ — *ekkaḍa* — where? — asking about a place.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is ఎవరు *evuru*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **e-** for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ఎక్కడ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *ekkaḍa*? (where? — asking about a place.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**e-** — ask.)

41.7 i- / a- / e- — six words, one machine

Say the six words from this chapter out loud, in order. Listen to how they begin.

Grammar lens: one slot changes

You did not learn six words. You learned **three beginnings** and reused them.

meaning	word
near	ఇక్కడ <i>ikkaḍa</i>
far	అక్కడ <i>akkaḍa</i>
question	ఎక్కడ <i>ekkaḍa</i>

Telugu keeps the whole tail identical: ఇక్కడ, అక్కడ, ఎక్కడ — only the first vowel moves.

Change the front, and the meaning walks from **near** to **far** to a **question**. Nothing else in the word moves.

The same three beginnings run the thing-words too: ఇది *idi* and అది *adi* start exactly like the first two rows. This chapter did not teach you the matching question word for things — that one arrives later, and when it does you will already know what it has to start with.

This is worth more than the six words are. When you meet a new word in this family later, you will not have to be taught all three of it — you will be taught one and work out the others.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the near word, then the far word, then the question word
- *Say it*: them again for place, not for things
- *Notice*: the part that did NOT change

Before you move on

Which beginning means near? (**i-**) Far? (**a-**) And which one turns the word into a question? (**e-**)

Chapter 42

Describing Things

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something in Telugu and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

42.1 పెద్ద (pedda) — big

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: పెద్ద

పెద్ద — *pedda* — big.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “పెద్ద” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *pedda*? (**big.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.2 చిన్న (cinna) — small

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: చిన్న

చిన్న — *cinna* — small.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met పెద్ద *pedda* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “చిన్న” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *cinna*? (**small.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.3 మంచి (manci) — good

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: మంచి

మంచి — *manci* — good.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met చిన్న *cinna* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “మంచి” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *manci*? (**good.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.4 కొత్త (kotta) — new

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: కొత్త

కొత్త — *kotta* — new.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met మంచి *manci* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “కొత్త” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *kotta*? (**new.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.5 పాత (pāta) — old — of a thing, not of a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: పాత

పాత — *pāta* — old — of a thing, not of a person.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met కొత్త *kotta* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “పాత” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *pāta*? (**old — of a thing, not of a person.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.6 before the noun, unchanged — five words, one rule

Say the five words from this chapter out loud, then say each one in front of a noun you already know.

Grammar lens: where an adjective goes

You did not learn five separate words. You learned **where an adjective goes**, and five words that go there.

meaning	word
big	పెద్ద <i>pedda</i>
small	చిన్న <i>cinna</i>
good	మంచి <i>manci</i>

They sit in front of the noun and stay exactly as they are.

This is worth more than the five words are. Every noun you already know — your name, the house, the water, the day — can now take any of them in front, and every adjective you meet from here goes in the same place.

Your turn

- *Say it*: each of the five in front of a noun you already know
- *Say it*: two of them with the same noun, one after the other
- *Notice*: whether the adjective changed shape when the noun did

Before you move on

Where does an adjective go in this language? (**In front of the noun.**) Does it change shape to match the noun? (unchanged.)

The Telugu script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** క = ka, మ = ma, ర = ra. (Many wear the *talakaṭṭu*, a small check-mark hat.)
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** కా = k̄ā, కి = k̄i, కీ = k̄ī, కు = k̄u, కూ = k̄ū, కె = k̄e, కే = k̄ē, కో = k̄o, కో = k̄ō.
3. **A *virama* strips the vowel, and the bare consonant *stacks below the next* as a conjunct.** స + క → స్క (ska), న + య → న్య (nya). A dot **anusvāra** ం adds a final nasal.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

అ a · ఆ ā · ఇ i · ఈ ī · ఉ u · ఊ ū · ఎ e · ఏ ē · ఐ ai · ఒ o · ఓ ō · ఔ au.

Worth flagging

- **Aspiration is written.** క k / ఖ kh, ద d / ధ dh — the “h” is a real puff. Like Kannada (and unlike Tamil), Telugu keeps the Sanskrit aspirates and voiced stops as separate letters, because it borrowed so many Sanskrit words.
- **Round, looping forms.** Telugu and Kannada are script-sisters, shaped for palm-leaf writing; the two look far more like each other than like Tamil.

Telugu in the Dravidian family

Dravidian is a family entirely separate from Indo-European (English, Latin, Sanskrit). Telugu shares grammar and native vocabulary with Tamil, Kannada, and Malayalam — but, like Kannada and unlike Tamil, it borrowed *heavily* from Sanskrit. It also shows the family is not uniform: where its sisters say “no” with a word from the root *il-*, Telugu uses its own *lēdu* / *kādu*. The lessons trace, word by word, what is home-grown and what is borrowed.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

-కు *-ku*

the dative suffix -ku, 'to / for' — and the idea of stacking
Introduced in Chapter 6.

అది *adi*

that one — the thing over there
Introduced in Chapter 41.

అడుగు *aḍugu*

to ask — a native verb none of the three literary sisters share, and the clue to which branch of Dravidian Telugu actually sits on
Introduced in Chapter 34.

ఆకాశం *ākāśam*

the sky
Introduced in Chapter 53.

అక్కడ *akkaḍa*

there — where I am not
Introduced in Chapter 41.

అలాగే *alāgē*

just so, alright then
Introduced in Chapter 49.

ఆలకించు *ālakiñcu*

listen
Introduced in Chapter 44.

అమ్మమ్మ *ammamma*

grandmother, the mother's mother
Introduced in Chapter 45.

అంతే *antē*

that's all; that's just it
Introduced in Chapter 58.

అనుకో *anukō*

to think — literally “say it to yourself”, built from the family’s say-verb plus the ending that turns a verb back on its own doer
Introduced in Chapter 33.

అర్థం చేసుకో *arthamī cēsukō*

to understand — “make the meaning your own”, a Sanskrit noun on the native do-verb with the ending that hands the action back to you
Introduced in Chapter 33.

ఆశీర్వాదం *āśīrvādamī*

a blessing
Introduced in Chapter 51.

అతిథి *atithi*

a guest
Introduced in Chapter 48.

అవును *avunu*

yes (avumu)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

బాగా *bāgā*

well, fine — and the reply “నేను బాగున్నాను”
Introduced in Chapter 3.

బాట *bāṭa*

a path, a way
Introduced in Chapter 55.

బట్ట *baṭṭa*

cloth
Introduced in Chapter 46.

బయలుదేరు *bayaludēru*

to set out, to start off
Introduced in Chapter 50.

భర్త *bhartā*

husband
Introduced in Chapter 45.

భార్య *bhāryā*

wife
Introduced in Chapter 45.

భోజనం *bhōjanamī*

a meal — the polite Sanskrit noun Chapter 32 already named and never taught, finally given its own lesson
Introduced in Chapter 40.

బురద *burada*

mud
Introduced in Chapter 59.

బుట్ట *buṭṭa*

a basket

Introduced in Chapter 56.

చదువు *caduvu*

to read — and, with no second word, to study; the same form is the noun for an education, and its middle vowel moves as the endings change

Introduced in Chapter 33.

చాలు *cālu*

enough, that will do

Introduced in Chapter 49.

చంద్రుడు *candruḍu*

the moon

Introduced in Chapter 53.

చాప *cāpa*

a mat

Introduced in Chapter 56.

చెరువు *ceruvu*

a village tank, a reservoir

Introduced in Chapter 55.

చెట్టు *ceṭṭu*

a tree

Introduced in Chapter 54.

చెవి *cevi*

ear — native Dravidian, matching Tamil's own form closely

Introduced in Chapter 37.

చిన్న *cinna*

small

Introduced in Chapter 42.

చూడు *cūḍu*

look

Introduced in Chapter 44.

చూడు *cūḍu*

to see, to look — Telugu's own everyday see-word, and the respectful -అండి ending that fits any verb stem

Introduced in Chapter 32.

చుక్క *cukka*

a star; a dot

Introduced in Chapter 53.

దండం *daṇḍam*

a salutation, "my respects"

Introduced in Chapter 51.

దయచేసి *dayacēsi*

please (dayacēsi — “having done compassion,” from దయ *daya* “compassion”)
Introduced in Chapter 8.

దయచేసి టీ *dayacēsi tī*

tea, please — Telugu’s traditional word for tea travelled by sea, not by the
overland road most of its neighbours took
Introduced in Chapter 39.

ధన్యవాదములు *dhanyavādamulu*

thank you (dhanyavādamulu — “utterances of ‘worthy’”)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

దీపం *dīpam*

a lamp
Introduced in Chapter 46.

ఎక్కడ *ekkaḍa*

where? — asking about a place
Introduced in Chapter 41.

ఎక్కువ *ekkuva*

more, a great deal
Introduced in Chapter 58.

ఎల్లుండి *elluṇḍi*

the day after tomorrow
Introduced in Chapter 50.

ఏమిటి *ēmiti*

what
Introduced in Chapter 2.

ఏమో *ēmō*

perhaps, who knows
Introduced in Chapter 49.

ఎముక *emuka*

a bone
Introduced in Chapter 57.

ఎవరు *evaru*

who? — asking about a person
Introduced in Chapter 41.

గాలి *gāli*

wind, air
Introduced in Chapter 59.

గంట *ganṭa*

hour — matching Kannada and Hindi exactly, the same Sanskrit “bell” word
Introduced in Chapter 18.

గౌరవం *gauravam*

respect

Introduced in Chapter 51.

గిన్నె *ginne*

a cooking vessel, a bowl

Introduced in Chapter 56.

గోరు *gōru*

a fingernail, a claw

Introduced in Chapter 57.

గ్రామం *grāmam*

a village

Introduced in Chapter 55.

గుండె *gunde*

heart — the everyday native Dravidian word, cognate with Kannada's own native heart-word

Introduced in Chapter 38.

గురువు *guruvu*

a teacher

Introduced in Chapter 48.

గుట్ట *gutṭa*

a low hill

Introduced in Chapter 55.

హృదయం *hṛdayam*

heart — the literary Sanskrit word for the same organ, a genuine Indo-European cousin of English “heart”

Introduced in Chapter 38.

ఇది *idi*

this one — the thing near me

Introduced in Chapter 41.

ఇక్కడ *ikkada*

here — where I am

Introduced in Chapter 41.

ఇప్పుడు *ippuḍu*

now

Introduced in Chapter 50.

ఇసుక *isuka*

sand

Introduced in Chapter 59.

ఇవ్వు *ivvu*

give

Introduced in Chapter 43.

జాట్టు *juṭṭu*

hair (of the head)

Introduced in Chapter 47.

కడుపు *kaḍupu*

the stomach, the belly

Introduced in Chapter 47.

కాలు *kālu*

leg, foot

Introduced in Chapter 47.

కన్ను *kannu*

eye — a word this book has already used once, unglossed, as proof of the family's shared oldest seeing-root

Introduced in Chapter 37.

కత్తి *katti*

a knife

Introduced in Chapter 56.

కొడుకు *koḍuku*

son — a native Dravidian root that shares its shape with a word already met in this book, and not with the next lesson's word for daughter

Introduced in Chapter 36.

కొమ్మ *komma*

a branch

Introduced in Chapter 54.

కొంచెం *koñcem*

a little, a bit

Introduced in Chapter 58.

కొత్త *kotta*

new

Introduced in Chapter 42.

కృతజ్ఞత *kṛtajñata*

gratitude

Introduced in Chapter 51.

కుర్చీ *kurcī*

a chair

Introduced in Chapter 52.

కూర్చో *kūrcō*

sit

Introduced in Chapter 43.

కుటుంబం *kuṭumbam*

family — the collective word Chapter 12's parents and siblings never needed, because each of them was already the name of one specific person

Introduced in Chapter 35.

కూతురు *kūturu*

daughter — a second, separate Proto-Dravidian root, cognate across the family with a word for “infant” rather than with Telugu’s own word for son
Introduced in Chapter 36.

లేదు *lēdu*

no / there isn’t (*lēdu*)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

మబ్బు *mabbu*

a cloud
Introduced in Chapter 53.

మధ్యాహ్నం *madhyāhnam*

“afternoon” — the same word already met meaning precisely “noon” (TE-C17), confirmed via a directly-fetched source to also cover “the time between noon and evening” in modern usage — the same kind of semantic widening already found for Hindi’s दोपहर and, more thinly, Kannada’s ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ
Introduced in Chapter 28.

మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం *maḷḷi kaluddām*

we’ll meet again
Introduced in Chapter 4.

మంచి *manči*

good
Introduced in Chapter 42.

మంచు *mañcu*

mist, dew, snow
Introduced in Chapter 59.

మాట్లాడు *māṭlāḍu*

speak
Introduced in Chapter 44.

మాట్లాడు *māṭlāḍu*

to speak
Introduced in Chapter 5.

మెడ *meḍa*

the neck
Introduced in Chapter 57.

మేలు *mēlu*

a good turn, a benefit
Introduced in Chapter 51.

మొక్క *mokka*

a young plant
Introduced in Chapter 54.

ముగ్గు *muggu*

the rice-flour design drawn at the doorstep

Introduced in Chapter 52.

ముక్కు *mukku*

nose — native Dravidian, but an irregular reflex of its own Proto-Dravidian root, contaminated in shape by the separate word for “face”

Introduced in Chapter 37.

నా *nā*

my

Introduced in Chapter 2.

నది *nadi*

a river

Introduced in Chapter 55.

నాకు తెలుగు ఇష్టం *nāku telugu iṣṭam*

‘I like Telugu’ — a sentence with no verb in it at all, the liker in the dative and the liked thing left standing plain

Introduced in Chapter 34.

నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు *nāku telugu vaccu*

‘I know Telugu’ — literally ‘to me Telugu comes’, with no subject at all

Introduced in Chapter 6.

నమస్కారం *namaskāram*

hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

నేను *nēnu*

I

Introduced in Chapter 3.

నీ వయసెంత? *nī vayasenta*

how old are you? — literally “your age how-much?”, matching Kannada’s simple verbless possessive exactly

Introduced in Chapter 19.

నిజం *nijam*

true; the truth

Introduced in Chapter 49.

నిల్చి *nilcō*

stand

Introduced in Chapter 43.

నిప్పు *nippu*

fire, a live coal

Introduced in Chapter 59.

నోరు *nōru*

mouth — the one face-word where Telugu does not obviously match the root its three sisters all share

Introduced in Chapter 37.

నువ్వు / మీరు *nuvvu / mīru*

you (familiar / respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ఒకటి రెండు మూడు నాలుగు ఐదు *okaṭi reṇḍu mūdū nālugu aidu*

one to five — the Dravidian family numbers, with Telugu’s maverick “one”

Introduced in Chapter 7.

పచ్చ, పసుపు *pacca pasupu*

green and yellow — a genuine Telugu doublet pair, both from the same

Proto-Dravidian *pac-* root, unlike Kannada, where the yellow word broke away as a Sanskrit loan

Introduced in Chapter 22.

పదకొండు — ఇరవై *padakoṇḍu — iravai*

11-20 — additive “ten-echo” compounds for the teens; ఇరవై (20) most likely continues the SAME pan-Dravidian “two-tens” pattern as Kannada’s *ippattu*, though worn down further and less transparent on the surface today

Introduced in Chapter 20.

పాలు *pālu*

milk — the same Proto-Dravidian word the whole family shares, with Telugu on the majority side of a regular Kannada sound law

Introduced in Chapter 39.

పండు *paṇḍu*

a fruit

Introduced in Chapter 46.

పని చేయు *pani cēyu*

to work (lit. “work-do”)

Introduced in Chapter 5.

పన్ను *pannu*

a tooth

Introduced in Chapter 47.

పరవాలేదు *paravālēdu*

it’s okay / no problem / you’re welcome

Introduced in Chapter 3.

పాత *pāta*

old — of a thing, not of a person

Introduced in Chapter 42.

పెదవి *pedavi*

a lip

Introduced in Chapter 57.

పెద్ద *pedda*

big

Introduced in Chapter 42.

పేరు *pēru*

name

Introduced in Chapter 2.

పెట్టె *peṭṭe*

a box

Introduced in Chapter 56.

ప్రయాణం *prayāṇam*

a journey

Introduced in Chapter 50.

పూలదండ *pūladanḍa*

a flower garland

Introduced in Chapter 52.

పుస్తకం *pustakam*

a book

Introduced in Chapter 46.

పువ్వు *puvvu*

a flower

Introduced in Chapter 52.

రా *rā*

come

Introduced in Chapter 43.

రా *rā*

to come — the command is రా, but every ending attaches to వచ్చు instead

Introduced in Chapter 32.

రైతు *raitu*

a farmer

Introduced in Chapter 48.

రాత్రి *rātri*

“night” — the same Sanskrit tatsama word already hiding inside ardharātri;

unlike day’s Persian surprise, night genuinely follows the

Sanskrit-tatsama-as-everyday pattern, matching Kannada

Introduced in Chapter 24.

రాయి *rāyi*

write

Introduced in Chapter 44.

రాయు *rāyu*

to write — an old Dravidian word for drawing a line, still spelled వ్రాయు in books,
and the chapter’s fourth mind-verb

Introduced in Chapter 33.

రేపు కలుద్దాం *rēpu kaluddām*

see you tomorrow

Introduced in Chapter 4.

రోజు *rōju*

“day” — a genuine surprise: Telugu’s everyday word isn’t Sanskrit or native Dravidian at all, it’s a Persian loanword; దినము, the Sanskrit tatsama form, is the more formal alternate here — the mirror image of Kannada’s pattern
Introduced in Chapter 23.

సహాయం చేయు *sahāyam cēyu*

to help — a Sanskrit noun on the native do-verb, and the noun takes apart into “a going with somebody”
Introduced in Chapter 34.

సరే *sarē*

okay / alright (sarē)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

సాయంత్రం *sāyantram*

“evening” (sāyantram) — Sanskrit tatsama from సాయం (sāyam, “in the evening”) + a “-tana” time-adjective suffix; సాయం itself traces to PIE *seh₁-* (“long, lasting”), the SAME root as Latin’s *sērus* — attested as the root of French *soir* and Italian *sera* — a genuine distant cognate across two completely different Indo-European branches
Introduced in Chapter 27.

స్నేహితుడు *snēhitudu*

friend — the everyday Sanskrit-derived word, with Telugu’s own DEDR-attested alternative named beside it
Introduced in Chapter 35.

శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం *śubha madhyāhnam*

“good afternoon” (śubha madhyāhnam), built on the widened “noon” word rather than the classical later-afternoon term
Introduced in Chapter 31.

శుభ రాత్రి *śubha rātri*

“good night” — the standard Sanskrit-tatsama translation (rātri already met, śubha new); some sources describe everyday speakers often code-switching to English “good night” instead
Introduced in Chapter 25.

శుభ సాయంత్రం *śubha sāyantram*

“good evening” (śubha sāyantram) — pairs with సాయంత్రం (TE-C27, the word with the striking Latin *sērus*/French *soir* cognate); unlike GREETING-MORNING’s single, dramatic “displaced by English” source, TWO independently-fetched sources agree this one is genuinely, commonly used in both formal and casual speech, with నమస్కారం as a time-independent alternative rather than a replacement
Introduced in Chapter 30.

శుభోదయం *śubhodayam*

“good morning” (subhodayam) — శుభ + ఉదయం, the traditional phrase; one directly-fetched source (a Telugu-learning blog, the same low-authority genre already found overstated for Hindi/Kannada) claims it’s archaic, displaced by English “good morning” — treat with real skepticism, not as confirmed; నమస్కారం remains a safer everyday-greeting bet regardless
Introduced in Chapter 29.

సూర్యుడు *sūryuḍu*

the sun

Introduced in Chapter 53.

తక్కువ *takkuva*

less, too little

Introduced in Chapter 58.

తల చెయ్యి *tala ceyyi*

head (matching its cousins) and hand (the SAME Dravidian root as the others, transformed almost past recognition)

Introduced in Chapter 13.

తలుపు *talupu*

a door

Introduced in Chapter 52.

తప్పకుండా *tappakuṇḍā*

certainly, without fail

Introduced in Chapter 49.

తాత *tāta*

grandfather

Introduced in Chapter 45.

తెలుసు *telusu*

it is known — the verb that carries no person at all, so the knower rides in the dative

Introduced in Chapter 32.

తిను *tinu*

to eat — the inherited Dravidian root Telugu kept as its plain everyday verb, with the mealtime nouns borrowed from Sanskrit

Introduced in Chapter 32.

తీసుకో *tīsukō*

to take — తీయు, “to pull out”, wearing the same -కో as the last chapter’s two mind-verbs, so taking is pulling something out for yourself

Introduced in Chapter 34.

ఉదయం *udayam*

“morning” (udayam) — Sanskrit tatsama from udaya (“rise”) + Telugu -mu, Telugu’s most general everyday word, though genuine native competitors (poddu/podduna, vēkuva) also do real everyday work; unlike Kannada, where the same Sanskrit root (udaya) shows up ONLY inside the greeting śubhōdaya, Telugu’s everyday noun and its greeting-root are the SAME word
Introduced in Chapter 26.

ఉండు *unḍu*

to be, to exist, to stay — and the negative Telugu has to fetch from a different verb
Introduced in Chapter 32.

ఉండు *unḍu*

to be, to stay, to live
Introduced in Chapter 5.

ఉప్పు *uppu*

salt
Introduced in Chapter 46.

వద్దు *vaddu*

no, I don’t want it
Introduced in Chapter 58.

వైద్యుడు *vaidyudu*

a doctor, a physician
Introduced in Chapter 48.

వాతావరణం *vātāvaraṇam*

weather/atmosphere — a PURE Sanskrit compound, unlike Kannada’s Persian+Sanskrit hybrid: vata (“air/wind”) + avarana (“covering”)
Introduced in Chapter 20.

వెళ్లి వస్తాను *velli vastānu*

goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
Introduced in Chapter 4.

వెళ్ళొస్తాను *vellostānu*

I’ll go and come back — the everyday goodbye
Introduced in Chapter 50.

వెళ్ళు *vellu*

to go (and వచ్చు, to come)
Introduced in Chapter 4.

వెళ్ళు *vellu*

to go — with one tense-piece covering both “I go” and “I will go”, and “right now” built out of the be-verb
Introduced in Chapter 32.

వేలు *vēlu*

a finger
Introduced in Chapter 47.

వేరు *vēru*

a root

Introduced in Chapter 54.

విద్యార్థి *vidyārthi*

a student

Introduced in Chapter 48.

వీపు *vīpu*

the back

Introduced in Chapter 57.

విత్తనం *vittanam*

a seed

Introduced in Chapter 54.

ఆరు ఏడు ఎనిమిది తొమ్మిది పది

six to ten — where Telugu wanders furthest from its Dravidian cousins

Introduced in Chapter 7.

ఎలా

how

Introduced in Chapter 3.

కుక్క, పిల్లి

dog and cat — kukka genuinely breaks from its Dravidian cousins' shared naayi root, debated as onomatopoeic or a Sanskrit loan; pilli most likely closes the ENTIRE arc's cat-story loop, the probable Dravidian source behind Sanskrit's biDaala and so Hindi's billi

Introduced in Chapter 21.

క్షమించండి

please forgive / sorry (kṣamiṇcaṇḍi — from kṣamiṇcu “to forgive,” Sanskrit kṣamā + respectful -aṇḍi)

Introduced in Chapter 9.

చైత్రం వైశాఖం జ్యేష్ఠం ఆషాఢం శ్రావణం భాద్రపదం ఆశ్వయుజం కార్తీకం మార్గశిరం

పుష్యం మాఘం ఫాల్గుణం

the twelve lunisolar months — matching Kannada and Hindi's shared pan-Indian calendar, completing the split with Tamil/Malayalam's own solar systems

Introduced in Chapter 16.

నా పేరు ...

my name is... (with no “is”)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను

I speak Telugu

Introduced in Chapter 5.

నాన్న అమ్మ అన్న తమ్ముడు అక్క చెల్లి

father, mother, and four age-graded sibling words — Telugu's own father-word and “younger sister” word, but the same age-first system

Introduced in Chapter 12.

నలుపు తెలుపు ఎరుపు నీలం

black, white, red, blue — Telugu’s own basic colors, completing the whole family’s shared blue

Introduced in Chapter 11.

నీళ్ళు బియ్యం అన్నం

water (matching Tamil/Kannada’s neer/niiru), and rice raw/cooked — completing the family’s water and rice pattern

Introduced in Chapter 15.

మీ పేరు ఏమిటి?

what’s your name?

Introduced in Chapter 2.

మధ్యాహ్నం అర్ధరాత్రి

noon (Sanskrit “middle of day,” same as Kannada) and midnight (Sanskrit “HALF of night” — a different root than Kannada’s midnight word)

Introduced in Chapter 17.

మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు?

how are you? (respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

వసంత ఋతువు వేసవి వానాకాలం శీతాకాలం

spring, summer, monsoon, winter — completing the Dravidian pattern of native heat/rain words plus Sanskrit spring

Introduced in Chapter 14.

సంతోషం

joy / pleased to meet you

Introduced in Chapter 2.

సోమవారం మంగళవారం బుధవారం గురువారం శుక్రవారం శనివారం ఆదివారం

the seven weekdays — Sanskritic like Hindi, but Sunday means “the FIRST day,” not “Sun’s day”

Introduced in Chapter 10.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 31

31.1 శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం — *register and evidence*

Do both sources claim subha madhyahnam is less common?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 31

31.1 శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం — *register and evidence*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no they do not; only one source does

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

0–9

11-20 — additive “ten-echo” compounds for the teens; ఇరవై (20) most likely continues the SAME pan-Dravidian “two-tens” pattern as Kannada’s ippattu, though worn down further and less transparent on the surface today పదకొండు — ఇరవై (padakonḍu — iravai)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 20, p. 93

A

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Chapter 56, p. 299

a blessing ఆశీర్వాదం (āśīrvādaṁ)
Chapter 51, p. 269

a bone ఎముక (emuka)
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a doctor, a physician వైద్యుడు (vaidyudu)

Chapter 48, p. 251

a door తలుపు (talupu)

Chapter 52, p. 275

a farmer రైతు (raitu)

Chapter 48, p. 251

a finger వేలు (vēlu)

Chapter 47, p. 245

a fingernail, a claw గోరు (gōru)

Chapter 57, p. 305

a flower పువ్వు (puvvu)

Chapter 52, p. 275

a flower garland పూలదండ (pūladaṇḍa)

Chapter 52, p. 275

a fruit పండు (paṇḍu)

Chapter 46, p. 239

a good turn, a benefit మేలు (mēlu)

Chapter 51, p. 269

a guest అతిథి (atithi)

Chapter 48, p. 251

a journey ప్రయాణం (prayāṇam)

Chapter 50, p. 263

a knife కత్తి (katti)

Chapter 56, p. 299

a lamp దీపం (dīpaṁ)

Chapter 46, p. 239

a lip పెదవి (pedavi)

Chapter 57, p. 305

a little, a bit కొంచెం (koñcem)

Chapter 58, p. 311

a low hill గుట్ట (guṭṭa)

Chapter 55, p. 293

a mat చాప (cāpa)

Chapter 56, p. 299

A Meal

chapter topic; Chapter 40, p. 173

**a meal — the polite Sanskrit noun Chapter 32 already named
and never taught, finally given its own lesson** భోజనం (bhōjanam)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 40, p. 173

a path, a way బాట (bāṭa)

Chapter 55, p. 293

a river నది (nadi)

Chapter 55, p. 293

a root వేరు (vēru)

Chapter 54, p. 287

a salutation, “my respects” దండం (daṇḍam)

Chapter 51, p. 269

a seed విత్తనం (vittanam)

Chapter 54, p. 287

a star; a dot చుక్క (cukka)

Chapter 53, p. 281

a student విద్యార్థి (vidyārthi)

Chapter 48, p. 251

a teacher గురువు (guruvu)

Chapter 48, p. 251

a tooth పన్ను (pannu)

Chapter 47, p. 245

a tree చెట్టు (ceṭṭu)

Chapter 54, p. 287

a village గ్రామం (grāmam)

Chapter 55, p. 293

a village tank, a reservoir చెరువు (ceruvu)

Chapter 55, p. 293

a young plant మొక్క (mokka)

Chapter 54, p. 287

Afternoon

chapter topic; Chapter 28, p. 115

“afternoon” — the same word already met meaning precisely
 “noon” (TE-C17), confirmed via a directly-fetched source to also
 cover “the time between noon and evening” in modern usage —
 the same kind of semantic widening already found for Hindi’s
 दोपहर and, more thinly, Kannada’s

మధ్యాహ్న మధ్యాహ్నం (madhyāhnam)

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 28, p. 115

Answering With More Than Yes

chapter topic; Chapter 49, p. 257

Asking Someone’s Age

chapter topic; Chapter 19, p. 89

B

before the noun, unchanged — five words, one rule

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 42, p. 181

big పెద్ద (pedda)

Chapter 42, p. 181

black, white, red, blue — Telugu’s own basic colors, completing the whole family’s shared blue నలుపు తెలుపు ఎరుపు నీలం

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 11, p. 55

C

Case Endings and Dative Subjects

chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 23

certainly, without fail తప్పకుండా (tappakuṇḍā)

Chapter 49, p. 257

cloth బట్ట (baṭṭa)

Chapter 46, p. 239

come రా (rā)

Chapter 43, p. 227

Courtesy Words

chapter topic; Chapter 51, p. 269

D

daughter — a second, separate Proto-Dravidian root, cognate across the family with a word for “infant” rather than with Telugu’s own word for son కూతురు (kūturu)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 36, p. 155

Day

chapter topic; Chapter 23, p. 105

“day” — a genuine surprise: Telugu’s everyday word isn’t Sanskrit or native Dravidian at all, it’s a Persian loanword; దినము, the Sanskrit tatsama form, is the more formal alternate here — the mirror image of Kannada’s pattern రోజు (rōju)

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 23, p. 105

Days of the Week

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 49

Describing Things

chapter topic; Chapter 42, p. 181

Dog and Cat

chapter topic; Chapter 21, p. 99

dog and cat — kukka genuinely breaks from its Dravidian cousins’ shared naayi root, debated as onomatopoeic or a Sanskrit loan; pilli most likely closes the ENTIRE arc’s cat-story loop, the probable Dravidian source behind Sanskrit’s biDaala and so Hindi’s billi కుక్క, పిల్లి
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 21, p. 99

E

ear — native Dravidian, matching Tamil’s own form closely చెవి (cevi)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 159

enough, that will do చాలు (cālu)
Chapter 49, p. 257

Evening

chapter topic; Chapter 27, p. 113

“evening” (sāyantram) — Sanskrit tatsama from సాయం (sāyam, “in the evening”) + a “-tana” time-adjective suffix; సాయం itself traces to PIE *seh₁-* (“long, lasting”), the SAME root as Latin’s *sērus* — attested as the root of French *soir* and Italian *sera* — a genuine distant cognate across two completely different Indo-European branches సాయంత్రం (sāyantram)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 27, p. 113

eye — a word this book has already used once, unglossed, as proof of the family’s shared oldest seeing-root కన్ను (kannu)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 159

F

Family

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 59

Family and Friends

chapter topic; Chapter 35, p. 151

family — the collective word Chapter 12’s parents and siblings never needed, because each of them was already the name of one specific person కుటుంబం (kuṭumbam)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 151

Farewells

chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 15

father, mother, and four age-graded sibling words — Telugu’s own father-word and “younger sister” word, but the same

age-first system నాన్న అమ్మ అన్న తమ్ముడు అక్క చెల్లి

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 12, p. 59

fire, a live coal నిప్పు (nippu)

Chapter 59, p. 317

Four Core Colours

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 55

Four Verbs Between People

chapter topic; Chapter 34, p. 143

Four Verbs of the Mind

chapter topic; Chapter 33, p. 135

Four Words on the Face

chapter topic; Chapter 37, p. 159

friend — the everyday Sanskrit-derived word, with Telugu’s own DEDR-attested alternative named beside it స్నేహితుడు (snēhituḍu)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 151

G

give ఇవ్వ (ivvu)

Chapter 43, p. 227

good మంచి (manci)

Chapter 42, p. 181

Good Afternoon

chapter topic; Chapter 31, p. 121

“good afternoon” (śubha madhyāhnam), built on the widened

“noon” word rather than the classical later-afternoon term శుభ

మధ్యాహ్నం (śubha madhyāhnam)

Chapter 31, p. 121

Good Evening

chapter topic; Chapter 30, p. 119

“good evening” (śubha sāyantram) — pairs with సాయంత్రం

(TE-C27, the word with the striking Latin sērus/French soir

cognate); unlike GREETING-MORNING’s single, dramatic

“displaced by English” source, TWO independently-fetched

sources agree this one is genuinely, commonly used in both

formal and casual speech, with నమస్కారం as a time-independent

alternative rather than a replacement శుభ సాయంత్రం (śubha

sāyantram)

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 30, p. 119

Good Morning

chapter topic; Chapter 29, p. 117

“good morning” (subhodayam) — శుభ + ఉదయం, the traditional phrase; one directly-fetched source (a Telugu-learning blog, the same low-authority genre already found overstated for Hindi/Kannada) claims it’s archaic, displaced by English “good morning” — treat with real skepticism, not as confirmed; నమస్కారం remains a safer everyday-greeting bet regardless శుభోదయం (śubhodayam)
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 29, p. 117

Good Night

chapter topic; Chapter 25, p. 109

“good night” — the standard Sanskrit-tatsama translation (rātri already met, śubha new); some sources describe everyday speakers often code-switching to English “good night”

instead శుభ రాత్రి (śubha rātri)

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 25, p. 109

goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”) వెళ్ళి వస్తాను (velli vastānu)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

grandfather తాత (tāta)

Chapter 45, p. 235

grandmother, the mother’s mother అమ్మమ్మ (ammamma)

Chapter 45, p. 235

Grandparents, and the Married Pair

chapter topic; Chapter 45, p. 235

gratitude కృతజ్ఞత (kṛtajñata)

Chapter 51, p. 269

Green and Yellow

chapter topic; Chapter 22, p. 103

green and yellow — a genuine Telugu doublet pair, both from the same Proto-Dravidian *pac-* root, *unlike Kannada, where the yellow word broke away as a Sanskrit loan* పచ్చ, పసుపు (pacca pasupu)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 22, p. 103

Greetings

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

H

hair (of the head) జుట్టు (juṭṭu)

Chapter 47, p. 245

Head and Hand

chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 65

head (matching its cousins) and hand (the SAME Dravidian root as the others, transformed almost past recognition) తల

తెయ్యి (tala ceyyi)

Chapter 13, p. 65

heart — the everyday native Dravidian word, cognate with

Kannada’s own native heart-word గుండె (guṇḍe)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 38, p. 165

heart — the literary Sanskrit word for the same organ, a genuine Indo-European cousin of English “heart” హృదయం (hṛdayam)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 165

hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a

bow”) నమస్కారం (namaskāram)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

here — where I am ఇక్కడ (ikkāḍa)

Chapter 41, p. 175

hour — matching Kannada and Hindi exactly, the same Sanskrit “bell” word గంట (gaṇṭa)

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 18, p. 85

how ఎలా

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

How Are You?

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 11

how are you? (respectful) మీరు ఎలా ఉన్నారు?

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

how old are you? — literally “your age how-much?”, matching

Kannada’s simple verbless possessive exactly నీ వయసెంత? (nī

vayasenta)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 19, p. 89

husband భర్త (bharta)

Chapter 45, p. 235

I

I నేను (nēnu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

i- / a- / e- — six words, one machine

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 41, p. 175

‘I know Telugu’ — literally ‘to me Telugu comes’, with no

subject at all నాకు తెలుగు వచ్చు (nāku telugu vaccu)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 23

'I like Telugu' — a sentence with no verb in it at all, the liker in the dative and the liked thing left standing plain నాకు తెలుగు

ఇష్టం (nāku telugu iṣṭam)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 143

I'll go and come back — the everyday

goodbye వెళ్ళొస్తాను (vellōstānu)

Chapter 50, p. 263

I speak Telugu నేను తెలుగు మాట్లాడతాను

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 19

In the House

chapter topic; Chapter 56, p. 299

Introducing Yourself

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 7

it is known — the verb that carries no person at all, so the

knower rides in the dative తెలుసు (telusu)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 32, p. 125

it's okay / no problem / you're welcome పరవాలేదు (paravālēdu)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

J

joy / pleased to meet you సంతోషం

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

just so, alright then అలాగే (alāgē)

Chapter 49, p. 257

L

leg, foot కాలు (kālu)

Chapter 47, p. 245

less, too little తక్కువ (takkuva)

Chapter 58, p. 311

listen ఆలకించు (ālakiñcu)

Chapter 44, p. 231

look చూడు (cūḍu)

Chapter 44, p. 231

M

milk — the same Proto-Dravidian word the whole family shares,
with Telugu on the majority side of a regular Kannada sound

law పాలు (pālu)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 169

mist, dew, snow మంచు (mañcu)

Chapter 59, p. 317

more, a great deal ఎక్కువ (ekkuva)

Chapter 58, p. 311

More Everyday Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 43, p. 227

More of the Body

chapter topic; Chapter 57, p. 305

More Short Replies

chapter topic; Chapter 58, p. 311

Morning

chapter topic; Chapter 26, p. 111

“morning” (udayam) — Sanskrit tatsama from udaya (“rise”) +
Telugu -mu, Telugu’s most general everyday word, though
genuine native competitors (poddu/podduna, vēkuva) also do
real everyday work; unlike Kannada, where the same Sanskrit
root (udaya) shows up ONLY inside the greeting śubhōdaya,
Telugu’s everyday noun and its greeting-root are the SAME
word ఉదయం (udayam)

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 26, p. 111

mouth — the one face-word where Telugu does not obviously
match the root its three sisters all share నోరు (nōru)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 159

mud బురద (burada)

Chapter 59, p. 317

my నా (nā)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

my name is... (with no “is”) నా పేరు ...

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 7

N

name పేరు (pēru)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

Naming Who Someone Is

chapter topic; Chapter 48, p. 251

new కొత్త (kotta)

Chapter 42, p. 181

Night

chapter topic; Chapter 24, p. 107

“night” — the same Sanskrit tatsama word already hiding inside ardharātri; unlike day’s Persian surprise, night genuinely follows the Sanskrit-tatsama-as-everyday pattern, matching

Kannada రాత్రి (rātri)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 24, p. 107

no, I don’t want it వద్దు (vaddu)

Chapter 58, p. 311

no / there isn’t లేదు (lēdu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

Noon and Midnight

chapter topic; Chapter 17, p. 81

noon (Sanskrit “middle of day,” same as Kannada) and midnight (Sanskrit “HALF of night” — a different root than Kannada’s midnight word) మధ్యాహ్నం అర్ధరాత్రి

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 17, p. 81

nose — native Dravidian, but an irregular reflex of its own Proto-Dravidian root, contaminated in shape by the separate word for “face” ముక్కు (mukku)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 159

now ఇప్పుడు (ippuḍu)

Chapter 50, p. 263

Numbers 11–20 and Weather

chapter topic; Chapter 20, p. 93

Numbers One to Ten

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 31

O

okay / alright (sarē) సరే (sarē)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

old — of a thing, not of a person పాత (pāta)

Chapter 42, p. 181

◌౧ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 31

◌౦ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 9, p. 43

◌్ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 10, p. 49

౧ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 12, p. 59

౨ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 12, p. 59

౩ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 13, p. 65

౪ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 16, p. 77

౫ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 17, p. 81

one to five — the Dravidian family numbers, with Telugu’s maverick “one” ఒకటి రెండు మూడు నాలుగు ఐదు (okaṭi reṇḍu mūḍu nālugu aidu)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 31

P

perhaps, who knows ఏమో (ēmō)

Chapter 49, p. 257

Please

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 37

please (dayacēsi — “having done compassion,” from దయ daya “compassion”) దయచేసి (dayacēsi)

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 8, p. 37

please forgive / sorry (kṣamiṇcaṇḍi — from kṣamiṇcu “to forgive,” Sanskrit kṣamā + respectful -aṇḍi) క్షమించండి

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 9, p. 43

Pointing, and Asking

chapter topic; Chapter 41, p. 175

R

respect గౌరవం (gauravaṇi)

Chapter 51, p. 269

River and Road

chapter topic; Chapter 55, p. 293

S

salt ఉప్పు (uppu)

Chapter 46, p. 239

sand ఇసుక (isuka)

Chapter 59, p. 317

Seasons

chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 69

see you tomorrow రేపు కలుద్దాం (rēpu kaluddām)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

sit కూర్చో (kūrcō)

Chapter 43, p. 227

six to ten — where Telugu wanders furthest from its Dravidian cousins ఆరు ఏడు ఎనిమిది తొమ్మిది పది

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 31

small చిన్న (cinna)

Chapter 42, p. 181

son — a native Dravidian root that shares its shape with a word already met in this book, and not with the next lesson's word for daughter కొడుకు (koḍuku)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 36, p. 155

Son and Daughter, Two Different Roots

chapter topic; Chapter 36, p. 155

Sorry

chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 43

speak మాట్లాడు (māṭlāḍu)

Chapter 44, p. 231

spring, summer, monsoon, winter — completing the Dravidian pattern of native heat/rain words plus Sanskrit spring వసంత

ఋతువు వేసవి వానాకాలం శీతాకాలం

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 14, p. 69

stand నిల్చో (nilcō)

Chapter 43, p. 227

T

Taking Your Leave

chapter topic; Chapter 50, p. 263

Tea and Milk, Two Roads

chapter topic; Chapter 39, p. 169

tea, please — Telugu's traditional word for tea travelled by sea, not by the overland road most of its neighbours took దయచేసి

టీ (dayacēsi ṭī)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 169

Telling Time

chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 85

thank you (dhanyavādamulu — “utterances of

‘worthy’”) ధన్యవాదములు (dhanyavādamulu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

that one — the thing over there అది (adi)

Chapter 41, p. 175

that’s all; that’s just it అంతే (antē)

Chapter 58, p. 311

the back వీపు (vīpu)

Chapter 57, p. 305

The Core Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 32, p. 125

the dative suffix -ku, ‘to / for’ — and the idea of

stacking -కు (-ku)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 6, p. 23

the day after tomorrow ఎల్లుండి (ellundi)

Chapter 50, p. 263

The First Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 19

The Heart, Two Ways

chapter topic; Chapter 38, p. 165

The Leg and the Tooth

chapter topic; Chapter 47, p. 245

the moon చంద్రుడు (candrudu)

Chapter 53, p. 281

the neck మెడ (meḍa)

Chapter 57, p. 305

the rice-flour design drawn at the doorstep ముగ్గు (muggu)

Chapter 52, p. 275

the seven weekdays — Sanskritic like Hindi, but Sunday means

“the FIRST day,” not “Sun’s day” సోమవారం మంగళవారం బుధవారం

గురువారం శుక్రవారం శనివారం ఆదివారం

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 10, p. 49

The Sky

chapter topic; Chapter 53, p. 281

the sky ఆకాశం (ākāśam)

Chapter 53, p. 281

the stomach, the belly కడుపు (kaḍupu)

Chapter 47, p. 245

the sun సూర్యుడు (sūryudu)

Chapter 53, p. 281

The Traditional Months

chapter topic; Chapter 16, p. 77

The Tree

chapter topic; Chapter 54, p. 287

the twelve lunisolar months — matching Kannada and Hindi’s shared pan-Indian calendar, completing the split with Tamil/Malayalam’s own solar systems చైత్రం వైశాఖం జ్యేష్ఠం ఆషాఢం శ్రావణం

భాద్రపదం ఆశ్వయుజం కార్తీకం మార్గశిరం పుష్యం మాఘం ఫాల్గుణం

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 16, p. 77

there — where I am not అక్కడ (akkada)

Chapter 41, p. 175

Things You Ask For

chapter topic; Chapter 46, p. 239

this one — the thing near me ఇది (idi)

Chapter 41, p. 175

to ask — a native verb none of the three literary sisters share, and the clue to which branch of Dravidian Telugu actually sits on అడుగు (aḍugu)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 143

to be, to exist, to stay — and the negative Telugu has to fetch from a different verb ఉండు (uṇḍu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar; Chapter 32, p. 125

to be, to stay, to live ఉండు (uṇḍu)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 19

to come — the command is రా, but every ending attaches to వచ్చు instead రా (rā)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 32, p. 125

to eat — the inherited Dravidian root Telugu kept as its plain everyday verb, with the mealtime nouns borrowed from Sanskrit తిను (tinu)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 32, p. 125

to go (and వచ్చు, to come) వెళ్ళు (vellu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

to go — with one tense-piece covering both “I go” and “I will go”, and “right now” built out of the be-verb వెళ్ళు (vellu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar; Chapter 32, p. 125

to help — a Sanskrit noun on the native do-verb, and the noun takes apart into “a going with somebody” సహాయం చేయు (sahāyaṁ cēyu)

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 34, p. 143

to read — and, with no second word, to study; the same form is the noun for an education, and its middle vowel moves as the endings change చదువు (caduvu)

explicit focus: script, grammar; Chapter 33, p. 135

to see, to look — Telugu’s own everyday see-word, and the respectful -అండి ending that fits any verb stem చూడు (cūḍu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar; Chapter 32, p. 125

to set out, to start off బయలుదేరు (bayaludēru)

Chapter 50, p. 263

to speak మాట్లాడు (māṭlāḍu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 19

to take — తీయు, “to pull out”, wearing the same -కో as the last chapter’s two mind-verbs, so taking is pulling something out for yourself తీసుకో (tīsukō)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 143

to think — literally “say it to yourself”, built from the family’s say-verb plus the ending that turns a verb back on its own doer అనుకో (anukō)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 135

to understand — “make the meaning your own”, a Sanskrit noun on the native do-verb with the ending that hands the action back to you అర్థం చేసుకో (artham cēsukō)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 135

to work (lit. “work-do”) పని చేయు (pani cēyu)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 19

to write — an old Dravidian word for drawing a line, still spelled వ్రాయు in books, and the chapter’s fourth mind-verb రాయు (rāyu)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 135

true; the truth నిజం (nijam)

Chapter 49, p. 257

V

Verbs of Seeing and Saying

chapter topic; Chapter 44, p. 231

W

Water and Rice

chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 73

water (matching Tamil/Kannada’s neer/niiru), and **rice** raw/cooked — completing the family’s water and rice pattern నీళ్ళు బియ్యం అన్నం

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 73

we’ll meet again మళ్ళీ కలుద్దాం (maḷḷī kaluddām)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

Weather and Ground

chapter topic; Chapter 59, p. 317

weather/atmosphere — a PURE Sanskrit compound, unlike Kannada’s Persian+Sanskrit hybrid: **vata** (“air/wind”) + **avarana** (“covering”) వాతావరణం (vātāvaraṇam)
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 20, p. 93

Welcoming a Guest

chapter topic; Chapter 52, p. 275

well, fine — and the reply “నేను బాగున్నాను” బాగా (bāgā)
explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

what ఏమిటి (ēmiṭi)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

what’s your name? మీ పేరు ఏమిటి?

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 7

where? — asking about a place ఎక్కడ (ekkaḍa)

Chapter 41, p. 175

who? — asking about a person ఎవరు (evaru)

Chapter 41, p. 175

wife భార్య (bhārya)

Chapter 45, p. 235

wind, air గాలి (gāli)

Chapter 59, p. 317

write రాయ్ (rāyi)

Chapter 44, p. 231

Y

yes (avunu) అవును (avunu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

you (familiar / respectful) నువ్వు / మీరు (nuvvu / mīru)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

Other

ఉ — one character, met inside words you already say
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 19, p. 89

ఎ — one character, met inside words you already say
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 21, p. 99

క — one character, met inside words you already say
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 8, p. 37

గ — one character, met inside words you already say
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 15, p. 73

చ — one character, met inside words you already say
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 9, p. 43

- డ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 20, p. 93
- త — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 23
- ద — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 13, p. 65
- న — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 23
- ప — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 10, p. 49
- య — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 31
- ర — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 11, p. 55
- ల — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 11, p. 55
- ళ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 18, p. 85
- వ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 14, p. 69
- శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం — **register and evidence**
culture and usage topic; explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 31, p. 121
- స — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 8, p. 37

More Everyday Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell someone to come, sit, stand and give in Telugu.

Complete TE-C43-give and say all four verbs in order.

42.7 ర్ (rā) — come

A short run of everyday verbs, one at a time.

You'll want to know: ర్

ర్ (rā) — “come”.

The bare command, and one of the shortest words in the language: a single syllable that is a complete sentence.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- rā
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway

Before you move on

What does ൠ mean? (“come”.) Say it once more.

42.8 ൠ (kūrcō) — sit

Before the new one: what did *rā* mean?

You’ll want to know: ൠ

ൠ (*kūrcō*) — “sit”.

A command you will hear on entering any home, usually before anything else is said.

What you’ve built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kūrcō*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after *rā*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does ൠ mean? (“sit”.) Say it once more.

42.9 ഺ (nilcō) — stand

Before the new one: what did *kūrcō* mean?

You'll want to know: నిల్చో

నిల్చో (*nilcō*) — “stand”.

Its pair. Telugu, like the other Dravidian languages, makes the bare stem do the work of a command with nothing added.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nilcō*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after *kūrcō*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does నిల్చో mean? (“stand”.) Say it once more.

42.10 ఇవ్వు (*ivvu*) — give

Before the new one: what did *nilcō* mean?

You'll want to know: ఇవ్వు

ఇవ్వు (*ivvu*) — “give”.

The everyday ‘give’. Softening it is done with a separate politeness word rather than by changing the verb.

What you've built

One more everyday action. That closes the run: four everyday actions, each met on its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ivvu*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after *nilcō*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does ఇవ్వు mean? (“give”.) Say it once more.

Verbs of Seeing and Saying

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell someone to look, listen, speak and write in Telugu.

Complete TE-C44-write and say all four verbs in order.

42.11 చూడు (cūḍu) — look

Four verbs for taking things in and putting them out, one at a time.

You'll want to know: చూడు

చూడు (cūḍu) — “look”.

Also 'to see' and 'to look after', the same three-way stem as its Kannada cousin *nōḍu* — the languages are close enough that the pattern travels.

What you've built

One more. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cūḍu*
- it once more, slowly

Before you move on

What does చూడు mean? (“look”). Say it once more.

42.12 ఆలకించు (*ālakiñcu*) — listen

Before the new one: what did *cūḍu* mean?

You’ll want to know: ఆలకించు

ఆలకించు (*ālakiñcu*) — “listen”.

‘Listen attentively’ — a step above simply hearing. Telugu keeps listening and asking separate, where Kannada merges them into one stem.

What you’ve built

One more. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ālakiñcu*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *cūḍu*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does ఆలకించు mean? (“listen”). Say it once more.

42.13 మాట్లాడు (*māṭlāḍu*) — speak

Before the new one: what did *ālakiñcu* mean?

You’ll want to know: మాట్లాడు

మాట్లాడు (*māṭlāḍu*) — “speak”.

From *māṭa*, ‘word’, plus *āḍu*, ‘to play’ — the same construction as Kannada’s *māṭāḍu*, built from the same two pieces.

What you've built

One more. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *māṭlāḍu*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *ālakin̄cu*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does మాట్లాడు mean? (“speak”.) Say it once more.

42.14 రాయి (rāyi) — write

Before the new one: what did *māṭlāḍu* mean?

You'll want to know: రాయి

రాయి (*rāyi*) — “write”.

The everyday ‘write’. Telugu and Kannada each kept their own Dravidian stem here rather than borrowing a shared one.

What you've built

That closes the run: look, listen, speak, write.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *rāyi*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *māṭlāḍu*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does ဝံ့ mean? (“write”.) Say it once more.

Grandparents, and the Married Pair

Modes: ⇌ voice (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name four more family and people words in this language.

Complete TE-C45-wife and say all four words in order.

42.15 తాత (tāta) — grandfather

Before the new one: what did *rāyi* mean?

You'll want to know: తాత

తాత (tāta) — “grandfather”.

It has the same small, repeatable shape as the *nānna* and *amma* you met in the family lesson. Sanskrit carries a *tāta* too, meaning ‘father’ or simply ‘dear one’; Telugu moved the word up a generation. Children use it for any kindly old man, not only their own grandfather.

What you’ve built

The first of four family words. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tāta*

- it once more, slowly
- it after *rāyi*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does తాత mean? (“grandfather”.) Say it once more.

42.16 అమ్మమ్మ (ammamma) — grandmother, the mother’s mother

Before the new one: what did *tāta* mean?

You’ll want to know: అమ్మమ్మ

అమ్మమ్మ (*ammamma*) — “grandmother”, and specifically your mother’s mother.

Say it slowly and you can hear what it is made of: *amma* twice over, mother of mother. Telugu keeps the two grandmothers apart, and the father’s mother is *nāyanamma*, assembled the same way on *nāyana*, ‘father’. Nothing here is borrowed; every piece came from the family lesson.

What you’ve built

Two of four, and a word you could have decoded before you were taught it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ammamma*
- it once more, slowly, hearing the two halves
- it after *tāta*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does అమ్మమ్మ mean? (“grandmother”, the mother’s mother.) Say it once more.

42.17 భర్త (bharta) — husband

Before the new one: what did *ammamma* mean?

You'll want to know: భర్త

భర్త (*bharta*) — “husband”.

Sanskrit, and it opens cleanly: the root *bhr̥*, ‘to bear, to carry, to support’, plus the ending that names the one who does it. So the word says ‘the one who supports’. That root is old enough to have relatives far outside India — Latin *fero*, ‘I carry’, and English *bear* both continue it.

What you've built

Three of four. The last word comes from the very same root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bharta*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *ammamma*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does భర్త mean? (“husband”.) Say it once more.

42.18 భార్య (bhārya) — wife

Before the new one: what did *bharta* mean?

You'll want to know: భార్య

భార్య (*bhārya*) — “wife”.

The same root *bhr̥* as the last word, with a different ending: ‘she who is to be supported’. Two words, one root, and between them a picture of the household as Sanskrit’s grammarians framed it rather than as anyone lives in it now. That is worth hearing plainly, because the shape of the pair is the reason it is easy to remember.

What you've built

That closes the run: grandfather, grandmother, husband, wife.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bhārya*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *bharta*, and name the root they share

Before you move on

What does భార్య mean? (“wife”.) Say it once more.

Things You Ask For

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five everyday things I might ask someone for in Telugu, and say which of them Telugu has always had and which arrived from elsewhere.

Complete TE-C46-book and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.19 పండు (paṇḍu) — a fruit

Before the new run of words: what did *bhārya* mean?

You'll want to know: పండు

పండు (*paṇḍu*) — “a fruit”.

పండు is also a verb: *to ripen*. The fruit is named for what happened to it — the ripened thing — and Telugu never troubled to invent a second noun. Say *paṇḍu* of a mango on the table and you mean the fruit; say it of the tree's crop and you mean it is coming ripe.

Kannada writes the same inherited word ಹಣ್ಣು (*haṇṇu*). That *p-* at the front turning into *h-* is a regular Kannada sound law, and it has already turned up once, on పాలు beside ಹాలు. Watch for it again.

What you've built

The first of five things you might ask someone for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *paṇḍu*
- it once more, slowly
- *paṇḍu*, then *dayacēsi paṇḍu ivvaṇḍi* — “please give a fruit”

Before you move on

What does పండు mean? (“a fruit”.) Say it once more.

42.20 బట్ట (baṭṭa) — cloth

Before the new one: what did *paṇḍu* mean?

You’ll want to know: బట్ట

బట్ట (*baṭṭa*) — “cloth”.

బట్ట is the plain word for cloth: the bolt on the shelf, the washing on the line, the rag in your hand.

Sanskrit has *paṭṭa*, “a strip of cloth, a bandage”, and here the borrowing most likely ran the unusual way — out of Dravidian and into Sanskrit, rather than the other direction this book has shown so often. The same strip reached English by a different road: Hindi *paṭṭī*, a wrapping, is the soldier’s *puttee*.

What you’ve built

Two: a fruit and a cloth.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *baṭṭa*
- it once more, slowly
- *paṇḍu*, then *baṭṭa*, and ask for each one with *dayacēsi*

Before you move on

What does బట్ట mean? (“cloth”.) Say it once more.

42.21 దీపం (dīpaṁ) — a lamp

Before the new one: what did *baṭṭa* mean?

You’ll want to know: దీపం

దీపం (*dīpaṁ*) — “a lamp”.

దీపం is the small clay lamp with oil and a wick. Its Sanskrit root *dīp* means “to blaze”, so the word names the burning rather than the vessel.

Put దీప together with a word meaning “a row” and you get *dīpāvali*, “a row of lamps” — the festival English spells Diwali. The ending is the tatsama neuter -ం, the same shape already carried by హృదయం and భోజనం.

What you’ve built

Three: a fruit, a cloth, a lamp.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dīpaṁ*
- it once more, slowly
- all three, then name the one that came in from Sanskrit

Before you move on

What does దీపం mean? (“a lamp”.) Say it once more.

42.22 ఉప్పు (uppu) — salt

Before the new one: what did *dīpaṁ* mean?

You’ll want to know: ఉప్పు

ఉప్పు (*uppu*) — “salt”.

Proto-Dravidian had ***uppu**, and the whole family kept it almost untouched: Tamil உப்பு, Kannada ಉಪ್ಪು, Malayalam ഉപ്പ്. A word this ordinary gives nobody a reason to replace it.

Notice the doubled ప్ప in the middle. Telugu likes a consonant twice inside a short word — కుక్క, పిల్లి, కన్ను all do it — and the doubling is not decoration: it is the difference between one word and another.

What you've built

Four. Three of them inherited, one borrowed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *uppu*
- it once more, slowly
- all four in order, then say which one has not changed in three thousand years

Before you move on

What does ఉప్పు mean? (“salt”.) Say it once more.

42.23 పుస్తకం (pustakam) — a book

Before the new one: what did *uppu* mean?

You'll want to know: పుస్తకం

పుస్తకం (*pustakam*) — “a book”.

Sanskrit *pustaka* is the source, but the trail behind it leaves India altogether. Middle Persian *post* meant “hide, skin” — the thing written on before paper.

So the Telugu word for a book carries an animal skin folded up inside it, and it arrived by the same north-western road as రోజు, which turned out to be Persian too. Two of these five walked in from outside; three were always here.

What you've built

Five things you might ask for: a fruit, a cloth, a lamp, salt, a book.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pustakam*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then sort them into the inherited and the borrowed

Before you move on

What does పుస్తకం mean? (“a book”.) Say it once more.

The Leg and the Tooth

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five more parts of the body in Telugu, and say which of them held their old shape and which wore down past recognition.

Complete TE-C47-stomach and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.24 కాలు (kālu) — leg, foot

Before the new run: what did *pustakam* mean, and what did *uppu* mean?

You'll want to know: కాలు

కాలు (kālu) — “leg, foot”.

Proto-Dravidian *kāl, and every sister kept it nearly whole: Tamil கால், Kannada ಕಾಲು, Malayalam കാൽ.

Set that beside చెయ్యి, the hand-word, which wore down so far that its family resemblance is hard to see at all. Two body-words of the same age; one held its shape and one did not, and nothing about the meaning predicts which.

కాలు covers the whole limb, foot and leg together. When precision is wanted, Sanskrit's పాదం names the foot alone.

What you've built

The first of five more body words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kālu*
- it once more, slowly
- *kālu*, then *tala*, so the top and the bottom sit together

Before you move on

What does కాలు mean? (“leg, foot”.) Say it once more.

42.25 పన్ను (pannu) — a tooth

Before the new one: what did *kālu* mean?

You’ll want to know: పన్ను

పన్ను (*pannu*) — “a tooth”.

Proto-Dravidian ***pal**. Tamil kept பல்; Kannada has ಹಲ್ಲು, with that *p-* to *h-* law working again exactly where the last chapter said to watch for it. Telugu took a third road, the *-l-* coming out as *-n-* and doubling.

An honest warning: పన్ను is also the word for a tax. Nothing joins the tooth to the tax but an accident of sound. Telugu has a fair number of these pairs, and context is the only fix — which is what context is for.

What you’ve built

Two: a leg and a tooth.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pannu*
- it once more, slowly
- *kālu*, then *pannu*, and say which of the two also names something you pay

Before you move on

What does పన్ను mean? (“a tooth”.) Say it once more.

42.26 జుట్టు (juṭṭu) — hair (of the head)

Before the new one: what did *pannu* mean?

You’ll want to know: జుట్టు

జుట్టు (*juṭṭu*) — “hair (of the head)”.

జుట్టు is the hair on a head taken as one thing — the mass, not the strand. For a single hair Telugu reaches for a different noun, వెంట్రుక.

English leans on number for the same distinction — “a hair” against “hair” — while Telugu simply reaches for a different noun. జుట్టు also names the knot or tuft tied at the back of the head, which is most likely where the word started.

What you’ve built

Three: a leg, a tooth, hair.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *juṭṭu*
- it once more, slowly
- *juṭṭu*, then *tala*, and say which one sits on the other

Before you move on

What does జుట్టు mean? (“hair (of the head)”.) Say it once more.

42.27 వేలు (vēlu) — a finger

Before the new one: what did *juṭṭu* mean?

You'll want to know: వేలు

వేలు (*vēlu*) — “a finger”.

Proto-Dravidian ***viral**. Tamil kept **விரல்** entire; Kannada has **ಬೆರಳು**; Telugu dropped the *-r-* and came out with **వేలు**. On the page the three look barely related, and they are the same word.

It is still working inside compounds: **బొటనవేలు**, the thumb, is the stubby one of the set.

What you've built

Four. Note that **చెయ్యి** and **వేలు** are separate roots — Telugu does not build the finger out of the hand.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vēlu*
- it once more, slowly
- *vēlu*, then *ceyyi*, and say which one has five of the other

Before you move on

What does **వేలు** mean? (“a finger”.) Say it once more.

42.28 కడుపు (kaḍupu) — the stomach, the belly

Before the new one: what did *vēlu* mean?

You'll want to know: కడుపు

కడుపు (*kaḍupu*) — “the stomach, the belly”.

కడుపు is the unfussy everyday word, and it carries the commonest way of saying you have eaten enough: *kaḍupu niṇḍindi*, “the stomach has filled”.

It also says, gently and without ever being explicit, that a woman is expecting. Sanskrit's **ఉదरो** exists in Telugu and stays where the clinical register lives.

What you've built

Five more body words: a leg, a tooth, hair, a finger, a belly. With తల, చెయ్యి, కన్ను, ముక్కు, నోరు and చెవి behind them, you can point at most of a person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kaḍupu*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then add *tala* and *ceyyi* and say the seven as one list

Before you move on

What does కడుపు mean? (“the stomach, the belly”.) Say it once more.

Naming Who Someone Is

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 👁️ eyes (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what someone’s role is in Telugu — teacher, student, doctor, farmer, guest — and name the root that two of those words share.

Complete TE-C48-guest and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.29 గురువు (guruvu) — a teacher

Before the new run: what did *kaḍupu* mean, and what did *vēlu* mean?

You’ll want to know: గురువు

గురువు (*guruvu*) — “a teacher”.

Sanskrit *guru* means “heavy”. The teacher is the weighty one — the one whose word carries weight — and Telugu added its own -వు to make గురువు.

You have already said the word without being told. గురువారం, Thursday, is Guru’s day: the guru there is Jupiter, the heaviest wanderer the naked eye can find and the teacher of the gods. Latin named the same weekday for Jove, which is the same planet under another name.

What you’ve built

The first of five roles.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *guruvu*
- it once more, slowly
- *guruvu*, then *guruvārani*, and say what the two have in common

Before you move on

What does గురువు mean? (“a teacher”.) Say it once more.

42.30 విద్యార్థి (vidyārthi) — a student

Before the new one: what did *guruvu* mean?

You’ll want to know: విద్యార్థి

విద్యార్థి (*vidyārthi*) — “a student”.

Two Sanskrit pieces welded: *vidyā*, knowledge, and *arthin*, one who seeks. A student is a knowledge-seeker, and the word says so on its face.

vidyā grows from the root *vid*, “to know” — the same ancient root behind English *wit* and *wisdom*, and behind Latin *vidēre*, “to see”. Knowing and seeing were one word long before either language existed.

What you’ve built

Two: a teacher and a student.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vidyārthi*
- it once more, slowly
- *guruvu*, then *vidyārthi*, and say which one seeks and which one weighs

Before you move on

What does విద్యార్థి mean? (“a student”.) Say it once more.

42.31 వైద్యుడు (vaidyudu) — a doctor, a physician

Before the new one: what did *vidyārthi* mean?

You'll want to know: వైద్యుడు

వైద్యుడు (*vaidyudu*) — “a doctor, a physician”.

Look at the middle of it. *vaidya* is built on the very *vid* sitting inside విద్యార్థి: a physician is one versed in the knowledge, the knowledge in question being ఆయుర్వేద, the science of long life.

The ending -ుడు is not Sanskrit's but Telugu's own, marking a masculine person — the same -ుడు already carried by స్నేహితుడు.

What you've built

Three roles, and two of them share a root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vaidyudu*
- it once more, slowly
- *vidyārthi*, then *vaidyudu*, and name the syllable they share

Before you move on

What does వైద్యుడు mean? (“a doctor, a physician”.) Say it once more.

42.32 రైతు (raitu) — a farmer

Before the new one: what did *vaidyudu* mean?

You'll want to know: రైతు

రైతు (*raitu*) — “a farmer”.

రైతు came the long way round. Arabic *raʿīyah* meant a flock, then the people a ruler answers for. Persian and Urdu carried it into India as *raʿīyat*,

the subject, the tenant; the revenue clerks of the Deccan wrote it on their rolls; and Telugu kept it for the person who works the land.

That is a second arrival from the north-west, after రోజు and పుస్తకం. The words that travel are the words that follow paperwork and trade.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *raitu*
- it once more, slowly
- *raitu*, then *rōju*, and say what road the two have in common

Before you move on

What does రైతు mean? (“a farmer”.) Say it once more.

42.33 అతిథి (atithi) — a guest

Before the new one: what did *raitu* mean?

You'll want to know: అతిథి

అతిథి (*atithi*) — “a guest”.

a-tithi — “one without a *tithi*”, without a date on the calendar. The guest is defined by not being expected.

The old formula అతిథి దేవో భవ, “let the guest be a god to you”, is built on exactly that: you cannot prepare for a god who arrives unannounced, so you keep the house ready instead. What a Telugu house actually does when the అతిథి arrives has a chapter of its own, at the end of this book.

What you've built

Five roles: a teacher, a student, a doctor, a farmer, a guest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *atithi*
- it once more, slowly
- all five, then say *nā pēru* and your own name, and ask *mīru evaru?*

Before you move on

What does అతిథి mean? (“a guest”.) Say it once more.

Answering With More Than Yes

Modes: ⇌ voice (3) 👁 eyes (2) ⇌ Hands-free start: first 3 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer in Telugu with more than yes and no — true, enough, certainly, perhaps, just so — and see the three-vowel grid running under అది, ఇక్కడ and ఎలా.

Complete TE-C49-alright and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.34 నిజం (nijam) — true; the truth

Before the new run: what did *atithi* mean?

You'll want to know: నిజం

నిజం (*nijam*) — “true; the truth”.

Sanskrit *nija* meant “one’s own, innate” — what belongs to a thing by its nature. Telugu moved it one step: what belongs to a thing by nature is what is really so, and నిజం became the truth.

Alone it answers a doubt: *nijam*, “true”. With a question on the end it becomes perhaps the commonest interjection in the language: *nijamā?*, “really?”

What you’ve built

The first of five answers that are neither అవును nor లేదు.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nijam*

- it once more, slowly
- *nijamī*, then *nijamā?*, and say which one asks

Before you move on

What does ನಿಜಂ mean? (“true; the truth”.) Say it once more.

42.35 చాలు (cālu) — enough, that will do

Before the new one: what did *nijamī* mean?

You’ll want to know: చాలు

చాలు (*cālu*) — “enough, that will do”.

చాలు is a verb — “it suffices” — used as a complete answer. Held over a glass being filled it stops the pouring; said of an argument it ends it.

చాలా, the everyday word for “very” and “a lot”, is the same root wearing a different ending. Sufficiency and abundance sit one letter apart, which is a fair account of how the two ideas are related anywhere.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cālu*
- it once more, slowly
- *cālu*, then *nijamī*, and say which one you would use to stop someone pouring

Before you move on

What does చాలు mean? (“enough, that will do”.) Say it once more.

42.36 తప్పకుండా (tappakuṇḍā) — certainly, without fail

Before the new one: what did *cālu* mean?

You’ll want to know: తప్పకుండా

తప్పకుండా (tappakuṇḍā) — “certainly, without fail”.

Take it apart: తప్పు, “to miss, to slip, to go wrong”, plus -కుండా, the ending meaning “without doing”. తప్పకుండా is *without missing*.

The ending is worth having on its own, because it attaches to any verb stem: *ceppakuṇḍā*, without telling; *tinakuṇḍā*, without eating. One suffix, and every verb you own gains a negative.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tappakuṇḍā*
- it once more, slowly
- *tappakuṇḍā*, then *cālu*, and say which one is a promise

Before you move on

What does తప్పకుండా mean? (“certainly, without fail”.) Say it once more.

42.37 ఏమో (ēmō) — perhaps, who knows

Before the new one: what did *tappakuṇḍā* mean?

You’ll want to know: ఏమో

ఏమో (ēmō) — “perhaps, who knows”.

ఏమో is a shrug made into a word: perhaps, it may be so, who knows.

Look at the front of it and you will find the questioning ఏ- that already stands in ఏమిటి, “what”. ఏమో is that question with the asking taken out and only the uncertainty left behind.

It also hangs on the end of a whole sentence, where English would need a separate clause: *vastāḍēmō*, “he may come”. A language with a settled, unembarrassed word for not knowing is telling you something about its manners.

What you’ve built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ēmō*
- it once more, slowly
- *ēmō*, then *tappakuṇḍā*, and say which one commits you

Before you move on

What does ఏమో mean? (“perhaps, who knows”.) Say it once more.

42.38 అలాగే (alāgē) — just so, alright then

Before the new one: what did *ēmō* mean?

You’ll want to know: అలాగే

అలాగే (*alāgē*) — “just so, alright then”.

అలా means “in that way”; -గే is the small emphatic tail that makes it “just so”. అలాగే is the yes you give to an instruction — not “that is correct” but “it shall be as you said”.

Now look at the front of it. అ- points far, and already carries అది, “that one”, and అక్కడ, “there”. ఇ- points near: ఇది, ఇక్కడ, and so ఇలా, “in this way”. ఎ- asks: ఎక్కడ, ఎలా. Three vowels, one grid, and అలాగే is simply the far corner of it with an ending stuck on.

What you've built

Five answers, and a three-way grid you can now see running under అది, ఇక్కడ and ఎలా.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *alāgē*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then say *alāgē* as a reply to *dayacēsi kūrco*

Before you move on

What does అలాగే mean? (“just so, alright then”.) Say it once more.

Taking Your Leave

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can take my leave in Telugu the way a Telugu speaker actually does, and say why the flat “I am going” is the one thing never said at a door.

Complete TE-C50-farewell and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.39 ఇప్పుడు (ippuḍu) — now

Before the new run: what did *alāgē* mean?

You’ll want to know: ఇప్పుడు

ఇప్పుడు (*ippuḍu*) — “now”.

The grid from the last chapter has a time row, and this is its near corner. -ప్పుడు is the time-piece; put a pointing vowel in front of it and the word makes itself.

ఇప్పుడు is “this time” — now. అప్పుడు is “that time” — then. ఎప్పుడు is “which time” — when? You already owned the vowels; the row costs you one word.

What you’ve built

Now — and a shape that gives you two more words for free.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ippuḍu*

- it once more, slowly
- *ippudu*, then *ippudu vellu* — “go now”

Before you move on

What does ఇప్పుడు mean? (“now”.) Say it once more.

42.40 ఎల్లుండి (ellundi) — the day after tomorrow

Before the new one: what did *ippudu* mean?

You’ll want to know: ఎల్లుండి

ఎల్లుండి (*ellundi*) — “the day after tomorrow”.

One settled noun for the day after tomorrow. English needs four words and still sounds unsure of itself; Telugu, like its sisters, simply has the word.

There is an older tomorrow hiding at the front of it. ఎల్లి once meant tomorrow, and though రేపు took that job in everyday speech, ఎల్లి is still in service inside ఎల్లుండి, doing its old work one day further out.

What you’ve built

Two: now, and the day after tomorrow.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ellundi*
- it once more, slowly
- *ippudu*, then *ellundi*, and say which one is further off

Before you move on

What does ఎల్లుండి mean? (“the day after tomorrow”.) Say it once more.

42.41 ప్రయాణం (prayāṇam) — a journey

Before the new one: what did *ellundi* mean?

You'll want to know: ప్రయాణం

ప్రయాణం (*prayāṇam*) — “a journey”.

Sanskrit *pra-yāṇa*: the root *yā*, “to go”, with *pra-*, “forth”. A journey is a going-forth, and the word is transparent to anyone holding the pieces.

The ending is the -ం you have now sorted three times: the tatsama neuter, as on దీపం, హృదయం and భోజనం. When a Telugu noun ends in -ం and names an abstraction, Sanskrit is usually behind it.

What you've built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *prayāṇam*
- it once more, slowly
- *prayāṇam*, then *dīpam*, and name the ending they share

Before you move on

What does ప్రయాణం mean? (“a journey”.) Say it once more.

42.42 బయలుదేరు (bayaludēru) — to set out, to start off

Before the new one: what did *prayāṇam* mean?

You'll want to know: బయలుదేరు

బయలుదేరు (*bayaludēru*) — “to set out, to start off”.

Native, and a picture rather than an abstraction. బయలు is open ground, the outside; దేరు is to rise, to come forth. To set out is to come out into the open.

Set it beside ప్రయాణం and you have two languages building the same idea from opposite ends: Sanskrit from the going, Telugu from the doorstep.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bayaludēru*
- it once more, slowly
- *bayaludēru*, then *prayāṇam*, and say which of the two is inherited

Before you move on

What does బయలుదేరు mean? (“to set out, to start off”.) Say it once more.

42.43 వెళ్ళొస్తాను (*veḷlostānu*) — I’ll go and come back — the everyday goodbye

Before the new one: what did *bayaludēru* mean?

You’ll want to know: వెళ్ళొస్తాను

వెళ్ళొస్తాను (*veḷlostānu*) — “I’ll go and come back — the everyday goodbye”.

Two verbs you already have, welded at the seam: వెళ్ళి, “having gone”, and వస్తాను, “I will come”. వెళ్ళొస్తాను is *I’ll go and come back*, and it is what is said at the door.

What is not said is the flat “I am going”. Leaving without the returning half is what is said of the dead, and the rule holds right across the South. The politeness here is not decoration laid over the grammar; it is the grammar. The reply comes back in the same shape: వెళ్ళి రండి — “go, and come”.

What you've built

Five: ఇప్పుడు, ఎల్లండి, ప్రయాణం, బయలుదేరు, and a goodbye that refuses to be one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vell̥lostānu*
- it once more, slowly
- *vell̥lostānu*, then the reply *velli randi*, and say why neither half stands alone

Before you move on

What does వెళ్ళొస్తాను mean? (“I’ll go and come back — the everyday goodbye”.) Say it once more.

Courtesy Words

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can be polite in Telugu beyond thank you — gratitude, a good turn, respect, a blessing, a salutation — and name the piece that two of those words share.

Complete TE-C51-salutation and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.44 కృతజ్ఞత (kṛtajñata) — gratitude

Before the new run: what did *vellostānu* mean?

You’ll want to know: కృతజ్ఞత

కృతజ్ఞత (*kṛtajñata*) — “gratitude”.

kṛta, “done”, plus *jñā*, “knowing”: knowing what was done for you. That is the whole of gratitude in two Sanskrit syllables, and Telugu took it entire.

Set it beside ధన్యవాదములు, the thank-you from the first pages of this book, which is “utterances of ‘worthy’”. One word thanks by calling the giver worthy. The other thanks by admitting the debt is remembered. They are not the same gesture, and Telugu keeps both.

What you’ve built

A second word for thanks, with a different picture inside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kṛtajñata*

- it once more, slowly
- *kṛtajñata*, then *dhanyavādamulu*, and say which one remembers a debt

Before you move on

What does కృతజ్ఞత mean? (“gratitude”.) Say it once more.

42.45 మేలు (mēlu) — a good turn, a benefit

Before the new one: what did *kṛtajñata* mean?

You’ll want to know: మేలు

మేలు (*mēlu*) — “a good turn, a benefit”.

Inherited, and short. మేల్ meant “above”; the good is what is above. From it Telugu draws మేలు, a benefit or a good turn done to someone, and also the plain comparative sense of “better”.

So *idi mēlu* says “this one is higher” and lets the height do the judging — which is what English does too, in *superior*, without anyone noticing any more.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mēlu*
- it once more, slowly
- *mēlu*, then *manci*, and say which one is a thing done and which is a quality

Before you move on

What does మేలు mean? (“a good turn, a benefit”.) Say it once more.

42.46 గౌరవం (gauravam) — respect

Before the new one: what did *mēlu* mean?

You’ll want to know: గౌరవం

గౌరవం (*gauravam*) — “respect”.

gaurava is the abstract noun of *guru* — the very word met one chapter ago as the teacher. Respect is weightiness: to hold someone in గౌరవం is to grant that what they say has mass.

Telugu marks the same idea in its grammar as well as its vocabulary. మీరు rather than నువ్వు, and the -అండి hung on the end of a verb, are గౌరవం turned into endings. A language can be polite in its words or in its shapes, and this one does both.

What you’ve built

Three, and one of them is a word you already knew wearing a different suit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *gauravam*
- it once more, slowly
- *gauravam*, then *guruvu*, and name the syllable they share

Before you move on

What does గౌరవం mean? (“respect”.) Say it once more.

42.47 ఆశీర్వాదం (āśīrvādam) — a blessing

Before the new one: what did *gauravam* mean?

You'll want to know: ఆశీర్వాదం

ఆశీర్వాదం (*āśīrvādam*) — “a blessing”.

āśīs, a wish or a prayer, plus *vāda*, an utterance: a blessing is a wish said out loud.

The ceremony behind it is still in daily use. You bend and touch an elder's feet, and what comes back is ఆశీర్వాదం — a hand on the head — at a birthday, before an examination, at a wedding, and at every departure.

Notice *vāda* sitting there. It is the same piece inside ధన్యవాదములు, “utterances of 'worthy'”. Twice now this language has counted a thing said as a thing given.

What you've built

Four courtesy words, and two of them are utterances by name.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *āśīrvādam*
- it once more, slowly
- *āśīrvādam*, then *dhanyavādamulu*, and name the piece they share

Before you move on

What does ఆశీర్వాదం mean? (“a blessing”.) Say it once more.

42.48 దండం (*daṇḍam*) — a salutation, “my respects”

Before the new one: what did *āśīrvādam* mean?

You'll want to know: దండం

దండం (*daṇḍam*) — “a salutation, “my respects””.

దండం is what you say with the palms together — my respects — offered to an elder, a temple, a photograph on the wall. Children are taught to say it long before anyone explains it.

Sanskrit *daṇḍa* is a staff, a stick. The full form of the gesture, *daṇḍa-praṇāma*, is the prostration where the body lies down straight as a staff. Telugu kept the word and let the body straighten most of the way up.

Hold on to దండ; it comes back in the next chapter carrying flowers.

What you've built

Five courtesy words: కృతజ్ఞత, మేలు, గౌరవం, ఆశీర్వాదం, దండం. Thanks, a good turn, respect, a blessing, and the greeting you make with your hands.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *daṇḍam*
- it once more, slowly
- *daṇḍam*, then *namaskāram*, and say which one you would give a grandparent

Before you move on

What does దండం mean? (“a salutation, “my respects”.”) Say it once more.

Welcoming a Guest

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the five things a Telugu welcome puts between the street and the guest, from the mark on the ground to the garland.

Complete TE-C52-garland and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.49 తలుపు (talupu) — a door

Before the last run: what did *daṇḍam* mean, and what did *gauravam* mean?

You'll want to know: తలుపు

తలుపు (*talupu*) — “a door”.

తలుపు is the leaf: the panel that swings and shuts. The opening it fills is a different word — వాకిలి in everyday speech, ద్వారం in the formal Sanskrit register. Telugu keeps the hole and the thing that fills it apart, which English manages only when it is being careful.

తలుపు is inherited. That ద్వారం sits beside it doing no daily work is the usual arrangement here: the old word carries the load, the borrowed one keeps the ceremony.

What you've built

The first of five things standing between the street and a guest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *talupu*
- it once more, slowly
- *talupu*, then *ikkada talupu undi* — “there is a door here”

Before you move on

What does తలుపు mean? (“a door”.) Say it once more.

42.50 కుర్చీ (kurcī) — a chair

Before the new one: what did *talupu* mean?

You’ll want to know: కుర్చీ

కుర్చీ (*kurcī*) — “a chair”.

Arabic *kursī* is a seat, a throne — the word standing in the Qur’ān’s Throne Verse. Persian took it, Urdu carried it across the Deccan, and Telugu has కుర్చీ.

The word came because the thing came. A house welcoming a guest before the chair arrived offered a పీట, a low wooden plank set on the floor, and many still do. Borrowed furniture brings borrowed nouns with it.

One trap: కుర్చీ and కూర్చో, “sit”, look like a pair and are not. The verb is inherited, the noun is Arabic, and the resemblance is an accident. Sound alone never proves a relation.

What you’ve built

Two: a door and a chair.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kurcī*
- it once more, slowly
- *kurcī*, then *kūrcō*, and say why the two are not related

Before you move on

What does కుర్చీ mean? (“a chair”.) Say it once more.

42.51 ముగ్గు (muggu) — the rice-flour design drawn at the doorstep

Before the new one: what did *kurci* mean?

You’ll want to know: ముగ్గు

ముగ్గు (*muggu*) — “the rice-flour design drawn at the doorstep”.

ముగ్గు is the design put on the ground outside the door, in rice flour, before the sun is up. It is walked over all day and drawn again the next morning.

The flour is the point. It is laid where ants and birds will find it, so the welcome begins by feeding something smaller than a guest. Tamil calls the same act கோலம், Kannada ರಂಗೋಲಿ. The word is local; the practice is not.

What you’ve built

Three: the door, the chair, and the mark on the ground in front of both.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *muggu*
- it once more, slowly
- *muggu*, then *talupu*, and say which one is outside the other

Before you move on

What does ముగ్గు mean? (“the rice-flour design drawn at the doorstep”.) Say it once more.

42.52 పువ్వు (puvvu) — a flower

Before the new one: what did *muggu* mean?

You'll want to know: పువ్వు

పువ్వు (*puvvu*) — “a flower”.

Proto-Dravidian ***pū**, and the family kept it: Tamil பூ, Malayalam പൂ, Kannada ಹೂವು.

There is that *p-* to *h-* once more on the Kannada side — the third time in this book, after పాలు beside హాలు and పండు beside ಹಣ್ಣು. A sound law you have watched work three times has stopped being a claim; it is a pattern you can predict with, and predicting is the only test a sound law ever gets.

The plural stem is పూల-, which is about to matter.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *puvvu*
- it once more, slowly
- *puvvu*, then *paṇḍu*, and say what the two share at the front

Before you move on

What does పువ్వు mean? (“a flower”.) Say it once more.

42.53 పూలదండ (pūladanḍa) — a flower garland

Before the new one: what did *puvvu* mean?

You'll want to know: పూలదండ

పూలదండ (*pūladanḍa*) — “a flower garland”.

పూల, flowers, and దండ — the same దండ that gave you దండం, the salutation, one chapter back. Sanskrit *daṇḍa* is a staff, and by extension a row. A పూలదండ is a row of flowers, strung.

So the greeting and the garland are one word used twice. You say దండం with your hands; you put పూలదండ round a neck. Both of them come from a straight line.

And that closes the welcome: the ముగ్గు on the ground, the తలుపు opened, the కుర్చీ offered, and a పూలదండ of పువ్వులు for the అతిథి who sent no word ahead.

What you've built

Five: తలుపు, కుర్చీ, ముగ్గు, పువ్వు, పూలదండ. A guest can now be met at the door and seated.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pūladanḍa*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then say *namaskāraṁ* as you would at the door to an *atithi*

Before you move on

What does పూలదండ mean? (“a flower garland”.) Say it once more.

The Sky

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five things overhead in Telugu, and say which of them Telugu borrowed and which it has always had.

Complete TE-C53-cloud and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.54 ఆకాశం (ākāśam) — the sky

Before the new one: what did *pūladanḍa* mean?

You'll want to know: ఆకాశం

ఆకాశం (ākāśam) — “the sky”.

ఆకాశం came from Sanskrit *ākāśa*, built on a piece meaning “to shine, to be seen”. So the sky is named for being the open, lit place where a thing can be visible at all, rather than for being a lid over the world.

Telugu also holds an inherited word for the same overhead space, నింరి, which owes Sanskrit nothing. The two sit side by side: ఆకాశం does the ordinary work and turns up in newspapers and weather talk, while నింరి keeps to songs and poetry. A borrowed word taking the daily shift and leaving the old one the ceremony is an arrangement you have watched before, with the door.

ākāśa travelled, too. Traders carried it east, and Malay and Indonesian still say *angkasa* for the sky.

What you've built

The space that the rest of this chapter hangs in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ākāśam*
- it once more, slowly
- *ākāśam*, then *namaskāram*, as you would greet somebody outdoors

Before you move on

What does ఆకాశం mean? (“the sky”.) Say it once more.

42.55 సూర్యుడు (sūryuḍu) — the sun

Before the new one: what did *ākāśam* mean?

You’ll want to know: సూర్యుడు

సూర్యుడు (*sūryuḍu*) — “the sun”.

Sanskrit *sūrya* is the sun. Telugu took the word and hung -డు on the end, the ending it puts on a man’s name and on the words for men doing work — the same -డు that stands at the end of రైతు’s formal cousin and of వైద్యుడు.

That ending is doing something real here. సూర్యుడు is the sun as a person: the one who drives, who is greeted, who is asked for things. Telugu has a plainer inherited word for the thing in the sky, పొద్దు, which you already have, and పొద్దు is what you use to say the sun came up.

So one language keeps two suns: పొద్దు for the light, సూర్యుడు for the god.

What you’ve built

Two: the sky, and the brightest thing in it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sūryuḍu*
- it once more, slowly
- *sūryuḍu*, then *poddu*, and say which one of them can be prayed to

Before you move on

What does సూర్యుడు mean? (“the sun”.) Say it once more.

42.56 చంద్రుడు (candruḍu) — the moon

Before the new one: what did *sūryuḍu* mean?

You’ll want to know: చంద్రుడు

చంద్రుడు (*candruḍu*) — “the moon”.

Sanskrit *candra* means “shining, bright”, and it carries the same -డు that సూర్యుడు carries. Two borrowed lights, and Telugu made people of both.

The inherited word here is నెల, which you already have as the word for a month. One shape for the moon and for the stretch of time it measures — the moon is the oldest calendar there is, and Telugu keeps that fact inside a single word.

candra went a long way west as well. It shares an ancestor with the Latin piece that gives English *candle* and *incandescent*: a very old root for burning white.

What you’ve built

Three, and two of them named as people.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *candruḍu*
- it once more, slowly
- *candruḍu*, then *sūryuḍu*, and say what the two share at the end

Before you move on

What does చంద్రుడు mean? (“the moon”.) Say it once more.

42.57 చుక్క (cukka) — a star; a dot

Before the new one: what did *candrudu* mean?

You'll want to know: చుక్క

చుక్క (*cukka*) — “a star; a dot”.

చుక్క is inherited, and it means a star and a dot and a drop of liquid, all with one shape. Anything small and round and separate is a చుక్క.

That is why it matters for the ముగ్గు. The design at the doorstep is laid out first as a grid of చుక్కలు, dots of rice flour set at even spacing, and the lines are then drawn around and between them. A woman who says she is putting down చుక్కలు in the morning is not talking about the sky.

The borrowed word for a star is నక్షత్రం, and it is what an astrologer uses. చుక్క is what a child points at.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cukka*
- it once more, slowly
- *cukka*, then *muggu*, and say how the two are connected on the ground

Before you move on

What does చుక్క mean? (“a star; a dot”.) Say it once more.

42.58 మబ్బు (mabbu) — a cloud

Before the new one: what did *cukka* mean?

You'll want to know: మబ్బు

మబ్బు (*mabbu*) — “a cloud”.

మబ్బు is inherited and quite plain: the grey thing between you and the సూర్యుడు.

It stretched, the way weather words do. మబ్బు also describes a dull, heavy, half-asleep feeling, and a person who is slow to catch on. English went the same way with *cloudy* and *foggy*, from opposite ends of the earth and with no contact at all. When two unrelated languages reach for the same picture, the picture is doing the work rather than the borrowing.

With that, the sky is furnished.

What you've built

Five: ఆకాశం, సూర్యుడు, చంద్రుడు, చుక్క, మబ్బు. You can now say what is overhead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mabbu*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then say which two of them end the same way

Before you move on

What does మబ్బు mean? (“a cloud”.) Say it once more.

The Tree

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a tree and its parts in Telugu, from the seed it started as to the branch at the top.

Complete TE-C54-seedling and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.59 చెట్టు (ceṭṭu) — a tree

Before the new one: what did *mabbu* mean?

You'll want to know: చెట్టు

చెట్టు (*ceṭṭu*) — “a tree”.

చెట్టు is inherited and old. The Dravidian family kept the shape but shuffled the meaning: Tamil's *ceṭi* is a bush or a shrub, a small woody thing, while Telugu raised the same word to the full-grown tree and left the bush to other words.

A meaning that moves up or down the scale like that is the commonest kind of drift there is. The word holds its place in the family; what it points at slides.

వూను is another Telugu word for a tree, older-sounding and now mostly literary. చెట్టు is what anybody says.

What you've built

The thing the rest of this chapter is made of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ceṭṭu*
- it once more, slowly
- *ceṭṭu*, then *puvvu*, and say which one grows on the other

Before you move on

What does చెట్టు mean? (“a tree”.) Say it once more.

42.60 కొమ్మ (komma) — a branch

Before the new one: what did *ceṭṭu* mean?

You’ll want to know: కొమ్మ

కొమ్మ (*komma*) — “a branch”.

కొమ్మ is the branch, the arm the చెట్టు puts out sideways.

It stands very close to కొమ్ము, the horn of an animal, and the closeness is not an accident: both are the thing that grows out and forks. A tree wearing horns is a fair description of a tree in winter.

కొమ్మ turns up in old poetry meaning a young woman, by way of the slenderness of a branch. That sense has gone quiet, but it is why the word looks odd inside a love poem.

What you’ve built

Two: the tree and what it puts out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *komma*
- it once more, slowly
- *komma*, then *ceṭṭu*, and say which is part of which

Before you move on

What does కొమ్మ mean? (“a branch”.) Say it once more.

42.61 వేరు (vēru) — a root

Before the new one: what did *komma* mean?

You’ll want to know: వేరు

వేరు (*vēru*) — “a root”.

వేరు is the root under the చెట్టు. It also means “separate, apart, other” — వేరు as an answer means “that is a different thing”.

One shape, two jobs, and they are not far apart when you think about what a root does: it is the part that is set aside, buried, kept out of the daylight and out of the reckoning.

Telugu is comfortable letting a word carry a solid thing and an abstract idea at once. You had one working two jobs a moment ago, with చుక్క.

What you’ve built

Three: what is up, what is out, and what is under.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vēru*
- it once more, slowly
- *vēru*, then *komma*, and say which end of the చెట్టు each one is at

Before you move on

What does వేరు mean? (“a root”.) Say it once more.

42.62 విత్తనం (vittanam) — a seed

Before the new one: what did *vēru* mean?

You'll want to know: విత్తనం

విత్తనం (*vittanani*) — “a seed”.

విత్తనం is the seed, and it is built on విత్తు, “to sow”. The word for the thing comes out of the word for the act, which is the ordinary direction of travel: people had been sowing for a long time before anybody needed a name for what they held.

Sanskrit's *bīja* was borrowed in as *bījam*, and it does the abstract work — the seed of an idea, the germ of a quarrel. విత్తనం stays in the sack.

The whole chapter is inside this word. A విత్తనం becomes a చెట్టు with a వేరు below and a కొమ్మ above.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vittanani*
- it once more, slowly
- *vittanani*, then *ceṭṭu*, and say which one comes first

Before you move on

What does విత్తనం mean? (“a seed”.) Say it once more.

42.63 మొక్క (mokka) — a young plant

Before the new one: what did *vittanani* mean?

You'll want to know: మొక్క

మొక్క (*mokka*) — “a young plant”.

మొక్క is what the విత్తనం becomes before it earns the name చెట్టు: a seedling, a sapling, anything small and green and rooted.

The line between మొక్క and చెట్టు is about woodiness rather than height. A tomato plant stays a మొక్క at any size, because it stays soft. A చెట్టు has bark.

Do not tie it to మొక్క, “to bow, to make a vow”, which sounds close. Telugu has a good many pairs like that, and a resemblance on its own settles nothing.

What you’ve built

Five: చెట్టు, కొమ్మ, వేరు, విత్తనం, మొక్క. A tree, its parts, and its beginning.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mokka*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then say them again as a life story, starting with the seed

Before you move on

What does మొక్క mean? (“a young plant”.) Say it once more.

River and Road

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the water, the ground and the road around a Telugu village, and ask my way with them.

Complete TE-C55-path and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.64 నది (nadi) — a river

Before the new one: what did *mokka* mean?

You'll want to know: నది

నది (*nadi*) — “a river”.

Sanskrit *nadī* is the river, and it is built on a piece meaning “to sound, to roar”. A river is named for the noise it makes, which tells you the people who named it were listening for water before they could see it.

Telugu clipped the long final vowel and says నది. The inherited Telugu word is ఏరు, a stream, and it survives in place names up and down the country long after it stopped being said on its own.

నది is the word you want when asking a stranger which way the water is.

What you've built

The first thing you would ask the way to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nadi*
- it once more, slowly
- *nadi*, then *dayacēsi*, and put the two together as a question

Before you move on

What does నది mean? (“a river”.) Say it once more.

42.65 చెరువు (ceruvu) — a village tank, a reservoir

Before the new one: what did *nadi* mean?

You’ll want to know: చెరువు

చెరువు (*ceruvu*) — “a village tank, a reservoir”.

A చెరువు is not a natural lake. It is a dug and banked tank that catches the rain and holds it through the dry months, and a great many Telugu villages were laid out around one before they were laid out around anything else.

So the word carries an argument about how the country was settled: the నది is where the water goes, the చెరువు is where it was made to stay. Kings had them dug and put their names on the bunds, and the names are still there.

Indian English calls this a “tank”, which is why the translation can sound strange until you have stood on the bund of one.

What you’ve built

Two waters: one that moves, one that was kept.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ceruvu*
- it once more, slowly
- *ceruvu*, then *nadi*, and say which one people made

Before you move on

What does చెరువు mean? (“a village tank, a reservoir”.) Say it once more.

42.66 గుట్ట (guṭṭa) — a low hill

Before the new one: what did *ceruvu* mean?

You’ll want to know: గుట్ట

గుట్ట (*guṭṭa*) — “a low hill”.

గుట్ట is inherited, and it means the small rocky rise that the Deccan is covered in — a heap of boulders rather than a peak. It also means a heap of anything: a గుట్ట of grain, a గుట్ట of clothes.

That double sense is honest about the landscape. These hills look piled rather than pushed up, and a speaker naming one is naming a pile.

The borrowed పర్వతం is the big mountain, the one in a poem. Nobody calls the rise behind their village a పర్వతం.

What you’ve built

Three: water that moves, water that stays, and ground that stands up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *guṭṭa*
- it once more, slowly
- *guṭṭa*, then *ceruvu*, and say which of the two you would climb

Before you move on

What does గుట్ట mean? (“a low hill”.) Say it once more.

42.67 గ్రామం (grāmaṁ) — a village

Before the new one: what did *guṭṭa* mean?

You'll want to know: గ్రామం

గ్రామం (*grāmam*) — “a village”.

Sanskrit *grāma* began as the word for a moving band of people, a travelling group, and settled into meaning the place they settled in. The word sat down when the people did.

Telugu's own word is *ūru*, and it is the one used in speech: it is in half the place names on the map and it is what you say to a neighbour. గ్రామం is the official register — the word on a form, in a land record, on a signboard.

So a Telugu speaker holds two villages, one for the revenue office and one for home.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *grāmam*
- it once more, slowly
- *grāmam*, then *ceruvu*, and say which one a village is built around

Before you move on

What does గ్రామం mean? (“a village”.) Say it once more.

42.68 బాట (bāṭa) — a path, a way

Before the new one: what did *grāmam* mean?

You'll want to know: బాట

బాట (*bāṭa*) — “a path, a way”.

బాట is the inherited word for a way, a track, the line worn by feet going the same way twice. దారి does much the same work; బాట is the more physical of the two, the ground itself.

It goes abstract as easily as English “path” does. బాట పట్టు is to take up a way of living, and a person can be on somebody else's బాట.

You can now ask your way properly: దయచేసి, which గ్రామం, which బాట, which side the నది is on.

What you've built

Five: నది, చెరువు, గుట్ట, గ్రామం, బాట. Enough to be given directions with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bāṭa*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then ask a stranger the way to the నది using *dayacēsi*

Before you move on

What does బాట mean? (“a path, a way”.) Say it once more.

In the House

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five ordinary things inside a Telugu house and thank somebody for handing me one.

Complete TE-C56-box and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.69 చాప (cāpa) — a mat

Before the new one: what did *bāṭa* mean?

You'll want to know: చాప

చాప (cāpa) — “a mat”.

A చాప is woven from palm leaf or reed, rolled up against a wall by day and unrolled to sit or sleep on.

It belongs beside the కుర్చీ you already have. Where the chair is a borrowed thing with a borrowed name, the చాప is old and the word is inherited, and a house that has both will often put the చాప down for the people who are comfortable on the floor and keep the కుర్చీ for the guest who is not.

Offering somebody a చాప is an invitation to stay a while. It is a slower gesture than pointing at a chair.

What you've built

The first thing a floor gets.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cāpa*
- it once more, slowly
- *cāpa*, then *kurcī*, and say which of the two gets rolled up

Before you move on

What does చాప mean? (“a mat”.) Say it once more.

42.70 బుట్ట (buṭṭa) — a basket

Before the new one: what did *cāpa* mean?

You’ll want to know: బుట్ట

బుట్ట (*buṭṭa*) — “a basket”.

బుట్ట is inherited: the woven basket that carries vegetables home, holds flowers for the morning, and sits on a head on the way to market.

Weaving words tend to be old, and they tend to stay put while the trade words move around them. A బుట్ట and a చాప come off the same hands and the same palm leaf, which is why the two words feel like family even though they are not.

పూల బుట్ట is the flower basket — పువ్వు’s పూల- shape doing its work again.

What you’ve built

Two: something to sit on, something to carry with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *buṭṭa*
- it once more, slowly
- *buṭṭa*, then *cāpa*, and say what the two are made of

Before you move on

What does బుట్ట mean? (“a basket”.) Say it once more.

42.71 కత్తి (katti) — a knife

Before the new one: what did *buṭṭa* mean?

You’ll want to know: కత్తి

కత్తి (*katti*) — “a knife”.

కత్తి is the knife and, in older use, the sword. Size did not divide them; the blade did.

It is inherited, and it is spread right across the family — Tamil, Kannada and Malayalam all have a word of the same shape for a cutting blade. Tools that a household could make for itself keep their names for a very long time.

కత్తి also does the work English gives to “sharp” when talking about people: కత్తిలాంటి is knife-like, said of somebody quick.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *katti*
- it once more, slowly
- *katti*, then *buṭṭa*, and say which one you would cut a పండు with

Before you move on

What does కత్తి mean? (“a knife”.) Say it once more.

42.72 గిన్నె (ginne) — a cooking vessel, a bowl

Before the new one: what did *katti* mean?

You'll want to know: గిన్నె

గిన్నె (*ginne*) — “a cooking vessel, a bowl”.

గిన్నె is the round metal vessel that food is cooked and served in — the everyday one, brass or steel, with no lid worth mentioning.

Telugu splits its containers finely. A గిన్నె is not a కుండ, the fired clay pot, and it is not a పళ్ళెం, the flat plate. English pushes all three towards “pot” and “dish” and loses the difference between what holds heat, what holds water and what holds a meal.

When a kitchen has a name for each shape, the names are telling you which shapes the kitchen actually uses.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ginne*
- it once more, slowly
- *ginne*, then *katti*, and say which one goes on the fire

Before you move on

What does గిన్నె mean? (“a cooking vessel, a bowl”.) Say it once more.

42.73 పెట్టె (petṭe) — a box

Before the new one: what did *ginne* mean?

You'll want to know: పెట్టె

పెట్టె (*petṭe*) — “a box”.

పెట్టె comes straight out of పెట్టు, “to put”: the box is the put-place. Telugu builds a good many of its household words this way, from the thing you do to the thing you do it in.

Then the railways arrived and పెట్టె picked up a second job — a railway carriage is a పెట్టె, a box that people are put in. A word for putting things away ended up on the side of a train.

The house is furnished now: a చాప on the floor, a బుట్ట by the door, a కత్తి and a గిన్నె in the kitchen, and a పెట్టె for what is not needed today.

What you've built

Five: చాప, బుట్ట, కత్తి, గిన్నె, పెట్టె. You can name what a room holds, and say ధన్యవాదాలు when one is handed to you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pette*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then take one from somebody and say *dhanyavādālu*

Before you move on

What does పెట్టె mean? (“a box”.) Say it once more.

More of the Body

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five more parts of the body in Telugu and say which one hurts.

Complete TE-C57-bone and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.74 మెడ (meḍa) — the neck

Before the new one: what did *peṭṭe* mean?

You'll want to know: మెడ

మెడ (*meḍa*) — “the neck”.

మెడ is inherited and short, which is what you expect of a body word: the parts people point at got their names early and kept them.

It is where a పూలదండ goes, so you already had the place before you had the word.

మెడ వంచు, to bend the neck, is to give in. The gesture and the phrase mean the same thing in a great many languages, because the gesture came first.

What you've built

The place a garland already went.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *meḍa*

- it once more, slowly
- *meḍa*, then *pūladanḍa*, and put one on the other

Before you move on

What does మెడ mean? (“the neck”.) Say it once more.

42.75 వీపు (vīpu) — the back

Before the new one: what did *meḍa* mean?

You’ll want to know: వీపు

వీపు (*vīpu*) — “the back”.

వీపు is the back — the flat of it, the part you carry a load on and a child rides on.

It sits with the other inherited body words you have: కాలు, పన్ను, వేలు, and now మెడ above it. The head is a different matter, since Telugu leans on borrowed words in the higher registers there, but the trunk and the limbs are almost entirely old stock.

That pattern is worth noticing. The words a language borrows tend to be for things it acquired; the body was not acquired.

What you’ve built

Two more, both of them old.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vīpu*
- it once more, slowly
- *vīpu*, then *meḍa*, and say which is above the other

Before you move on

What does వీపు mean? (“the back”.) Say it once more.

42.76 పెదవి (pedavi) — a lip

Before the new one: what did *vīpu* mean?

You’ll want to know: పెదవి

పెదవి (*pedavi*) — “a lip”.

పెదవి is the lip. Telugu keeps it separate from నోరు, the mouth as an opening, which you already have: the పెదవి is the rim, the నోరు is the hole.

పెదవి విరుచు — to twist the lip — is the Telugu way of saying somebody sneered. The face does the talking, and the language just reports it.

It is the part that shapes the sounds you have been making all along. Every ప in this book has been made with two పెదవులు.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pedavi*
- it once more, slowly
- *pedavi*, then say *puvvi* slowly and notice what your పెదవులు do at the start

Before you move on

What does పెదవి mean? (“a lip”.) Say it once more.

42.77 గోరు (gōru) — a fingernail, a claw

Before the new one: what did *pedavi* mean?

You’ll want to know: గోరు

గోరు (*gōru*) — “a fingernail, a claw”.

గోరు is the nail on a finger and the claw on an animal, with no line drawn between them. One word for the hard thing at the end of the digit, whoever it belongs to.

It goes on the end of వేలు, which you already have. వేలి గోరు is the fingernail said in full, when the plain word would be unclear.

గోరువెచ్చని, “nail-warm”, is the Telugu word for lukewarm water — the temperature you test by dipping a fingertip. A measurement made with the body, before there were thermometers.

What you’ve built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *gōru*
- it once more, slowly
- *gōru*, then *vēlu*, and say which one grows out of the other

Before you move on

What does గోరు mean? (“a fingernail, a claw”.) Say it once more.

42.78 ఎముక (emuka) — a bone

Before the new one: what did *gōru* mean?

You’ll want to know: ఎముక

ఎముక (*emuka*) — “a bone”.

ఎముక is the bone, inherited, and it covers the whole family of them.

It carries the same weight English gives it: ఎముకలు విరిగేలా, “until the bones break”, is how you describe work that took everything a body had. The bone stands for the last thing left when the rest is gone.

That closes the body words. మెడ, వీపు, పెదవి, గోరు and ఎముక join కాలు, పన్ను, వేలు and the rest, and between them you can tell a doctor where it hurts.

What you've built

Five: మెడ, వీపు, పెదవి, గోరు, ఎముక. Enough to answer a వైద్యుడు with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *emuka*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then point at your మెడ and say *nāku noppi*

Before you move on

What does ఎముక mean? (“a bone”.) Say it once more.

More Short Replies

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say how much I want, refuse politely, and close a conversation in Telugu.

Complete TE-C58-thats-all and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.79 కొంచెం (koñcem) — a little, a bit

Before the new one: what did *emuka* mean?

You'll want to know: కొంచెం

కొంచెం (*koñcem*) — “a little, a bit”.

కొంచెం is “a little”, and it does far more work in Telugu than its size suggests. It softens whatever comes after it.

Ask for something plainly and you are demanding; put కొంచెం in front and you are asking. కొంచెం నీళ్లు is a request for water that leaves the other person room. The word is a quantity in the dictionary and a manner in the mouth.

Telugu shares this habit with a good many languages. English does it with “just” and “a bit”, and both of those have stopped measuring anything too.

What you've built

A word that makes the next one polite.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *koñcem*
- it once more, slowly
- *koñcem*, then *koñcem pālu*, and hear how much softer it is than *pālu* alone

Before you move on

What does కొంచెం mean? (“a little, a bit”.) Say it once more.

42.80 ఎక్కువ (ekkuva) — more, a great deal

Before the new one: what did *koñcem* mean?

You’ll want to know: ఎక్కువ

ఎక్కువ (*ekkuva*) — “more, a great deal”.

ఎక్కువ is built on ఎక్కు, “to climb, to go up”. The quantity is a movement: more is what has gone up.

Set it against కొంచెం, which you had a moment ago, and you have the two ends of a plate of food. కొంచెం is what you say when you would like the serving to stop; ఎక్కువ is what you say when it was too much.

It doubles as “too much” without changing shape, so tone and face carry the difference. ఎక్కువ మాట్లాడు can be praise or a complaint depending on how it is said.

What you’ve built

Two: a little, and a lot.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ekkuva*
- it once more, slowly
- *ekkuva*, then *koñcem*, and say them as a pair

Before you move on

What does ఎక్కువ mean? (“more, a great deal”.) Say it once more.

42.81 తక్కువ (takkuva) — less, too little

Before the new one: what did *ekkuva* mean?

You’ll want to know: తక్కువ

తక్కువ (*takkuva*) — “less, too little”.

తక్కువ is built on తక్కు, “to fall short”, exactly the way ఎక్కువ is built on climbing. Two words, one shape of construction, opposite directions.

A matched pair like this is worth holding on to, because it lets you guess. Once the -కువ ending on both has registered, you can meet a Telugu word for the first time and have some idea what it is doing.

తక్కువ చేసి మాట్లాడు, to speak somebody less, is to belittle them. The arithmetic goes straight into the manners.

What you’ve built

Three, and two of them are a pair.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *takkuva*
- it once more, slowly
- *takkuva*, then *ekkuva*, and say which one climbs

Before you move on

What does తక్కువ mean? (“less, too little”.) Say it once more.

42.82 వద్దు (vaddu) — no, I don’t want it

Before the new one: what did *takkuva* mean?

You'll want to know: వద్దు

వద్దు (*vaddu*) — “no, I don’t want it”.

వద్దు is the refusal of a thing offered. It is not the same as కాదు, which denies that something is so; వద్దు turns down an offer.

It answers కావాలి, “I want it”, and the two of them run every meal in a Telugu house. A hand over the plate and వద్దు is a complete sentence.

It softens the moment you put కొంచెం’s cousin in front of it, or the -అండి ending on the end: వద్దండి is the same refusal with the door left open.

What you’ve built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vaddu*
- it once more, slowly
- *vaddu*, then *vaddaṇḍi*, and say which one you would use with a stranger

Before you move on

What does వద్దు mean? (“no, I don’t want it”.) Say it once more.

42.83 అంతే (antē) — that’s all; that’s just it

Before the new one: what did *vaddu* mean?

You'll want to know: అంతే

అంతే (*antē*) — “that’s all; that’s just it”.

అంతే is అంత, “that much”, with a small -ఏ on the end that means “just, exactly”. So the word says “exactly that much” — and it ends a list, a story or an argument.

It has a second life as agreement. Somebody explains why a thing went wrong and you say అంతే: that is precisely it, nothing further to add. The same word closes a sale and closes a discussion.

It is a good word to leave a chapter on. కొంచెం, ఎక్కువ, తక్కువ, వద్దు — and then అంతే.

What you've built

Five: కొంచెం, ఎక్కువ, తక్కువ, వద్దు, అంతే. You can now say how much, and when to stop.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *antē*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then refuse a second helping with *vaddu*, *antē*

Before you move on

What does అంతే mean? (“that’s all; that’s just it”.) Say it once more.

Weather and Ground

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the weather and what is underfoot in Telugu, and use it as a reason to go home.

Complete TE-C59-fire and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.84 గాలి (gāli) — wind, air

Before the new one: what did *antē* mean?

You'll want to know: గాలి

గాలి (gāli) — “wind, air”.

గాలి is inherited, and it covers both the wind that blows and the air that is simply there. Telugu does not split them.

It reaches further than weather. గాలి is breath, and it is rumour — గాలి వార్త is a story with nothing holding it up, blown in from somewhere. Air, breath and hearsay under one word is a chain a great many languages make, and it usually starts with breathing.

A గాలి getting up in the evening is the ordinary reason given for cutting a visit short.

What you've built

The first reason to start saying goodbye.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *gāli*
- it once more, slowly
- *gāli*, then *vellostānu*, and use the one as a reason for the other

Before you move on

What does గాలి mean? (“wind, air”.) Say it once more.

42.85 మంచు (mañcu) — mist, dew, snow

Before the new one: what did *gāli* mean?

You’ll want to know: మంచు

మంచు (*mañcu*) — “mist, dew, snow”.

మంచు is the cold wet thing in the air: mist on a winter morning, dew on the ground, and snow where there is any. One word for all three states, which suits a country that meets the third of them rarely.

This is worth sitting with. A language draws its lines where its speakers need them. Telugu splits its cooking vessels three ways and lumps mist, dew and snow together; a language spoken where snow falls would do the opposite.

మంచు కురుస్తోంది is “it is misting” on the coast and “it is snowing” in the hills, with no change to the word.

What you’ve built

Two: what moves, and what settles.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mañcu*
- it once more, slowly
- *mañcu*, then *gāli*, and say which of the two you can see

Before you move on

What does మంచు mean? (“mist, dew, snow”.) Say it once more.

42.86 ఇసుక (isuka) — sand

Before the new one: what did *mañcu* mean?

You’ll want to know: ఇసుక

ఇసుక (*isuka*) — “sand”.

ఇసుక is inherited and unremarkable, and that is the point: it is the ground beside every నది in the Telugu country.

The sand of a riverbed is where cattle are watered, where lorries come at night to dig, and where a village argument about who owns the river tends to start. A plain word can carry a lot of local weather.

ఇసుకలో నీళ్ళు, water in sand, is what you say about effort that soaks away.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *isuka*
- it once more, slowly
- *isuka*, then *nadi*, and say where you would find one beside the other

Before you move on

What does ఇసుక mean? (“sand”.) Say it once more.

42.87 బురద (burada) — mud

Before the new one: what did *isuka* mean?

You'll want to know: బురద

బురద (*burada*) — “mud”.

బురద is mud — what ఇసుక becomes when the rain has been at it.

It does the same second job that mud does in English. బురద చల్లు, to throw mud, is to slander somebody, and the picture is exact enough that you can guess the phrase before you are told it.

బురద is also the honest reason a visit ends early in the wet months. The బాట between the గ్రామం and the నది turns to it.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *burada*
- it once more, slowly
- *burada*, then *isuka*, and say what turns one into the other

Before you move on

What does బురద mean? (“mud”.) Say it once more.

42.88 నిప్పు (nippu) — fire, a live coal

Before the new one: what did *burada* mean?

You'll want to know: నిప్పు

నిప్పు (*nippu*) — “fire, a live coal”.

నిప్పు is inherited, and it is the fire you can point at: the live coal, the burning thing in the hearth. అగ్ని, borrowed from Sanskrit, is fire as an idea and as a god, the one that carries offerings.

So Telugu keeps a working fire and a ceremonial one, in the same way it keeps a పొద్దు and a సూర్యుడు. That split has turned up so often in these chapters that you can start expecting it: the old word does the work, the borrowed one does the ceremony.

నిప్పు is what a house is banked down around at night, and putting it out is the last thing done before sleep. A good place to say వెళ్ళొస్తాను.

What you've built

Five: గాలి, మంచు, ఇసుక, బురద, నిప్పు. Weather enough to take your leave on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nippu*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then say *gāli ekkuva*, and take your leave with *veḷḷostānu*

Before you move on

What does నిప్పు mean? (“fire, a live coal”.) Say it once more.